

have not been considered while computing number of Equity Shares acquired.

* Computed based on the allotment/ acquisition of Equity Shares excluding Equity Shares acquired pursuant to the bonus issue of Equity Shares.

Notes:

1. Effect of sub-division and bonus issuance has been given while calculating weighted average cost of acquisition and effect of sub-division has been given while calculating the range of acquisition price

18. The number of BRLMs associated with the Offer have handled 76 public issues in the past three years, out of which 18 issues have closed below the issue price on the listing date

Name of BRLMs	Total Public Issues	Issues closed below IPO price on the day of listing
Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited*	8	3
Axis Capital Limited*	24	5
Goldman Sachs (India) Securities Private Limited*	0	0
Jefferies India Private Limited*	5	0
J.P. Morgan India Private Limited*	1	0
UBS Securities India Private Limited*	1	0
DBS Bank India Limited**	0	0
Common issues of above BRLMs	39	9
Total	76	18

* Issues handled where there were no common BRLMs

** DBS Bank India Limited is deemed to be an "associate" of Imperius Healthcare Investments Pte. Ltd. (one of our Promoters and Selling Shareholders) in terms of Regulation 21A of SEBI Merchant Bankers Regulations and has not been taken to be associated only with respect to the marketing of the Offer in compliance with Regulation 21A of SEBI Merchant Bankers Regulations. Further, DBS Bank India Limited has signed the due diligence certificate and has been disclosed as a Book Running Lead Manager in the Red Herring Prospectus.

ANS Pvt Limited, Asst. C. Mehta Investment Intermediates Ltd, Axis Securities Limited, Centrum Fivestore Ltd, G Raj & Co. (Consultants) Limited, HDFC Securities Limited, ICICI Securities Limited, IDBI Capital Markets & Securities Limited, Innovate Securities Pvt Limited, Javeri Securities, JM Financial Services Limited, Jobangpala Facs Services Pvt Limited, Kapatkar Multipier Limited, Keynote Capital Limited, KAMC Capital Market Services Limited, Lakshminthre Investment & Securities Pvt Ltd, LKP Securities Limited, Marwad Shars & Franco, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Pvt, Motilal Oswal Securities Limited, Nirmal Bang Securities Pvt. Ltd., Navana Health and Investment Limited (Edelweiss Broking Limited), Patel Wealth Advisors Pvt Limited, Prabubhai Lilashar Pvt Ltd, Praveen Ratilal Shree & Stock Brokers Limited, PR Equity Brokers Pvt Limited, SBICAP Securities Limited, Sharekhani Ltd, SMC Global Securities Ltd, Tanna Financial Services, YES Securities (India) Ltd.

ESCRROW COLLECTION BANK(s): Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited. **(REFUND BANK(s):** Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited.

PUBLIC OFFER ACCOUNT BANK(s): Axis Bank Limited. **(SPONSOR BANKS(s):** Axis Bank Limited and Kotak Mahindra Bank Limited.

UPI: UPI Bidders can also bid through UPI Mechanism.

All capitalised terms used herein and not specifically defined shall have the same meaning as ascribed to them in the RHP.

For Manipal Health Enterprises Limited
On behalf of the Board of Directors
Sd/-
Satish Kulkarni Ramamnoorthy
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place: Bengaluru
Date: July 28, 2026

filed a RHP dated July 23, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs i.e., Kotak Mahindra and Jeefferies India Private Limited at www.jeefferies.com, JP Morgan India Private Limited at www.jpmorg.com, USBS Securities India Private Limited at www.usbs.com/in/directorsand and a manipalshoes.in. Any potential investor should note that investment in Equity shares involves a high degree of risk and should refer to the RHP including the section titled "Risk Factors" and the U.S. Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any state securities laws in the United States and unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold within the United States only to "qualified institutional buyers", as defined in Rule "144A" under the U.S. Securities Act, as defined in, and in compliance with Regulation S ("Regulation S") under the U.S. Securities Act, and in accordance with the applicable laws of the jurisdictions where such offers are made.

WEDNESDAY, JULY 29, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

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Happening today

● **THE SC WILL HEAR** an application alleging that the alternate site identified by the MP government for offering Friday namaz was located too far from the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maulla Mosque complex in Dhar.

● **BJP WILL LAUNCH** a nationwide 'Samrasta Sankalp Abhiyan' (campaign for social harmony and resolve) to mark the 650th birth anniversary of the mystic poet-saint Guru Ravidas.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Gen Z was handled by a police, constantly reforming since the ancient Gen X era?



THE BIG PICTURE



A SON'S 'REVENGE' AND THE LONG ROAD HOME
PAGE 13

NATION



PANJAB UNIVERSITY PHD SCHOLAR ELECTROCUTED, DIES, STUDENTS PROTEST
PAGE 7

CJI-LED BENCH ASKS CENTRE, STATES TO RESPOND, DIRECTS PRESERVATION OF FOOTAGE

Petitions flag police 'excesses', SC weighs independent probe option

Orders release of detained minors, no coercive action against students

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 28

UNDERLINING THE need to fix accountability, the Supreme Court Tuesday considered setting up a Special Investigation Team for a "completely independent, transparent, fair probe" into allegations of police excesses on those protesting against exam paper leaks in Delhi and other states.

Ordering the release of "children under the age of 18, who have been reported to be arrested or detained in connection with the ongoing protests and who do not possess any criminal antecedents", the bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joydeep Bagchi and Justice V Mohana said, "The NCT of Delhi and other States may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered; however, no coercive measures shall be taken against the protesting students. Such protection, nonetheless, shall not be extended to the persons with criminal antecedents."

The bench said it would take a call on an independent probe after examining the responses of the Centre and states. As an interim measure, it directed that CCTV, drone and body cam footage, wireless communication and PCR notes related to the protest be preserved.

The petitioners have demanded that the probe committee should be headed by a former Chief Justice of India. The bench, however, said "prior to issuing any such order based on a tentative opinion, we consider it appropriate, in the interest of justice, to afford a brief period to the NCT of Delhi and the Union of India to submit their respective versions through an affidavit accompanied by relevant material. Likewise, we find it necessary to grant short hearings to the various States where similar acts of authorities" may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered."

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with Union Ministers Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah and J P Nadda at the NDA Parliamentary Party meeting, Tuesday. PTI

Change angle of heart, not camera, says Priyanka; NDA hails new Bill

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 28

AS THE BJP-led NDA described the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 as a "visionary step towards safeguarding the future" of the youth, Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra led the Opposition attack Tuesday, slamming the government over the police crackdown on student protesters in Delhi



Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in Lok Sabha, Tuesday. ANI

and other places. Participating in the Lok Sabha debate on the Bill that has provisions for stringent punishment to those involved in exam paper leaks, Vadra targeted the Prime Minister, saying he "will have to change the angle of his heart rather than that of the camera" if he wants to win over the Gen Z.

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM video briefly blocked, Meta's global officials get summons from Centre

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 28

THE MINISTRY of Electronics and IT (MeitY) has summoned Meta's global policy heads after a video posted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi last week, in which he had promised strict measures against paper leaks, was briefly withheld by Facebook in India, sources said.

The ministry also intends to discuss Meta's compliance with India's technology-focused laws, and deepfakes on its various social media platforms. The summons are understood to have been sent via email to Meta's global affairs president, Joel Kaplan, and Instagram's chief, Adam Mosseri. A Meta spokesperson said the PM's video was removed "in error" and has since been restored. Queries sent to the IT Ministry did not elicit any response.

"We have been having various meetings with Meta's

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CJP WARNS OF FRESH STIR IF CASES NOT WITHDRAWN

After Assam and Bihar, Bengal and Maharashtra say 'no coercive action'

Shubhangi Khapre, Mohamed Thaver, Sweety Kumari & Shaju Philip
Mumbai, Kolkata, Thiruvananthapuram, July 28

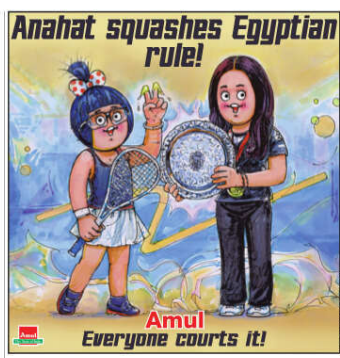
AFTER THE Supreme Court ordered the release of minors "arrested or detained" in connection with recent student protests, while saying the authorities "may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered"

vestigation of the FIRs registered", BJP-ruled Maharashtra and West Bengal took first steps on the cases lodged by them. Expressing "alarm" over the Supreme Court order that allowed the FIRs to stay, the Coochbehar Janta Party warned that it may restart its protest if cases were not withdrawn.

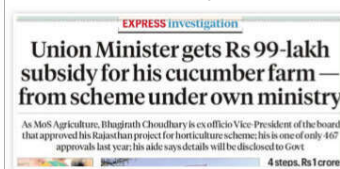
On Monday, Assam and Bihar had announced withdrawal of FIRs connected with the

protests. The Maharashtra government, which had resisted criticism over police action in the NEET protests that were largely peaceful in the state, began the process to withdraw the cases Tuesday. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, who also holds the Home portfolio, directed the Home Department to do the same, while asking police

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Agriculture MoS returns Rs 99-lakh subsidy availed from own ministry scheme



The Indian Express report published on June 27

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 28

A MONTH after *The Indian Express* reported that Union MoS for Agriculture Bhagirath Choudhary had availed a Rs 99-lakh subsidy for his cucumber farm through a scheme under his own ministry, the Government told Lok Sabha on Tuesday that the Minister has repaid the amount.

In a written reply to a question by TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee, Ramnath Thakur, who is also an MoS in the Ministry, said, "Shri Bhagirath Choudhary has communicated that he has repaid the subsidy to the bank concerned under the scheme. The concerned bank has been directed to return the subsidy amount to NHB (National Horticulture Board)".

Thakur also informed the House that apart from Bhagi-

rath Choudhary, Lumbaram Choudhary, BJP MP from Jalore in Rajasthan, had also received financial assistance under the NHB scheme during the past five years.

The *Indian Express* reported on June 27 that Bhagirath Choudhary's farm, spread across 16,592 square metres, was one of the 467 projects approved by the NHB in 2025 under the scheme, "Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops".

The NHB, an autonomous organisation under the administrative control of Choudhary's Ministry, administers the subsidy scheme to promote "commercial farming" — farming on a large scale for profit — of select vegetables and flowers under Mission for Integrated

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Focus on Vijayan, 'soft on Hindutva' impression: CPM on Kerala debacle

Express News Service
Thiruvananthapuram, July 28

IN A review of this year's Assembly election in Kerala, the CPI(M) central committee said that centring the election campaign on former chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan, not putting enough emphasis on political messaging, and the "impression that we are soft towards Hindutva communal forces" were among the factors that led



Kerala ex-CM Pinarayi Vijayan

to the party's loss after a rare two consecutive terms in power. The review also specifically pointed to the decision for a

party minister to read out a statement by Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath at a Kerala government-organised event last year as "perplexing" and a "major embarrassment".

The Left Democratic Front (LDF) saw its vote share drop from 44.4% in 2021 to 37.4% this year, and the CPI(M), which leads the alliance, recorded a vote share of 21.7%, its lowest in 40 years. While the LDF won 99 of 140 seats in the last election,

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Left setback

This year's election defeat, coming after two consecutive terms in power, was a historic one for the CPI(M), which registered its lowest vote share in Kerala in 40 years. It lost bastions such as Taliparamba and Payyanur, which were once seen as impregnable fortresses of the Left. The party's loss in Kerala also marked the first time since 1977 that no state in India has a Left government.

2022 Khargone communal violence: 11 accused acquitted by court as prosecution case collapses

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 28

A MADHYA Pradesh sessions court has acquitted 11 men accused in the 2022 Khargone Ram Navami violence after the prosecution's case collapsed with eight of its 11 eyewitnesses failing to identify any of the accused and laboratory findings failing to establish the alleged use of petrol bombs or any explosive substance.

The case arose from the com-



At least 16 houses and 29 shops were demolished in Khargone, MP, a day after the Ram Navami violence on April 10, 2022. FILE

munal violence that erupted in Khargone on April 10, 2022 during Ram Navami processions.

According to the prosecution, mobs armed with stones, swords and petrol bombs attacked houses in the Bhatwadi locality between 6 pm and 9 pm, setting homes and motorcycles on fire, damaging property and allegedly trespassing into residences. One man, identified as Idris Khan, was killed in the violence.

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● SHARMILA DHANKAR WINS INDIA'S FIRST-EVER COMMONWEALTH GAMES GOLD MEDAL IN PARA ATHLETICS

CWG para gold at 40, her message to women tells a story: 'Fight back against abuse'

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 28

SHARMILA DHANKAR still remembers the day in 2012 when her then husband stripped her and threw her and their two young daughters out of their home in Ghurkawas village of Rewari in Haryana. She says her neighbours wrapped her in a quilt before her parents, Jai Lal and Santosh, took her back to their village of Chithrauli in Mahendragarh.

For Sharmila, that was the lowest of lows. On Monday night in Glasgow, the 40-year-old won India's first-ever Commonwealth

Games gold medal in para athletics — a season-best throw of 9.81m in the women's shot put F57 category for athletes with lower-limb impairment.

Soon after, she called her mother, daughters and Ajit Singh, whom she married in 2018, to celebrate the high. "My first husband stripped me. My neighbours wrapped me in a quilt. I was married at 19, he was a drug addict, and this was the abuse I got worse after my second daughter was born. As I hold this gold medal in Glasgow, my message to every woman in India is to fight back against abuse," Sharmila, who was diagnosed with

polio in one leg at the age of two, told *The Indian Express*. Her mother Santosh, visually impaired by birth, had listened to the commentary on television. "My daughter was the topper from Class 11 to Class 10. But our financial condition wasn't good, so we had to marry her off. When the abuse got bad, I told my husband we had to bring her back. This gold is Sharmila's jazba (spirit)," Santosh said.

Six years after her divorce, Sharmila's parents got her remarried to Ajit, a water pump technician. "Ajit was the one who opened my eyes to the possibility of being a para-athlete," Sharmila said. When the Haryana Road-



Gold medalist Sharmila Dhankar (left) with Shilpa K Shyla, who won bronze in the same event for athletes with lower-limb impairment. PTI

ways Workers Union called a strike in 2018, she was hired on a three-month contract as the

state's first female bus conductor, only to lose the job once the strike ended.

"My relatives called me a home-wrecker when I stayed at my parents' home. I worked for 18 days as a conductor before I lost that job too. All I asked of Ajit, when his proposal came, was that he support my daughters and me," she said.

Ajit introduced her to kabaddi first, then took her to Tula Ram Stadium in Rewari to train under Paralympian coach Tek Chand. He sent her daughters, Amul and Laxmi, into athletics too, leaving his job and taking loans to keep the training going. "Naruk se swag banana chahta tha main Sharmila aur betyon ke liye (I wanted to turn hell into heaven for Sharmila and our

daughters), I saw para sports on TV and started her off with kabaddi, then took her to Tek Chand," Ajit said.

Tek Chand, who had competed in the F57 category himself, taught her to throw standing with the support of a pole. "He made sure my basics became very strong," Sharmila said. She won her first national title, competed at the Birmingham Para CWG and finished fourth at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games. In 2023, her father died, but her mother "sold half an acre of the family's farmland" to keep her daughter's training going. "I was born without vision, but I have raised four children and have been run-

ning this house," Santosh said. Sharmila soon moved to train under coach Virender Thakur in Sonapat, rewrote her national mark with a 9.77m throw in Dubai last year, and picked up shot put gold and discus bronze at the Faza International Para Athletics meet this year.

In Glasgow, teammate Shilpa K Shyla added bronze in the same event, a rare double Indian podium. Paralympic Committee of India chief coach Satya Narayana, who trains both women, believes the best is still ahead. "It was cold here (Glasgow), so it was not easy to compete."

• CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NMC guidelines for NEET candidates with disability come 2 weeks after results

Annona Dutt
New Delhi, July 28

EVEN AS the National Medical Commission (NMC) has released guidelines to assess the eligibility of NEET candidates with disability for MBBS admissions, activists have questioned the timing of the move coming almost two weeks after the results for the medical entrance test was announced.

On Monday night, the apex regulator issued guidelines to assess whether a NEET candidate with disability is eligible, eligible with reasonable accommodations, or ineligible for admissions. It had also directed all colleges under its aegis to set up 'Enabling Units' to ensure that students with disability are able to get reasonable accommodations so that they are able to complete all course-work.

With hearings underway in the Anmol Vs Union of India case in the Supreme Court, the regulator is rushing to comply with several directions.

"This is the second time that NMC has come out with guidelines for assessing disability at the last moment, without giving the usual 30-day time for stakeholder consultation," said Dr Satendra Singh, a disability rights activist. A doctor living with disability, Dr Singh was an expert in two of the key Supreme Court cases in this regard.

While the dates for counselling for this year are yet to be announced, the interim guidelines were released just two days before the process started in 2025.

The body is yet to come up with similar assessment guidelines for post-graduate medical courses.

The new guidelines also do not mention that the assessment boards should have a doctor with disability, as recommended by the court.

A significant change this time as compared to last year's interim guidelines is that the assessment boards have been asked to record in writing the

reasons a candidate has been considered to be ineligible.

Other changes in the new guidelines are:

- The new guidelines refer to the 'disability certificates', which medical aspirants with disability had to apply for each year as 'eligibility certificate' now. "...it is intended to certify the candidate's eligibility or otherwise for admission to the MBBS course," the guidelines say.

- The number of assessment centres has been increased from 16 to 61. "For years, candidates with disability had to travel to different states to get the certificate as there were only 16 designated centres across the country. We argued that no other aspirant needs to travel for the admission process, then why should it be different for candidates with disability? Now the number of centres has been increased, though it is still not (the case) in all states," said Dr Singh. The guidelines say that "further expansion" of the number of centres is possible.

- Three, the guidelines, for the first time, mention reasonable accommodation. "Prior to declaring a candidate ineligible, the Medical Assessment Board shall examine whether reasonable accommodation, assistive technology, adaptive devices or appropriate infrastructural support would enable the candidate to successfully pursue and complete the MBBS course," the guidelines state.

- Further, it says if a candidate is still determined to be ineligible, the board has to record in writing: the nature and extent of disability, the findings of functional competency assessment, reasonable accommodations that can be considered, reasons for determining a candidate's eligibility or ineligibility, and the final recommendation of the board. Dr Singh says: "Now a person cannot be disqualified arbitrarily as the board will have to record the reason."

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Police 'excesses'

violence have occurred, as the proposed investigation will encompass inquiries into all incidents within those States as well."

It sought replies from the Centre and the governments of Delhi, Maharashtra, Bihar, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh where police cracked down on protesters who had joined the Coochrao Janta Party-led protest against exam paper leaks.

The bench was hearing petitions on alleged police excesses, the counsel for families of injured police personnel and some journalists who were allegedly attacked.

"The allegations made by the petitioners, prima facie, establish a compelling case for an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence. Such an investigation will adequately address the allegations presented by the family members of the police personnel, as well as the issues raised by the learned Solicitor General of India," it said.

With the petitioners raising the apprehension that the digital data of the protesters recorded by police may be used to harass

them, the bench asked the police to ensure that the data is preserved and not brought in the public domain for the time being.

To a query on who may have perpetrated the violence during the protests, Mehta, who appeared for the Centre and Delhi, said he was of the view that it was not the students but some "anti-social elements".

While he said the government had no objection to an independent probe, he rejected the charge of police excesses.

Mehta said that hardened criminals and undesirable elements had entered the protest site and attacked the police personnel, injuring almost 280 of them.

Senior Advocate Gopal Santharavanan, appearing for petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi, referred to alleged instances of use of pellet guns and electronic batons against the protesters and said accountability should be fixed right to the top.

The CJI pointed to the need for an independent probe. "It was initially meant to be a peaceful protest by students. Such a protest is protected by

the Constitution. Now two things happen. People who protest stop the protests and indulge in violence after entering it. Second, there are petitions on behalf of injured police.... The question is why there should not be an independent investigation?" he said.

Santharavanan said the developments also raised some legal questions, including the absence of any prohibitory order under Section 144 CrPc/163 BNSS in place in the Jantar Mantar area, the lack of name tags on police personnel and the use of policemen in civilian attire for crowd control.

He pointed out that the Supreme Court, following the Ramilla ground protests and subsequent cases, had already laid down elaborate guidelines on how to respond.

The CJI said, "The time has come that all these principles are collated and expanded." He said, "Whosoever has committed excesses, whosoever has taken law in hands, and whosoever has committed atrocities on innocent people... law must take care of them.... And for that, there needs to be a completely independent, transparent, completely fair probe to identify them.... Probe is meaningless if no responsibility is fixed."

Senior Advocate Shadan Fa-

rasat, appearing for another petitioner, said what happened to protesters in Bihar was greater than what happened in Delhi. He said although the state had decided to drop FIRs registered in connection with the protests, about 150 individuals, mostly minors, were still in custody.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for Junaid Khan, served food to protesters at Jantar Mantar, said he was picked up by police and taken to Mussoorie, and that his family members were also harassed. He also referred to a truck full of stones being brought to Jantar Mantar on the day of the Parliament march.

The CJI pointed out that the police claimed that it was brought by protesters.

Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, also appearing for a petitioner, said what was needed was an independent probe and not a departmental enquiry.

Senior Advocate N Hariharan said the Delhi High Court was seized of some similar petitions and suggested that they should be transferred to the Supreme Court.

On the question of who should head the SIT, Mehta said he would prefer if the court decided that instead of leaving it to the petitioners or respondents.

(BJP), Bansuri Swaraj (BJP) and Shrikant Shinde (Shiv Sena) were among those who spoke on the Bill.

Surya said the Modi government's model was one of turning crises into opportunities, and that the government was responding to the recent NEET crisis in a manner that would fundamentally reform the education and exam system.

Bansuri praised the Bill for speeding up investigations and setting up fast-track courts, saying it did not let the country step towards a solution.

Shinde suggested that instead of just one annual competition exam, there should be multiple exams even if admission takes place once a year. He said this would protect students from losing one year in the event of any eventuality.

NCP (SP) leader Supriya Sule urged the House to think of parents whose children were facing exam leaks. Among other Opposition leaders who participated in the debate were Congress MP K C Venugopal and Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Abhishek Banerjee.

politan Magistrate said: "There is prima facie no material... to show that any of the accused persons have a criminal background."

In Kerala, the CMO said Sa-theesan's letter had been handed over to the Home Department for further action. While Vijayan claimed that around 5,000 people had been booked across the state, police sources said the exact number of cases was not known, though most were bailable offences for unlawful assembly or gathering at public places.

Vijayan pointed out that Sa-theesan himself had joined the Congress agitation in Delhi in support of the students. "It is inappropriate that the government led by you in Kerala has filed cases."

magistrate said that the rioters had covered their faces.

The court identified several investigative lapses that further weakened the prosecution. It noted that Vaishnavi's name did not appear as an eyewitness in any of the written complaints or the FIR, despite both being lodged two days after the violence. It also found "no explanation" for the delay of two days in lodging the First Information Report.

The court observed that Vaishnavi's police statement under Section 161 CrPc was recorded 51 days after the incident, without any explanation for the delay in recording the statement of what the prosecution claimed was its most important eyewitness.

The judgment questioned how police had implicated all 11 accused in the first place. It noted that the FIR named only six accused, while five others were added later without any explanation.

The prosecution also failed to establish its allegation that petrol bombs had been used. Referring to the State Forensic Science Laboratory report, the court recorded that "no residues of inflammable petroleum hydrocarbons were detected" (petrol/diesel/kerosene) were detected" in the seized bottle fragments and burnt material.

Priyanka

Recalling her visit to a Delhi hospital to meet the mother of a girl who was critically injured in a police action on July 20, she said the woman was "displeased" with VIP visits and wanted to fight alone for her daughter.

"I want to ask the Prime Minister and Home Minister what was the need to perpetrate such atrocities on a girl. What was the need to use pellet guns and AK-47 on students? Will the Home Minister answer who gave this order - the PM or the HM? The country is asking this today," Vadra said.

She took strong objection to BJP MPs garlanding Dharmendra Pradhan in the Parliament complex after his resignation as the Union Education Minister.

On Tuesday, Lok Sabha took up the amended Bill for consideration and passage, ending a week-long logjam in Parliament.

Union Minister Jitendra Singh said the Bill was an amendment to the Public Exam-

inations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, to make the law more stringent, which has been brought to protect the interests of students and youths.

Singh said that paper leaks had happened in many states under governments of various parties and that the Modi government's 2024 law was perhaps the first to combat various exam malpractices.

He recalled past paper leaks in the Railway Recruitment Board exam in 2009. All India Bar Council has filed a petition in the AIIMS Delhi paper leak in 2012, saying that all these occurred during the tenure of the previous Congress-led UPA regime. Singh also mentioned paper leaks under state governments led by Opposition parties in states like UP, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal.

He provided details on enhancement of punishment for exam irregularities under the new Bill, the fast-track courts that have been set up, and on the deadline of two months for investigations and three months for trial.

Vadra, on the other hand,

will not be detentions, police will not do the houses of the accused and no coercive measures will be taken while the government works out the legal process for withdrawal," the official said.

He said that even as police notices to protesters were sent out, officials had maintained the investigations could not be halted until formal directions were issued.

Home Department officials said examining the legal route, and that the CM's direction alone does not automatically terminate the FIRs. "While such cases are usually withdrawn at the prosecution stage, filing closure reports is also an option," a senior official said.

Those arrested in Bengal had been accused of violence during the protests in Kolkata, with CM Suvedu Adhikari earlier warning strict action against them.

During the hearing Tuesday on their bail, the defence lawyers had urged the court to grant bail to the Home Department for further action. While Vijayan claimed that around 5,000 people had been booked across the state, police sources said the exact number of cases was not known, though most were bailable offences for unlawful assembly or gathering at public places.

Vijayan pointed out that Sa-theesan himself had joined the Congress agitation in Delhi in support of the students. "It is inappropriate that the government led by you in Kerala has filed cases."

"does not know the persons who committed the incident... because he could not see their faces, as their faces were covered with cloth." The court held that "no substantive fact against the accused persons emerges from the testimony of this witness, nor does his testimony establish the identity of the accused persons."

The judgment was equally critical of Dinesh Jain's testimony. Although he identified all 11 accused in court, the judge said that "merely because a witness identifies the accused persons does not establish their involvement in the offence." The witness specifically states that the person identified was among those who committed the crime."

The court found that Dinesh Jain admitted he had viewed the crowd from 500-600 metres away, had not seen the accused from the front, and had no personal acquaintance with them. He accepted that the rioters had covered their faces, and ultimately admitted that "he could not say who burnt the door of his house, who threw the stones, or who committed the looting."

The judge found it "not natural, satisfactory, or reliable" that someone could identify them merely by seeing them "from behind at a distance of 500-600 metres", particularly when the

Subsidy

Development of Horticulture.

The initiative offers a maximum subsidy of 50 per cent, capped at Rs 1 crore per family, of the project cost for farming capsicum, cucumber and tomato, and eight varieties of flowers, including, rose, anthurium and orchids.

In his question, TMC MP Banerjee had asked the Ministry: "Whether any serving Union Minister, Member of Parliament, or their immediate family members have received subsidy under schemes of the National Horticulture Board during the last five years and if so, the details thereof..."

Banerjee had also asked whether any conflict-of-interest or recusal policy exists for applications from public functionaries or their family members.

In his reply, Thakur stated: "The existing NHBS Scheme guidelines do not contain any specific provision regarding conflict of interest or recusal in respect of applications submitted by public functionaries or their family members."

On June 27, *The Indian Express* had also reported that the family members of Banarsi Pal Gangwar, a senior IAS officer and Animal Husbandry Secretary at the Centre, collectively claimed over Rs 1.16 crore in hor-

ticulture subsidies across five years.

Last week, Gangwar was appointed as the new Higher Education Secretary, replacing Vineet Joshi, amid the CJP-led protests triggered by the NEET-UG exam paper leak.

In the second case, which was disclosed by the Government on Tuesday, records show Rajasthan MP Lumbaram received Rs 4.20 lakh under the same subsidy scheme for growing lemons on his six-acre farm at Vadehi village in Rajasthan's Sirohi district.

Lumbaram was elected as MP in May 2024. Records show he applied for the subsidy in April 2021 but his application was approved only in December 2024, and the amount was transferred to his SBI bank account on January 15, 2025.

The total cost of the project was Rs 16.92 lakh, for which he took a loan of Rs 12.69 lakh, and availed the subsidy of Rs 4.20 lakh, the records show.

The Lok Sabha website describes Lumbaram as "agriculturist", "farmer" and "LIC agent".

Before becoming MP, Lumbaram served as a member of Zila Parishad in Sirohi from September 2021 to 2024. Earlier, he served as BJP's district president for family members of Banarsi Pal Gangwar, a senior IAS officer and Animal Husbandry Secretary at the Centre, collectively claimed over Rs 1.16 crore in hor-

PM video

India-based policy executives to convey our issues on the company's non-compliance with the Information Technology Rules, and the prevalence of deepfakes on platforms like Instagram and Facebook. But we don't think

any of our members of Banarsi Pal Gangwar, a senior IAS officer and Animal Husbandry Secretary at the Centre, collectively claimed over Rs 1.16 crore in hor-

In his video, uploaded on July 23 night amid the student protests, Modi announced that a tough new law with stricter penalties for those involved in paper leaks was on its way. The video, shot in a vertical format, was seen as an effort to communicate with the youth on social media platforms like Instagram, where short videos,

primarily in a vertical format, are popular. After the student protests ended over the weekend, the administration also asked social media platforms to remove content seen as objectionable and offensive, targeting senior leaders.

Meta, which owns popular social media platforms like Instagram, WhatsApp and Facebook, has been under the crosshairs of the government over various issues in the last few weeks.

That a significant amount of commentary and documentation surrounding the recent student protests happened on Instagram is now well documented. Before that, Instagram had drawn the government's ire over advertisements and content promoting and facilitating access to child sexual abuse material.

Earlier this month, the government also asked WhatsApp not to roll out its username feature, citing concerns of impersonation and fraud.

CWG

Sharmila showed this is the start of a dominating phase. She's 40, but the way she trains, she can carry on for another four or five years," he said.

Sharmila is not done, either. "I started competing at 33. I

CPM loss

this year, it could only muster 35. The CPI(M) saw its seats fall from 64 to 26. The party's central committee on Tuesday published a report on its dismal performance.

"The focus of the campaign on development and welfare, without putting politics to the fore, was not effective. We should never forget that unless we integrate development and welfare policies with a political campaign against neoliberal and corporate-communal policies, we cannot expect the people to support us," the report said.

It suggested that CPM should be revitalised and the party should reconnect with its base through sustained struggles on people's issues. To regain its support base, the review said the party should focus on its strengths, accept mistakes and rectify them. "It is only by taking up the livelihood problems of the people and leading the struggles against the attacks launched by the UDF (Congress-led United Democratic Front) and BJP governments on the tolling masses that we can regain the trust of the base and win back people's support," it said.

Regarding the selection of candidates, including CPI(M) strongholds of Taliparamba and Ponnayannur, where rebels won with Congress support, the review said, "The top leadership of the state committee, who were involved in these decisions, failed to assess the adverse impact of such decisions and react immediately to address these issues. So, the main responsibility related to the choice of candidates in certain constituencies and the issue of not having

want to see both my daughters qualify for the Games too... Anuj in javelin, Laxmi in long jump," she says.

Back home, meanwhile, the daughters Anuj (16) and Laxmi (14) were busy bursting crackers on the occasion. "Annu has fired a lot, especially after I was born. But she never stopped pushing us," Laxmi said.

enough women, minorities or youth cannot be put on the district committees alone. The state leadership should own up to this responsibility."

Parliamentary opportunism has emerged as a trend within the party, the report said, adding, "The defeat of party candidates in the three traditional bases of the party shows the gap that has developed between the leadership and the rank and file, and the results are not effective. We should never forget that unless we integrate development and welfare policies with a political campaign against neoliberal and corporate-communal policies, we cannot expect the people to support us," the report said.

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the resulting loss to the campaign having been centred around Vijayan, the report said. "A narrative was prevalent that the entire campaign revolved around one person, Vijayan, who led the government with efficiency. By personalising the campaign and centring it around Vijayan, we unwittingly gave an opportunity to the UDF to conduct a targeted campaign against him. Consequently, we lost the political initiative to expose the reactionary, ruling class bias of the Congress party and the UDF."

It also said that the party had not properly monitored the functioning of its government

Maharashtra, Bengal

not to take coercive action against those named in the FIRs. Twenty FIRs were registered in Mumbai alone, with more than 1,000 people booked.

In West Bengal, the government said it would not take "coercive action" against students, but cited the Supreme Court order to clarify that this "shall not extend to persons having criminal antecedents". It added that as of July 26 evening, "one case has been registered... on the complaint of the police", in which 16 people had been arrested. During the day, the 16 got bail from the Chief Metropolitan Magistrate's court.

There are six other cases registered in Bengal, on complaints by journalists who alleged that they were assaulted during the student protests.

In Congress-ruled Kerala, CM V D Satheesan directed the Home Department to examine the demand for the withdrawal of cases, soon after Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan wrote to him in this regard.

The CJP, which led the Jantar Mantar protests, said the direction that governments could proceed with existing FIRs in the Supreme Court's order "stands in direct contradiction to the solemn assurance... extended by the government".

Khargone

Police charged 11 men - Ibadat, Sadiq, Abdullah, Saheb alias Shahib, Sheryar, Faizal, Azam, Shabbir, Imran, Mustaq and Rajik - with rioting, arson, house trespass and offences under the Explosive Substances Act in connection with the violence.

A day after the violence, the district administration had carried out a demolition drive, razing 16 houses and 29 shops in five localities of the town. The then Madhya Pradesh Home Minister, Narottam Mishra, had said "Jis ghar se pathar aaye hain, ush ghar ko pathar hona ka dhar banayenge (Will turn the houses from where the stones were hurled to a heap of rubble)".

In a detailed judgment Monday, Fourth Additional Sessions Judge Mukesh Nath held that the prosecution's case collapsed on the question of identification. The court found that eight of the 11 eyewitnesses examined by the prosecution completely failed to implicate the accused, no test identification parade was ever conducted, there was no explanation on how police selected the accused from a mob of about 50 people, and forensic evidence failed to establish the

alleged use of petrol bombs. The court recorded that eight prosecution witnesses, including complainants and victims, "did not support the prosecution story."

"None of these eight witnesses identified any of the accused; none stated that any accused trespass and offences under the Explosive Substances Act in connection with the violence. Even after they were declared hostile, "the prosecution derived no benefit, and no substantive fact implicating the accused persons came on record." The court concluded that "the involvement of the accused persons in the offence is neither disclosed nor proved in any manner."

The prosecution's case rested substantially on a local resident, Vaishnavi Jain, whom the court described as being only a witness to attribute the incident to all 11 accused. But the judgment found her evidence riddled with contradictions. The court noted that Vaishnavi claimed she recognised all the accused by their faces, while her own father Dinesh Jain and brother Akash Jain both stated they did not see their faces covered with cloth."

Akash told the court he saw only four or five people and

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Assembly security breach: Accused has bipolar disorder, court told

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 28

SARABJIT SINGH, the 37-year-old man who forced his way into the Delhi Assembly complex this year, has bipolar disorder, his counsel told a Delhi court on Monday.

Advocate Anshul Shukla had filed an application under the Mental Health Care Act, cit-

ing that his client was suffering from bipolar disorder, and requested that directions be issued for the constitution of a medical board.

According to the World Health Organisation (WHO), bipolar disorder is a mental health condition that affects a person's mood, energy, activity and thought and is characterised by manic and depressive episodes.

After hearing Shukla's submissions, Additional Sessions Judge (ASJ) Ankur Jain of the Hazrat Court directed the constitution of a medical board to examine him.

"Ld. Addl. PP (Public Prosecutor) for the State submits that state has no objection to the constitution of the medical board. Accordingly, Director, IHBAS, is directed to constitute

a medical board consisting of a Specialist as required under the Mental Health Act to examine whether patient/inmate is of unsound mind and that he is incapable of entering his defence," ASJ Jain said in his order dated July 27. The Institute of Human Behaviour & Allied Sciences is an autonomous body funded jointly by the Centre and Delhi governments.



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INFORMATION REGARDING 23RD ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF RAIL VIKAS NIGAM LIMITED

- This is to inform that the 23rd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of Rail Vikas Nigam Limited will be held on 25th August, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC")/Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") to transact the business as set out in the Notice of AGM, being circulated separately. In Compliance with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 and the circular issued earlier in this regard (collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars"), the 23rd AGM of the Company is being held through VC/OAVM.
- In Compliance with Regulations 36(1) and 44(4) of SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report 2025-26, will be sent only by electronic mode to those members of the Company whose email address are registered with the Company / Depository Participant(s). The aforesaid documents will also be available on the Company's website at www.rvnl.org, the website of the Stock Exchanges at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, website of CDSL (agency for providing e-voting/remote e-voting facility) i.e. www.evotingindia.com.
- Members can attend and participate in the AGM through the VC/OAVM facility ONLY. The detailed instructions with respect to such participation will be provided in the Notice convening the AGM. Members attending the meeting through VC/OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of quorum in terms of Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.
- The AGM Notice along with the Annual Report will be sent electronically to those Members whose e-mail addresses are registered with the Company/Registrar & Transfer Agent (RTA)/Depository Participants (DPs)/Depositories. The Company will send a letter providing the web-link, including the exact path where complete details of the Annual Report (including AGM Notice) are available, to those shareholder(s) who have not registered their email address with the Company/RTA/Depositories/DPs.
- Manner of registering / updating email addresses**
 - Members who have not registered their email address are requested to register the same in respect of shares held in electronic form with the depository through their depository participant(s) and in respect of shares held in physical form by writing (form ISR-1) to the company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, Alankit Assignments Limited, 205-208, Anarkali Complex, Jhandewalan Extension, New Delhi-110055 or by email to virenders@alankit.com.
 - Shareholders who have not registered their email address with the depository participants may procure user ID and password in the manner as set out below:
 - In case shares are held in physical mode, please provide Folio No., Name of Shareholder, Scanned Copy of the Share Certificate (Front & Back), PAN (self-attested scanned copy of PAN Card), AADHAR (self-attested scanned copy of Aadhar Card) by email to virenders@alankit.com.
 - In case of shares are held in Demat Mode, please provide DP ID & Client ID (16 digit DP ID + Client ID or 16 digit Beneficiary ID), Name, Client Master or copy of Consolidated Account Statement, PAN (self-attested scanned copy of PAN Card, AADHAR (self-attested scanned copy of Aadhar Card) by email to virenders@alankit.com. If you are an individual shareholder holding securities in Demat mode, please refer to the login method explained in the notice of AGM.
 - Alternatively, shareholders / members may send a request to www.evotingindia.com for procuring user ID & password for e-voting by providing the above mentioned documents.
- Manner of casting votes(s) through Remote e-voting is voting at AGM**
 - Members will have the opportunity to cast their vote(s) in the business as set out in the Notice of the AGM through electronic voting system ("e-voting").
 - The manner of voting remotely ("remote e-voting") by members holding shares in dematerialized mode, physical mode and for members who have not registered their email addresses has been provided in the Notice of AGM. The details will also be available on the website of Company at www.rvnl.org and on the website of CDSL www.cdslindia.com.
 - The facility of voting through electronic voting system will also be made available at the AGM and Members attending AGM who have not cast their vote(s) by remote e-voting will be able to vote at the AGM.
 - The login credentials for casting votes through e-voting shall be made available to all members through email. Members who do not receive email or whose email addresses are not registered with the Company / Alankit Assignments / Depository Participants may generate login credentials by following instructions given in the Notes to Notice of AGM and point no. 3(b) above.
- Process for updating Bank account details and KYC to receive Dividend**
In Compliance with the SEBI Master Circular dated February 6, 2026, issued to RTA read with other related SEBI Circulars and Regulation 12 of the SEBI Listing Regulations, the Company shall pay dividend to members holding shares in physical form, only through electronic mode and upon their folio being KYC compliant. Shareholders are requested to update their PAN, Contact Details (Postal Address with PIN and Mobile Number), Bank Account Details, Specimen Signature, etc., for their corresponding physical folios with the Company or its RTA.
For Members holding Shares in dematerialized form, we request you to please ensure that your electronic bank mandate is updated with your DP. The Company will not be able to accede to any direct request from such Members for change/addition/deletion in such bank details.
- Members are requested to carefully read all the Notices set out in the Notice of the AGM and in particular instructions to register / update e-mail id, for joining AGM, manner of casting votes through remote e-voting or voting at AGM and Dividend related information.**

For Rail Vikas Nigam Limited
Sd/-
(Kalpana Dubey)
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: New Delhi
Date: 28.07.2026

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Heavy rain sinks parts of Capital

At 80 mm, Pusa station records highest rainfall; waterlogging, jams across Delhi-NCR

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, July 28

SEVERAL PARTS OF Delhi CAME to a standstill for nearly three hours on Tuesday as heavy rain led to waterlogging on arterial roads, leading to traffic snarls. Commuters, including students, were seen wading through knee-deep water while water also entered shops in several key markets across the city, including Connaught Place and Sadar Bazar.

According to the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD), between 11.30 am and 2.30 pm, Safdarjung, the base weather station in the Capital, recorded 51 mm of rainfall. Pusa recorded the highest rainfall at 80 mm. Other stations like Janakpur recorded 72 mm of rain, Lodi Road 63.4 mm, Chhatrapur at 57.5 mm. Later in the day, the IMD issued a red alert for thunderstorms, lightning and heavy rainfall.

Traffic jams due to waterlogging roads were reported on Giza-09 near the Ghazipur Border, T.O. Azadpur, Malviya Nagar, Prahladpur and Kalindi Kunj. Waterlogging was also reported from Tolstoy Marg, Bharat Mandapam Road, Hanuman Road, Malviya Nagar and Mathura Road.

In the morning, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta travelled via a DTC bus and conducted an on-ground inspection in Rohini and nearby areas. During the inspection, Gupta reviewed the waterlogging-prone areas, cleanliness of major roads, and the condition of debris and garbage accumulated along road sides. She instructed officials to like similar schemes rolled out by several states, this one comes with a detailed set of eligibility conditions, exclusions and guidelines on how the assistance can be used.

Business disrupted

Major commercial areas like Connaught Place and the adjoining Janpath Market also witnessed severe disruptions. According to the New Delhi

•Skywatch

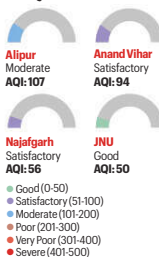
Forecast: July 29, 2026
Generally cloudy sky. Light to moderate rain.

MAX: 31-33
1.9°C below normal

MIN: 22-24
3.3°C below normal

•Sunrise: 5:42 AM (July 30)
•Sunset: 7:14 PM (June 29)
•Moonrise: 7:17 PM (June 29)
•Moonset: 6:05 AM (July 30)

•AQI Tracker



Traders Association, G Block, A Block and parts of the Outer Circle remained flooded, affecting commercial activity until around 1 pm. Megawati, even as Minto Bridge is a hotspot, the area did not see waterlogging on Tuesday. Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh shared a video on X showing traffic moving smoothly on Minto Bridge.

"Rain is pouring relentlessly but life on Minto Bridge is moving along at the same pace. The very effort is to ensure that the monsoon remains just a season, not a trouble," he said. AAP leader Saurabh Bhardwaj slammed the Minister's post by sharing a video showing school children being carried on their parents' shoulders through waist-deep water in Sadar Bazar. "In Sadar Bazar, one of Delhi's largest wholesale markets, school children are being forced to pass through waist-deep rainwater. Thank you, CM Rekha Gupta. After Gen Z, now Gen Alpha too will remain indebted to the BJP," he said.



CONNAUGHT PLACE



ANAND VIHAR



(From top) A flooded Connaught Place; an inundated lane at Sadar Bazar; traffic snarl near Anand Vihar on the Delhi Meerut Expressway after heavy rain lashed Delhi-NCR on Tuesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA, ABHINAV SAHA

GROUND report

In wholesale hub Sadar, drains are choked and shops flooded

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, July 28

AT A souvenir shop in Old Delhi's Sadar Bazar, one of the largest wholesale markets in India, Anil Kumar, in his 30s, stood in knee-deep water Tuesday with a bucket in his hand. Even as he tirelessly continued to throw out the water, the efforts did not yield a result he expected. Sadar Bazar, famous for souvenirs, glassware, furniture, and dry fruits, emerges as a waterlogging hotspot every monsoon, causing heavy losses to shop owners.

"I have been working here for 20 years, and every time it rains, it floods. This hasn't changed in decades," said Kumar. Outside the shop, hordes of workers could be seen carrying heavy backpacks on their heads, backs or rickshaws.

A little further along the road, an MCD official and a worker were trying to start a pump to suck the water out from the area. "The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation has a permanent pump connected to the drains, to remove the water, in case it rains. But we received a call from the control room to speed up the process," said the official.

On blocked drains, he said, "The MCD does proper cleaning early in the morning. But the waste from the nearby factories clog the drains."

Ajay Bajaj, Senior Advisor to the Confederation of Sadar Bazar Traders Association, too voiced his grievance. "This place is decades old. We help the government with our huge turnovers. And what do we get in return? Nothing."

The sun has set at the Bazar. The MCD's tractor came back to life after a coordinated effort by the officials and the traders. The sound of the pump sucking the water out emits a sigh of relief among the traders. But they knew, this relief is temporary; until the next time it rains

CJP STIR: OFFICIAL RECORDS SHOW

RAF officer fired 'anti-riot gun' twice at protesters on senior cop's order

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 28

A RAPID Action Force (RAF) personnel fired an Anti-Riot Gun (ARG) twice on orders of a Deputy Commissioner of Police-rank officer during the Cockroach, Janta Party's 'Sant Chalo' march on July 20, official records show. Sources, meanwhile, said that Delhi Police has submitted its report to the Ministry of Home Affairs regarding the incident mentioning the use of the ammunition and force in controlling the crowd.

An ARG is not a pellet gun, but falls under the same category of 'non-lethal' weapons that can engage multiple targets with one shot. It is used to fire plastic or rubber pellets, tear gas shells, and other projectiles.

At least three people who participated in the July 20 protest sustained pellet injuries. Irshad Sheikh, 25, who works in Gurgaon; Sahil Lochab, 19, a Delhi University student; and a 28-year-old journalist with Outlook magazine. One of them risks losing his eyesight.

Last week, the RAF had said it would inquire into the use of pellets by its personnel even as the Delhi Police had categorically denied its usage. A comment from the Delhi Police in this regard is awaited.

According to a General Diary entry—an official log maintained at every police station, which records all important events, information received, and actions taken by

the police—filed on July 22 at 1.24 pm at the Parliament Street police station, a RAF Deputy Commandant told the duty officer that he was deployed near Jantar Mantar with a DCP-rank officer from North Delhi district on July 20.

The DCP had been called in to oversee the law and order situation at the protest site, along with multiple IPS officers from other districts. As per the diary entry, a RAF officer claimed that on the DCP's orders, he fired the ARG twice on protesters, along with 55 non-electrical shells, 15 electrical shells and five tear gas shells.

A source in Delhi Police still deny that they authorised the use of any pellet guns during the protest.

According to sources, a meeting of senior officers was held at the Police Headquarters, where the validity of the General Diary entry was discussed. Questions were raised over the diary entry made two days after the incident. A source also claimed that the IPS officer denied being present at the site of the incident at the time it happened, claiming to be about 500 metres away from there.

According to another source in the Delhi Police, the DCP, whose name was mentioned in the diary entry at Parliament Street Police Station, was initially deployed in Zone 3 near Parliament Street. When the crowd moved towards Parliament, he was shifted to Zone 6, the source said.

SIR OF ELECTORAL ROLLS

Don't create unbearable burden on teachers: HC to Election Commission

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 28

THE ONGOING Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise chosen in the Capital must not "cause so much stress" to teachers that it leads to "unbearable burden", the Delhi High Court said on Tuesday as it questioned the Election Commission of India (ECI) "over the language used in its order" to school principals. The court was referring to the order issued to ensure deployment of school teachers as SIR enumerators or booth level officers (BLOs).

A bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia was dealing with a public interest litigation (PIL) challenging the deputation of schoolteachers in the Ambekar Nagar constituency for election-related work during school hours. The plea filed by advocates Rajesh Kumar Gogna and Ashok Aggarwal contended that the deployment has severely disrupted classroom teaching and infringes the fundamental rights of schoolchildren. The PIL seeks the court's direction that such deployment be rationalised by capping it at 10% with a provision to provide qualified substitute teachers whenever necessary.

Addressing ECI's counsel,

while referring to an order issued by the Electoral Registration Office (ERO) to school principals to ensure strict compliance, the court said, "What we want is you to be a bit sensitive to their situation. We are not curtailing your right...but we are conscious of the Right to Education as also the human condition...asking any teacher to work for 11 hours...they have their children, their families...you've to humanise their condition. The kind of language you've used in this order...is to create fear or what?"

The ERO ordered July 27 to school principals objected to the direction of school heads to BLOs, who have been deployed for SIR duty. "To attend routine school work or are otherwise creating hindrances in the discharge of their election-related responsibilities".

"No principal, head of school or any other administrative authority is authorised to prevent, obstruct or interfere with the discharge of election duties assigned to BLOs and BLO supervisors. They shall not compel such officers to prioritise routine institutional work over election-related assignments...any such interference shall be viewed seriously and may invite appropriate action...," the order read.

Cabinet nod to monthly aid scheme for women; conditions apply

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 28

THE BJP government in the Capital moved a step closer to delivering its key poll promise in the last Assembly elections as the Cabinet on Tuesday cleared the 'Delhi Lakshmi Yojana' that offers a monthly assistance of Rs 2,500 to women from Economically Weaker Sections (EWS). However, unlike similar schemes rolled out by several states, this one comes with a detailed set of eligibility conditions, exclusions and guidelines on how the assistance can be used.

The scheme is expected to benefit about 17 lakh women in the city, according to officials. A budget allocation of Rs 5,110 crore was made for this scheme in the budget 2026-27.

According to information shared by the Chief Minister's Office, the scheme will cover eligible women between 21 and 60 years of age whose family income is up to Rs 2.50 lakh per annum. Women with more

than three children won't be able to avail the benefits.

The eligible women will not get cash in hand. Rather, they can avail the aid in two ways—invest the entire amount in Recurring Deposit (RD) or Fixed Deposit (FD) accounts or save Rs 1,500 and get remaining. But that too will be credited through digital rupee wallet.

"The registration portal for the scheme will be launched from August 1. The government aims to release the first instalment on the occasion of Raksha Bandhan on August 28 to eligible beneficiaries," announced Chief Minister Gupta after the Cabinet meeting.

She added, "The scheme would usher in a new chapter of self-reliance for lakhs of women. The Delhi government has fulfilled this important promise made to women within just over a year of assuming office."

2 options to avail aid

Explaining about the two options to avail aid, a senior of-

•The criteria

WHO CAN APPLY?

- Women aged between 21 and 60
- Should be eldest female member of family
- Applicant or her husband or either of her parents must have been a resident of Delhi for at least 10 years
- Registered voter of Delhi
- Family income should not exceed Rs 2.5 lakh per annum

cial said that it has been designed to give beneficiaries flexibility while encouraging both immediate financial support and long-term financial security.

Women whose families require regular monthly expenditure can opt for the first model with Rs 1,000 credited every month into a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) wallet for day-to-day household needs, while Rs 1,500 sim-

WHO ARE NOT ELIGIBLE?

- Women with more than 3 kids
- Govt employees
- Those receiving financial assistance or pension from govt
- Those paying income tax, GST
- Those who own car
- Those with criminal record
- Those belonging to families with annual electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units.

ultaneously invested in a recurring deposit (RD) or fixed deposit (FD) account. "This ensures that alongside meeting immediate needs, beneficiaries also build a savings corpus over time," the official explained.

"Alternatively, beneficiaries who wish to maximise their long-term savings may choose to receive the entire Rs 2,500 every month in an RD or FD account. This option allows them to accumulate a larger amount

with interest over the duration of the scheme.

CBDC Wallet, officials said, has been designed to ensure that government assistance is utilised for constructive household expenditure and not for "socially undesirable purposes".

Accordingly, the wallet will be configured with a negative list, which digitally blocks transactions relating to specified categories of goods and services, the officials added.

As per the guidelines, the amount available in the CBDC Wallet cannot be used for the purchase of alcoholic beverages, tobacco products, narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances, lottery tickets, gambling and betting services and any other goods or services prohibited by the Government from time to time, said officials. "The restrictions are enforced technologically through the CBDC platform itself, meaning transactions falling under these prohibited merchant categories will not be permitted. All other legitimate day-to-day

household purchases and permitted goods and services can continue to be made using the wallet," said an official.

Another official said, "This innovation combines financial assistance with responsible utilisation of public funds and is one of the distinguishing features of the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana."

While the government has shortlisted banks, it will pick the bank giving the highest interest rate on RD and FD accounts, said sources, and accounts will be opened in the name of the beneficiary.

The scheme will initially be implemented for three years from the date it comes into effect. It may thereafter continue with suitable modifications, the CM said.

Gupta said that the entire application process will be conducted online through the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana portal. "A transparent district-level mechanism has been put in place for the scrutiny of applications, final approval and the speedy redressal of grievances," she said.

SCAMMERS EXPLOIT VULNERABILITY IN FACEBOOK'S DESKTOP VERSION TO MANIPULATE TIMESTAMPS, SAYS PETITIONER

'Copyright strikes used to extort creators': HC asks Meta and Centre to respond

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 28

DIGITAL CONTENT creators are facing a new challenge on social media platforms: copyright complaints allegedly being used by third-party "rogue actors" as a tool to pressure creators into paying money to delete the grievances.

The issue came before the Delhi High Court on Tuesday. A bench of Justices V Kameswara Rao and Manmeet Pritham Singh Aroa sought responses from Meta Platforms and the Centre on a public interest lit-

igation filed by Noida-based full-time content creator Nitin Joshi, who has more than 16 million followers on Instagram.

Joshi, who creates content around entrepreneurship, finance, branding, business strategy, and marketing, had on July 7 published a video titled 'Instagram's Biggest Copyright Scam', alleging that digital creators were being targeted through co-ordinated copyright strikes. He invited other affected creators to share their experiences and supporting material.

The following day, his video was blocked worldwide by

Meta Platforms after a complaint filed by a person identifying himself as 'Nayon Mia'. Joshi subsequently approached the Delhi HC through a PIL, citing instances of nearly 40 creators who he claimed had faced similar situations.

Through his lawyer Tejvir Singh, Joshi has alleged that scammers exploit a vulnerability in Facebook's desktop version to manipulate timestamps. According to his petition, bad-faith actors upload unrelated or arbitrary material on Facebook pages with little to no engagement or fol-



Content creator Nitin Joshi. INSTAGRAM: @NITINJOSHI

lowers.

When a legitimate creator uploads a new, original reel on Instagram, the scammers allegedly download it and use the

"Edit Post" functionality on their older Facebook posts to replace the original media with the creator's video.

The altered post continues to display the earlier publication date, creating the appearance that the scammers had published the content first and owned the copyright.

Using these backdated posts, the scammers allegedly invoke Meta's "Rights Manager", a copyright enforcement tool designed to protect intellectual property. The automated system, relying on the oldest timestamp, assumes that

the scammer is the original creator and accepts the copyright complaint, the petition explains.

The PIL seeks formation of a special investigation team to probe what he describes as an "organised cyber extortion racket" and directions to Meta Platforms to establish a grievance redressal mechanism, human review instead of only automated review.

During Tuesday's hearing, senior advocate Arvind Datar, appearing for Meta, questioned the maintainability of the PIL. "In any mechanism, there will

be rogue players, that can't be helped...None of the 40 (exemplified in Joshi's PIL) have come to court...We want to take proactive steps to curb the rogue actors," he argued.

The bench, however, issued notice to Meta Platforms and the Centre, while orally observing, "Nothing will preclude you to address the grievances of Joshi. The court noted that "there is a larger issue of digital extortion" involved in the matter.

The Centre's counsel, advocate Ishkaran Bhandari, who is himself a content creator, acknowledged Joshi's concern as

legitimate issue that requires to be addressed during the course of the hearing.

Significantly, Delhi HC on Monday disposed of two petitions—one filed by the Jat Association and another by creator Riddhima Sharma—making similar allegations of extortion through copyright strikes by the discharge of election duties assigned to BLOs and BLO supervisors. They shall not compel such officers to prioritise routine institutional work over election-related assignments...any such interference shall be viewed seriously and may invite appropriate action...," the order read.

CJP volunteer moves SC alleging illegal detention and harassment

Drishiti Jain

New Delhi, July 28

JUNAID MALIK (30), who volunteered at the recently concluded protest at Jantar Mantar by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), moved the Supreme Court on Monday, alleging arbitrary and coercive actions by the police against him and his family.

In his petition, Malik, who has amassed over a million followers on Instagram and was involved in distributing food and water at the protest site, alleged "harassment" and "intimidation", stating that the police action violated provisions under Article 21 of the Constitution. The petition stated that on July 24, he was returning from Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital after receiving an anti-rabies injection and had barely travelled 50 metres in an autorickshaw when he and his friend were allegedly intercepted by a white Scorpio car that did not bear a number plate. He alleged that four-five policemen forced them into the vehicle, adding they were blindfolded and told to keep their heads bowed.

Malik, a law graduate from Meerut's Chaudhary Charan Singh University, alleged that the car was driven for 30-45 minutes to an "undisclosed location", after which the policemen took their phones and went through their contacts. They were allegedly taken to another location and detained for the night, the petition stated.

A senior police officer, the next morning on July 28, questioned the applicant and his friend regarding the sources of funding for the food distribution at the (protest) site, the plea stated, adding that they were threatened and dropped at a location situated around 16 km away from the Dehradun-Mussorie Road in Uttarakhand. It added that they had to book a cab to return to Delhi.



Junaid Malik

According to the petition, Malik's "illegal detention" followed his father Mustafa's alleged detention and questioning by the Ghaziabad police on July 23 at a police station in Masuri. Mustafa was allegedly questioned for six hours during which bank account details of the entire family were sought. The petition also stated that he was asked about Malik's whereabouts and told to persuade him to return home.

The police allegedly also raided Malik's home on July 24, sought bank account details and IDs of all the family members. According to the plea, another police team reached Malik's sister's house in Meerut and picked up her father-in-law and brother-in-law.

When contacted, Masuri ACP Sunil Kumar said: "Nobody was detained. Two-three persons were called to the police station for questioning... They were asked about Junaid and to specify their relation with him."

Asked why they were called for questioning, the officer said, "There are thousands of matters for which a person is called, including social issues, for which people keep coming. They told us who Junaid is and what their relation is with him."

The SHO at Masuri police station said that the police received a complaint and called Mustafa to the police station. "He was not picked up. Nobody was detained," the officers said.

FACES OF PROTEST AGAINST NEET PAPER LEAK AT JANTAR MANTAR

'Hit without provocation': Ranchi woman recovers after suffering ear injury during Sansad Chalo march

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 28

A 32-YEAR-OLD woman, who sustained a severe ear injury on July 20 during the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) Sansad Chalo march, has alleged that security forces fired at peaceful demonstrators demanding educational reforms to tackle the issue of paper leaks.

Nootan Toppo, who works with a private firm in Gurgaon, joined the demonstration with two friends. "Why were we hit when we were peacefully protesting?" she asked as she recovers at her home in Jharkhand's Ranchi.

According to Toppo, security personnel — including members of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) and men in plain clothes carrying sticks, initiated an unprovoked lathi-charge on the crowd.



Nootan Toppo

"Several uniformed personnel were not wearing badges and men in civilian dress used abusive language against protesters. I had just taken a selfie moments before the firing started," she claimed as she spoke to *The Indian Express* on Tuesday.

During the action, Toppo

said, she was hit on her right ear, resulting in heavy bleeding. Protesters provided emergency first aid at the scene using a stole before the two friends she had come with took her to Ram Manohar Lohia (RML) Hospital in Delhi. Medical records and the medico-legal report (MLC) noted a "swelling of ear lobe"

and recorded a "suspected gunshot injury," she said.

Toppo said that the injury is similar to a rubber bullet injury, according to medical reports, a claim that could not be independently verified by *The Indian Express*. Toppo underwent a reconstructive plastic surgery lasting nearly two hours that also involved stitches. She claimed that she continues to experience hearing impairment and a bout of recurring fever.

Earlier reports by *The Indian Express* revealed that an internal inquiry by the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) established that a Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel deployed in the nearby Connaught Place area in Delhi had fired seven rounds from a pellet gun during the crackdown.

The CRPF probe found that five of those rounds directly

struck protesters, while two hit the ground. The officer involved reportedly claimed the action was taken in self-defence after a section of the crowd engaged in stone-pelting. The force has since examined log entries and video footage to determine whether standard operating procedures regarding crowd control were violated.

The CRPF's findings stand in contrast to public statements issued by the Delhi Police, which maintained that the force neither possessed nor used pellet guns during the operation. However, medical evaluations reviewed across multiple city hospitals documented similar injuries, including a 28-year-old sports journalist who had more than 30 pellets lodged in his body, as well as a 19-year-old student who suffered facial injuries.

Govt appoints 3 health officials as DGHS link officers after ex-head's arrest

New Delhi: The Delhi government has appointed three senior health officials to handle the Directorate General of Health Services' routine work after former DGHS Director Dr Vatsala Aggarwal was arrested in an alleged multi-crore procurement scam. According to an order issued by the Health and Family Welfare Department, the Medical Director of Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital has been designated as the first link officer for the DGHS Director. The Medical Superintendent of Dr Hedgewar Arogya Sansthan and the Medical Superintendent of Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital have been appointed as the second and third link officers, respectively. The directive said the officers would look after routine administrative affairs.

PTI

'Mauj masti must not stop': 19-year-old whose reels energised demonstration

Anusree K C & Reva Thakkar
New Delhi, July 28

THE SUCCESS of last week's protest owed as much to GenZ's determination to fight it out on the streets as to the high spirits, wit, andchutzpah that they demonstrated online. The battle of narratives, attention spans, and laughs was decisively won on Instagram, and one of those who led the charge was Abhinav Bisht.

"Mauj masti rukni nahi chahiye (the fun must not stop)" is not just his Insta bio, it is also the motto of his 19-year-old life, the floppy-haired young man told *The Indian Express*.

Abhinav's reel, made to 'Subway Surfers' audio, of running with a crowd with police chasing behind, had someone commenting,

"Bhaag Genzlika Bhaag". Another one on a relationship with the police, made to 'Who's



Abhinav Bisht

most likely to' audio, got 1.2 million likes.

Before Abhinav posted his protest reels, his Insta handle, @issacrl, had 2,450 followers.

On Tuesday evening, the number stood at 766. His supportive parents decided to celebrate each milestone from 10K

to 700K, so "I cut a cake every day for five days," he said.

The young influencer, who is originally from Garhwal, Uttarakhand, started creating content a year and a half ago. "I had worked in a call centre for three months and saved up for a computer to edit videos and live-stream," he said.

The protest meant a lot for him — "Accountability is very important because the victims [of the paper leaks] were also students like me." He also came away from his days at Jantar Mantar with "20-30 new creator friends", and "I am now close to all of them".

Abhinav posted his first reel on July 21. He had gone to the protest without telling his parents — despite the pride in their son, they had seen the July 20 lathi-charge, and were worried for his safety.

"But after seeing the response my content got, they

didn't stop me again," he said.

The protest was fun — he played ludo, Uno, and pakdam-pakdai (tag) with other protesters on the road, Abhinav said.

"We were doing so much masti, and I wanted to capture that in my reels." He said he brought out old trends and made them relevant to the protest — like vibing with fellow creators to an upbeat remix of Kishore Kumar's Mere mehboob gayamat hogi. "My reels became so viral that even police officers recognised me. Some would smile, though some frowned. I was scared they would detain me," Abhinav said.

After his account was suspended two days ago, he could not sleep at night, Abhinav said. "I think it was due to Instagram's weak security. I hired an agency, and they helped me retrieve my account," he said.

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The Bose Files: A slice of history that will shock you

At a time when audiences are increasingly drawn to stories inspired by real events, *The Bose Files* revisits one of the most compelling and debated chapters of India's freedom struggle. More than a historical retelling, the film invites viewers to rediscover Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose through a fresh lens, celebrating his extraordinary legacy while reflecting on the enduring mystery that continues to surround his disappearance.

Directed by internationally acclaimed and award-winning filmmaker Rajesh Gupta, *The Bose Files* traces Bose's remarkable journey from a visionary nationalist to the Supreme Commander of the Indian National Army (INA). The film captures his unwavering determination to challenge British rule through bold and unconventional means, while exploring the ideals, sacrifices and defining moments that shaped one of India's most revered freedom fighters.

Featuring an accomplished ensemble cast including Yateen Karyekar, Akhileendra Mishra, Virendra Saxena, Apoorva Arora, Amit Behl, Rajeev Kumar and Rajesh Gupta, the film explores

themes of truth, sacrifice and the rewriting of history. It blends powerful drama with gripping sequences and emotionally charged moments, unfolding across meticulously recreated period settings and contemporary timelines.

Beyond celebrating Bose's heroism, *The Bose Files* ventures into one of modern India's most enduring historical debates. Revisiting the events surrounding Netaji's disappearance, it examines the long-standing controversy over the alleged cover-up by successive governments and the Intelligence Bureau, encouraging audiences to question accepted narratives while engaging with history from a fresh perspective.

Balancing historical authenticity with compelling storytelling, *The Bose Files* presents not only the legend of Netaji, but also the man behind the icon—his courage, conviction and unshakeable commitment to India's freedom. It is a film that seeks to honour his legacy while inspiring audiences to revisit a defining chapter of the nation's history with renewed curiosity and reflection.

"The film was incredibly informative and deeply engaging. After watching *The Bose Files*, I believe the story of Netaji will never be viewed the same way again. Every Indian owes a debt of gratitude to him for his immense contribution to our freedom, and this film does justice to his legacy

— Shubham Gupta, IT Professional

I went in expecting a historical film, but came out feeling inspired. The film challenges long-held historical narratives while honouring the legacy of one of India's greatest freedom fighters. It is a thought-provoking experience that every young Indian should watch.

— Anuja Kulkarni,
Marketing Executive

This movie made history feel alive. It presents Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's vision, courage and sacrifices in a way that is both emotional and thought-provoking. It made me realise why Netaji remains one of the most influential leaders of the freedom movement. A must-watch for every Indian.

— Rohan Iyer,
Engineering Student

Rarely does a film educate and move you at the same time. *The Bose Files* is a powerful cinematic experience that honours his extraordinary legacy while encouraging audiences to question accepted historical narratives. Every Indian should experience this remarkable film.

— Sneha Menon,
School Teacher

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THE BOSE FILES

A FILM BY RAJESH GUPTA

A SLICE OF HISTORY TO SHOCK YOU!

Cast: Yateen Karyekar, Virendra Saxena, Akhileendra Mishra, Apoorva Arora, Amit Behl, Rajeev Kumar, Akashdeep Arora & Rajesh Gupta
DP: Ramesh Arora | Editor: Rishabh Chandra | Sound Designer: Pratik Shah | Executive Producer: Rajesh Gupta
Production Designer: Vikas Rawat | Make-up: Jyoti Arora | Costumes: Suresh Dasi | Background Score: Sanjay Choudhary
Music Composer: Nitish Dey | UI Designer: Bhushan S. | VFX: Pratik Ushah | PR: Deepak Ravishanker
Story, Screenplay & Dialogues: Rajesh Gupta
Published by: Real Reels, Mumbai. Studio: Real Reels. Distributed by: UFO

RELEASING ALL OVER INDIA ON

30th JULY 2026



Helping Hand

AMID THE mounting tension between the Treasury benches and the Opposition, Parliament on Tuesday witnessed some moments of bonhomie between the two sides. After the Rajya Sabha was adjourned in the morning, Union Minister J P Nadda, who is the Leader of the House, and Leader of the Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge went to the canteen together. Nadda was seen holding Kharge's hand as the latter often faces mobility and walking difficulties. Inside the canteen, while Kharge joined Congress members, Nadda was seen enjoying tea with BJP MP Neeraj Shekhar and others during the brief break.

Gen Z jibe

TAKING A leaf out of the students' protest over paper leaks, Shiv Sena (Shinde) MP Shrikant Eknath Shinde, during the debate on the anti-paper leak Bill in Lok Sabha on Tuesday, sought to attack the Congress "in Gen Zlingo". Shinde alleged that the principal opposition party had been "MLA (mis)conduct in action" from the protests at Jantar Mantar but chose to stage a protest outside the PM's residence out of "FOMO (fear of missing out)". He added that the party was "delulu (delusional)" if it thought that former education minister Dharmendra Pradhan had stepped down due to its pressure.

Not Lost in Translation

DURING THE debate on the anti-paper leak Bill in the Lok Sabha, DMP MP Dayanidhi Maran made a light-hearted observation that he appreciated the Bill being drafted in English and not Hindi or Sanskrit, as some of its most crucial aspects could get lost in translation. Union Minister Jitendra Singh, who tabled the proposed law in the House, responded by offering to get the Bill translated into Hindi. Refusing to back down, Maran said if it came to translation, he would rather that the Bill be translated into all Indian languages.

TMC MPs who joined NCPI attend their first NDA parliamentary party meet

Press Trust of India

New Delhi, July 28

FOR THE first time, a group of MPs who left the Trinamool Congress and joined the NCPI attended a meeting of the NDA parliamentary party on Tuesday with the attendance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and top Union ministers.

As many as 20 Lok Sabha MPs revolted against their party, TMC, and joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI). Speaker Om Birla took a call on giving NCPI recognition.

The NDA parliamentary party meeting was held at the Parliament House complex. "I participated in the NDA meeting. It was an enriching and informative meeting in the presence of PM Narendra Modi. Today, we had a discussion on FTAs. It was a positive discussion," MP Sayonji Ghosh said. Another lawmaker, Ghosh Dastidar, said this was the first time 20 NCPI MPs were invited for the NDA's "Mangal Milan" meeting.

Govt, Opp cross swords over NEET row

Opp: Govt not serious about education... students were compelled to hit streets

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, July 28

THE OPPOSITION on Tuesday attacked the government over paper leaks and the crackdown on students' protest in the Capital last week, with Congress Deputy Leader in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi saying the youth were compelled to take to the streets as the Centre "is not serious about education".

Initiating the debate in the Lok Sabha on the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, Gogoi said despite an existing law, paper leaks of public examinations have continued, and the law has proved to be a failure.

The Congress leader said merely enhancing punishment and penalties will not curb paper leaks unless the education system is comprehensively changed. He said the proposed amendments are only a "cosmetic exercise" and reflect the government's "failure" to bring genuine reforms in the education sector. "This government is not serious about education. It does not want to bring real reforms. This is merely a showpiece amendment," he said.

Thanking the youth of the country, Gogoi said: "They reminded us what democracy truly means. They reminded us that asking questions is the fundamental right of every citizen." Congress MP Shashi Tharoor said the NTA has conducted hundreds of exams for crores of students. "But in the 14 major examinations conducted by the NTA, six have had allegations of paper leaks and other discrepancies and 15 examinations have been postponed by the NTA in the last seven years. The NTA has only 39 permanent posts



Deputy Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi speaks during the discussion on Tuesday. ANI

and 15 of these posts are vacant; so just 24 people on permanent posts are responsible for examinations that can determine the future of crores of young Indians. There is something fundamentally wrong about this arrangement," said Tharoor.

Samajwadi Party MP Akhilesh Yadav said the government was forced to bend before youth power and make Dharmendra Pradhan resign from the Education Ministry. "When the government gets rattled, it accepts... the government bowed down and accepted the demands."

On Pradhan's exit, he said: "Pradhan ji ko hataa kar Pradhan Mantri ko bacha liya apne (By removing Pradhan, you saved the PM)." The SP chief said the crackdown on the students during the protest was nothing less than what happened during the Emergency. He said batons were used even then, but this time "current" was also given to stu-

dents. He made the statement when Union Minister Kiren Rijji sought to know whether the government would support a Bill to respond to students' demands or those who imposed the Emergency. Akhilesh said just like there was a regime change after the Emergency, there would be regime change now too. He said even God would not save the government, as its people were involved in the "maha paap" (grave sin) of *chadhaava chor* (theft of Ram Temple donations).

SP MP Dimple Yadav accused the government of "ripping" the youth of their dignity and sacrificing the principles of Mahatma Gandhi by using force on students peacefully protesting against paper leak.

TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee said the amendment Bill on paper leaks will not wash away the 12 years of "incompetence and failure" of the government. Despite being critical of the

government on the issue, Banerjee extended his party's support to the proposed legislation. "It cannot erase the humiliation faced by lakhs of young Indians. It cannot erase images of students who came seeking justice and were met with barricades and pellet guns instead of love and compassion," he said.

AIMIM MP Asaduddin Owaisi asked if changing the law, making a law, or just resigning would bring back the lives of those students who lost their lives because of paper leak. He suggested that the government create an AI-based question bank, containing one lakh questions. "There should be no human interface in this," he said.

NCPSP MP Suraj Subramanian demanded that the government call an all-party meeting and also form a Joint Parliamentary Committee to examine the issue of paper leaks.

"We (Opposition) are not your enemy," he said.

Govt: Anti-paper leak Bill a visionary step towards safeguarding youth's future

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 28

THE BJP-LED NDA government on Tuesday threw its weight behind the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, terming it a "visionary step towards safeguarding the future of India's youth".

BJP's New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj said the proposed amendments would strengthen transparency, fairness and reliability of competitive exams by delivering "a strong blow to paper leak mafia and further strengthening the trust of millions of aspirants".

"I myself am a lawyer; we were always taught a legal maxim—that justice delayed is justice denied. This has become the spirit of this amendment... along with adding speed to it, this amendment also makes punishment tougher. An ordinary criminal will have to pay a fine of Rs 50 lakh instead of Rs 10 lakh and the punishment has been increased from three to five years to five to 10 years," she said.

"This amendment protects merit, preserves fairness and safeguards the dreams of India's youth... It is a product of responsible governance by the responsible (Narendra) Modi government," she said.

The BJP MP accused the Opposition of displaying "selective outrage" over examination paper leaks, saying such incidents also happened during the Congress-led UPA regime.

Shiv Sena (Shinde) MP Shrikant Shinde, while paying



BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj and Shiv Sena MP Shrikant Shinde speak in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday. ANI/PTI

tribute to the 21 students who died by suicide, said the Bill was a "pakka ilaj" (foolproof remedy) "for paper leaks which had devastating impact not just on students but also their families".

BJP MP Tejasvi Surya said the nation's students did not want politics over paper leaks, but sought a system that protected their future.

"The student who is preparing for the next examination is more concerned about who is going to fix the system for the future and knows that this government under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi is trying to fix the system once and for all for the better for his future," he said.

Attacking the Congress over alleged paper leaks in Karnataka where the party is in power, Surya said justice was not a one-way street.

"Today there are two kinds of political models in the country. One is the Modi model: hope and reform; the other is the model of the Opposition, which is cynicism and

anarchism... governance, nation-building is an exercise in continuum. It is not as if everything in the country is well and good. Changing this for the better is the responsibility of the nation's youth and that is why they are with Modi ji," he said.

Surya said whenever there is a crisis, PM Modi has "converted it into an opportunity for reform".

BJP MP Anurag Thakur said the proposed amendment was aimed at further strengthening the system and ensuring that no one was able to play with the future of the nation's youth. "The youth knows that when there was NEET exam leak on May 3... our government cancelled it (the paper) on May 12 and in just three days... decided to conduct a re-examination so that one year of the youth is not wasted," he said.

He said the Modi government would find a permanent solution to paper leaks, just as it had addressed challenges such as terrorism and Maoism.

Rahul targets Pralhad Joshi outside House; he must 'learn to respect elders', says BJP

Asad Rehman & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 28

AROW erupted in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday over Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's remarks about New Education Minister Pralhad Joshi, which led Speaker Om Birla to assure the riled-up Treasury Benches that the comments would be struck off the records.

After Joshi raised objections and asked Priyanka to authenticate her allegations, Birla requested MPs to verify their comments before speaking. The remarks were later expunged from the records.

BJP's chief national spokesperson Anil Bahuguna later termed the Wayanad MP's remarks as "misleading, unfortunate and condemnable". This kind of "unrestrained and misleading comment about a Union Minister on the floor of the House cannot be accepted in a healthy democracy," he said.

Following Priyanka's remarks, as the Treasury Benches rose in protest, Leader of Opposition (LoP) Rahul Gandhi rushed out of the House and returned with a sheet of paper. He handed it over to her even as Congress



Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi and Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Parliament premises on Tuesday. ANI

MPs rushed towards the Well and senior MPs from the ruling alliance went into a snaphuddle, followed by demands for the Wayanad MP to apologise.

The proof, Priyanka said in response, was an article that she said could be used to authenticate her comments. The Speaker then intervened, asking MPs on both sides of the aisle to concentrate on the anti-paper leak Bill instead.

"The case in reference to which Priyanka Vadra ji and Rahul Gandhi ji have mentioned the Union Minister's comment

is completely wrong. Union Minister Pralhad Joshi has never made any such comment in the said case. He had only remarked on the legal process and neither on the case nor its merit," Baluni said. "...modifying statements, misleading the nation, and making unrestrained comments according to their convenience has become the Congress's habit," he said.

Outside Parliament

Later, Gandhi, with Priyanka by his side, addressed reporters outside the House. The new

Education Minister was a "defender of rapists," he alleged.

"As the Education Minister of India, the BJP puts a man who is a defender of rapists... That is the Education Minister of India today. It's a strange reaction from the PM. There are so many people in his Cabinet; he could have chosen any one of them. But he chooses a person who protects rapists," said Gandhi.

BJP MP Nishikant Dubey said, "The Gandhi family thinks they can say or do whatever they wish, but they have to understand that there are Rules and Procedures which need to be followed."

Speaking to reporters outside Parliament, Dubey said, "I wish he had learned to respect his elders. In front of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh ji, he tore up a Bill and called the PM a joker. In this case, this is a poor ordinary person (Joshi)."

In 2022, breaking the Centre's silence on the premature release of 11 men serving life sentences in the 2002 Bilkis Bano gangrape case, Joshi, then the Minister of Parliamentary Affairs, Lok and Mines, said it was done "as per the legal provision".

RS adjourned amid protests by Opp MPs

New Delhi: Rajya Sabha was adjourned for the day on Tuesday following pandemonium over Opposition parties' demand to raise the issue of police actions against NEET paper leak demonstrators in the national capital last week.

As soon as the House reassembled after lunch, following an adjournment within minutes after it convened for the first time at 11am, Deputy Chairman Harivansh took up government legislative business.

Amid din, Union Minister Jitan Ram Manjhi introduced the MSME Development (Amendment) Bill. After this, Harivansh asked the protesting members to "move to (the) other bill".

However, the House could not take up discussion on The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 due to the uproar in the Upper House.

"So you don't want to run the House proceedings?" Harivansh asked the protesting Opposition legislators. Seeing continuing vociferous protests by the Opposition over his demand, the Chair adjourned the House till Wednesday. PTI

Rain Check

Samajwadi Party national president Akhilesh Yadav at Parliament House on Tuesday. ANI

Amid push to penalise Vande Mataram 'insult', 1,102 arrests, 60 convictions

Anjishnu Das
New Delhi, July 28

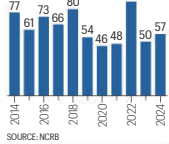
WHILE THE Monsoon Session of Parliament has so far failed to conduct any significant business amid a running conflict between the Narendra Modi government and the Opposition over the paper leak protests, the government on Friday introduced in the Rajya Sabha an amendment to the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, to make any insult to the national anthem "Vande Mataram" a criminal offence, granting it the same statutory protection currently given to the national anthem "Jana Gana Mana".

However, an analysis of data published by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) shows that while the number of pending cases under the Act has been growing each year, only a handful have resulted in completed trials or convictions.

Specific data on violations of the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, which fall under the broader category of "offences against the state", have been made available by the NCRB since 2014 in its annual "Crime in India" reports, with the latest such report published for 2024.

In the 11-year-period from 2014 to 2024, a total 699 cases of violations of the Act have been reported at an average rate of 64 cases per year. The number of cases per year has

• Violations of Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act
• Cases reported



dipped below 50 in a single year only in the Covid-affected years of 2020 and 2021, with most cases reported in 2022 at 87. In

2024, the latest year for which data is available, there were 57 cases.

However, as a rate per lakh population, the number of such violations have been negligible compared to other criminal offences.

But the data shows that neither the police nor the judiciary has been able to address these violations, with an average 48 cases pending investigation and an average 221 cases pending trial at year-end between 2014 and 2024.

In 2024, as many as 53 such cases were pending police investigation, including cases from previous years, and 358 cases were pending trial at the end of the year.

In 2014, there were 77 cases

reported during the year and another 7 pending from previous years. That year, the police submitted chargesheets in 45 cases, accounting for 53.6% of all cases investigated by the police. In subsequent years, the chargesheeting rate only fell, including to as low as 31.3% in 2020 and 36.5% in 2024.

From 2014 to 2024, a total of 1,102 people have been arrested in cases of violations of the Act—2020 alone saw 405 arrests, while there were 59 arrests in 2024. A total 962 individuals were chargesheeted in the same period, including 326 in 2023 alone, and 66 in 2024.

As far as the courts are concerned, in each year from 2014 to 2024, the number of cases pending trial at year-end has

consistently risen. In 2014, the year ended with 85 cases pending trials; this figure rose to 358 in 2024 for a four-fold increase over 11 years. But on average, just 43 cases have been sent to trial each year, peaking at 52 in 2017 and dropping to 38 by 2024.

Another significant point is that in each year from 2014 to 2024, the number of acquittals has exceeded the number of convictions. In 2024, for instance, the number of cases that ended in convictions stood at 6, while 10 cases saw acquittals. The highest number of convictions came in 2017 at 8 cases, though in 2020 and 2022 there were no convictions at all.

As a share of total cases sent to trial, no more than 16% of

cases ended in a conviction in a single year between 2014 and 2024.

In this 11-year period, a total of 105 cases ended in acquittals and discharges, while just 44 cases ended in convictions. From 2014 to 2024, just 60 individuals were convicted and as many as 153 were acquitted or discharged. In 2024, there were 6 convictions and 25 acquittals.

Moreover, the pendency rate of such cases has been about 40% in all but two years between 2014 and 2024. But even in those two years, the pendency rates were 89.7% in 2016 and 88.2% in 2017. In 2024, the pendency rate had hit 95.2%, just below the peak of 98.4% in 2022.

NEET UG paper leak: CBI files charges against 13 accused

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

THE CBI on Tuesday filed a charge-sheet against 13 accused persons in the 2026 NEET UG paper leak case. The charge sheet will be heard by the fast track court of Special Judge Anu Grover Baliga of Rouse Avenue Court on Wednesday.

The 13 have been accused of criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust, destruction of evidence among other BNS provisions, and for offences under the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024.

The CBI has cited 360 witness, 42 documents and 43 material objects in its charge-sheet. Questions were leaked allegedly by NTA panel member and translator PV Kul-karni, it said. After this, Shivraj Motegaonkar, who runs a coaching institute in Latur, allegedly obtained the questions on the premises of Siddhivinyay Hospital run by accused Manoj Bhagwanrao Shirure.

The CBI has claimed that the hospital complex was used to "facilitate access to a chemistry question paper in April 2026," weeks prior to the exam. Till date, it has made multiple arrests in the case, including teachers and students from Delhi, Jaipur, Gurgaon, Nashik, Pune, Latur and Ahilyanagar.

BJP rejects report on Govt's offer to CJP to change Pradhan portfolio

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

THE RULING BJP on Tuesday said *The Indian Express* report "Before Dharmendra Pradhan quit, Centre offered to change his ministry, CJP said no" was "completely baseless, entirely fictional and unfounded."

"Today, as the official spokesperson of the party, after reviewing the entire matter, I want to make it absolutely clear that this report published is completely baseless. It is entirely fictional and unfounded. This news has no basis," BJP spokesperson Sambit Patra told media persons on Tuesday morning. *The Indian Express* had on Tuesday reported that before Pradhan submitted his resignation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday, the government had proposed a change in his portfolio as a compromise solution to the CJP.

UP: Two suspended after girl found locked in classroom

Meerut: A headmaster, Rajeev Kumar, and an assistant teacher, Umesh Kumar, of the government-run Primary School Bahadurpur No. 1 in UP's Meerut have been suspended with immediate effect after a Class 5 student was found locked in a classroom for several hours, officials said on Tuesday.

District Basic Shiksha Adhikari Asha Chaudhary also directed that adverse entries be recorded in the service records of three assistant teachers and issued them warnings. PFI

PU scholar dies of electrocution on campus, students protest

Sukriti Chawla
Chandigarh, July 28

A WOMAN PhD scholar at Panjab University's (PU) Department of Microbiology died after allegedly being electrocuted on the campus on Tuesday, triggering massive protests from the students.

The incident occurred around 9.15 am when Jyoti Yadav (27) was on her way to the department from her hostel. Students said that she took an unpaved pathway and came into contact with an electric wire near the gate of Girls' Hostel No. 8 while walking through stagnant rainwater. She collapsed and was rushed to Government Multi-Specialty Hospital, Sector 16, where doctors declared her dead.

A resident of Kakrala village in Haryana's Mahendergarh, Jyoti, a fourth year scholar, was reportedly on way to submit the annual progress report to her supervisor when the incident occurred. She had completed her Bachelor of Science from the University of Delhi before pursuing a Master's degree from the Central University of Haryana.

Police registered an FIR against unknown persons for causing death by negligence. Family members said she was a good and neurotic person. While her uncle Jitender Yadav and other relatives reached Chandigarh after being informed of the incident, her parents rushed from their home-



Students protest outside Panjab University's V-C office on Tuesday; (right) the 27-year-old victim, Jyoti Yadav. KAMLESHWAR SINGH

town. The family has refused to accept the death, seeking clarity on the exact cause of her death. They have also sought a CBI investigation into the incident.

Meanwhile, the death sparked protest outside the office of Vice-Chancellor Renu Vig, with students demanding accountability from the university administration.

They sought action against officials of the university's Executive Engineer (XEN) of office, constitution of an audit committee to examine campus infrastructure, adequate compensation for the victim's family, suspension of the Chief Security Officer and the Vice-Chancellor's resignation.

University officials, however, said the exact cause of death was yet to be ascertained and said that the possibility of electrocution appeared low.

"The electric pole is 12-13 feet away, and all the wires are covered," said Lakhwinder Singh, SDE, Panjab University, adding that the area had been barricaded and an investigation was underway.

However, around 9.15 pm, tensions further escalated on the campus as students broke through both the inner and outer gates of the Vice-Chancellor's office.

The university authorities had discussed a compensation of Rs 16 lakh for the family and



a non-teaching job for her brother. However, the students and the deceased's family sought a higher compensation and the resignation of the Registrar and the XEN of the university.

Even as Vig assured protesters that necessary action would be taken and a committee would be constituted to look

into the issues raised by students, Gaurav Veer Sohal, president, Panjab University Campus Students' Council (PUCS), called the incident an "institutional murder" and demanded Vig's resignation.

As a precautionary measure, students also urged the authorities and the Chandigarh Electricity Department to temporarily disconnect power supply to the university's Sector 14 and Sector 25 campuses.

They said that the university had ignored repeated complaints about safety concerns and pointed out that the South Campus lacked a dispensary despite several representations.

Gurnoor, a PU student, said that they would not let any postmortem to be conducted until the authorities agree to their demands.

Chandigarh MP Manish Tewari expressed grief over the death of the scholar and demanded culpable homicide not amounting to murder charges be added to the FIR. "Extremely saddened at the demise of a young PhD scholar because of electrocution at PU. My condolences to the family," said the Congress MP on X.

"The news has shocked us. We completed all immediate procedural formalities when the family members were yet to arrive," said Prof Naveen Gupta, Chairperson of the Department of Microbiology.

WITH INPUTS FROM
ASMITA MAINI

• BRIEFLY



The accident site in J&K's Ganderbal on Tuesday. SHUAB MASOODI

JAMMU AND KASHMIR

39 Amarnath Yatra pilgrims injured as bus falls into gorge in Ganderbal

THIRTY-NINE AMARNATH Yatra pilgrims were injured on Tuesday after their bus fell into a gorge in Gund village along Srinagar-Baltal road in Jammu and Kashmir's Ganderbal. Police said the bus, carrying around 40 pilgrims, skidded off the road and fell into a gorge after the driver failed to negotiate a curve. "... 39 pilgrims returning after Darshan of Baba Barfani sustained injuries and are undergoing treatment at SKIMS. I have directed health officials to ensure best possible medical care. I pray to Lord Shiva for the speedy recovery of the injured devotees," J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha wrote on X. ENS

Family of 5 killed in road accident in Himachal

FIVE MEMBERS of a family were killed after their car plunged into a deep gorge near Lahad in Chamba district, Himachal Pradesh, on Monday night while returning home after taking their three-month-old baby to Chandigarh's Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research for treatment, officials said. Their Alto skidded off the Bhamaur-Pathankot NH amid heavy rain, fog, and poor visibility. Officials identified the victims as Bachan Singh, his son Ripan Kumar, Ripan's wife Rimpy, their three-month-old daughter, and Bachan Singh's niece Keerti. ENS

16 Maoists surrender before Jharkhand cops

SIXTEEN MAOISTS, including top commanders active in the Kolhan-Saranda region as well as Latehar district, surrendered before the Jharkhand Police in Ranchi on Tuesday, police said, adding that six of them carried a combined bounty of Rs 39 lakh. Those who surrendered included a Regional Committee Member, three Zonal Committee members, three Sub-Zonal Committee members, six Area Committee members, and three other cadres. The surrendered weapons comprised six INSAS rifles, two AK-47 rifles, as well as one each HK-33 rifle, US Carbine and M-16 rifle. ENS

Hyderabad: IPS trainee accused of assault and sexual harassment held

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 28

THE HYDERABAD police has taken trainee IPS officer M Uday Krishna Reddy into custody for allegedly sexually harassing another IPS trainee, senior officers said. Both the complainant and the accused were probationers at the National Police Academy (NPA) in Hyderabad.

Reddy was a constable with the Andhra Pradesh Police before he resigned in 2019 and cracked the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) exam in 2024. He was also congratulated by Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

A complaint by the woman IPS trainee, dated July 18, alleged that Reddy harassed her by sending "sexually abusive messages" on WhatsApp. She also alleged that he made derogatory remarks about her in front of other NPA trainees. The alleged harassment had been underway since June 23, the complainant had said. Reddy has rejected the allegations.

The complainant further alleged that Reddy repeatedly accused her of being "in a relationship with another trainee"

on what she claimed were "completely baseless" grounds.

She also alleged that he forcibly accessed her personal mobile phone after making her unlock the device. He "blackmailed me to show my personal messages to him", the complainant alleged.

"On July 9...", he restrained my movement and forced me to go to his room and grabbed me by my hair and tried to strangle me...", the complainant said. It further accused Reddy of having held a knife against the complainant's neck and "did not allow me to leave his room". She added that he allegedly physically assaulted her again on July 10.

"He recorded a private video without my consent or knowledge and sent it to my husband to blackmail me. He further tried to tarnish my image by false and degrading information," she alleged in her complaint. An FIR was later registered. Following the FIR, Krishna Reddy wrote on his Instagram page, "The complaint and rumours against me are baseless and untrue. I fully trust the legal process and believe justice will prevail."

EXPRESS special

177 cases, 312 arrests in a year: Mathura villages emerging as new hub of organised cyber fraud

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 28

ON THE morning of July 7, eight Mathura villages woke up to a strange sight — hundreds of people scampering across fields and narrow lanes, with policemen and drones in hot pursuit. "When the police teams arrived, several people fled," one police officer told *The Indian Express*. "After long hours of questioning, 42 people were arrested."

The raids were part of a police crackdown on the growing network of cybercrimes in Mathura. Investigators claim that over the last few years, Mathura has emerged as a major cybercrime hub, with a large network recruiting locals and operating from villages, earning the district the moniker "Mini Jamtara". Police claim to have registered 177 cyber fraud cases over the past year, and arrested 312 suspects. The latest crackdown has been driven largely by digital leads generated through the MHA's cybercrime platforms, including National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal and Samanvay Portal, with investigators saying some 7,000 cellphone numbers and 1,400 bank accounts have been traced to these villages.

The raids ranged from alleged masterminds to recruited operatives, reflecting what police describe as a highly organised network with cells across India. The latest raids came three years after a report by the Future Crime Research



Police personnel with the accused arrested on July 7. EXPRESS

Foundation, an IIT Kanpur-incubated startup, showed that Rajasthan's Bharatpur and Uttar Pradesh's Mathura have replaced Jharkhand's Jamtara and Haryana's Nuh as the top cybercrime hubs in India.

According to the study, Bharatpur (18%), Mathura (12%), Nuh (11%), Deogarh, Jharkhand (10%), Jamtara, Jharkhand (9.6%), Gurgaon (8.1%), Alwar, Rajasthan (5.1%), Bokaro, Jharkhand (2.4%), Karmatand, Jharkhand (2.4%) and Giridih, Jharkhand (2.3%) are the top contributors to cybercrime cases in India, collectively accounting for 80% of the incidence. Police claim to have "significantly disrupted cyber fraud networks" operating across the district.

"Raids continue to be carried out based on cybercrime complaints and intel inputs. The operations have considerably reduced the scale of the networks," Mathura SSP Shlok Kumar said.

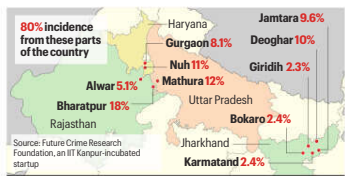
Another officer said, "The scale of the operation is difficult

to estimate. The operations function like small-scale industries, with young people increasingly turning to cybercrime instead of pursuing education or conventional jobs, attracted by the prospect of easy money without physical labour."

Investigators claim to have mapped 18 villages under the Govardhan, Barsana, Shergarh, Chhata and Kosi police stations, which they believe serve as operational bases for an organised online scam network. Most of these villages are nestled along the borders of Rajasthan and Haryana — two states that, as per the 2023 study, are major cybercrime hubs. Mathura Police claim that the proximity to at least three of these hubs — Bharatpur (40 km away), Nuh (107 km) and Alwar (111 km) — has contributed to the problem.

Most of the villages on the police radar are about 70 km from Mathura city, three hours from Delhi and an hour from Agra. Investigators claim that, of the 312

• Top 10 contributors to cybercrime



arrested in raids over the past year, many have records on the centralised cybercrime Samanvay Portal. In several cases, cellphone numbers and bank accounts had been linked to cyber fraud complaints on the NCRP portal, and FIRs registered in several states and districts.

Police said that cybercrime networks operate through well-defined cells across India, with groups handling specific roles and getting a fixed share of the proceeds. Typically, a group is allegedly responsible for logistics — arranging mobile accounts, SIM cards and forged ATM cards — another scouts for targets and makes phone calls, while a third makes the withdrawals.

The fraud rings were using online marketplaces such as OLX to identify targets and steal money through QR code payment tricks, fake advance deposits and impersonation, to fake hotel bookings using cloned websites and phishing messages to trick people into paying for

non-existent reservations. The groups allegedly used encrypted messaging platforms such as Telegram for logistical support.

In most cases, the fraud was allegedly conducted in fields, the open terrain allowing suspects to watch for approaching law enforcement vehicles. Investigators say the geography, combined with the proximity of two state borders, gives suspects operationalist to escape, highlighting challenges authorities face in dismantling such networks.

On why cyber fraud persists in Mathura, investigators claim that the networks constantly adapt, exploiting new technologies, communication platforms and financial channels to stay ahead of law enforcement. The groups rely on fake identities, mule accounts, prepaid SIM cards and encrypted messaging services while continually changing their tactics and recruiting new members.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• THE ORAL THERAPY CALLED SHETA2 TARGETS THE VIRUS'S CANCER-CAUSING PROTEINS; IT COULD OFFER A NEW TREATMENT OPTION AFTER LARGER HUMAN TRIALS

ICMR's cervical cancer pill shows promise by stopping HPV from turning cancerous

Annona Dutt
New Delhi, July 28

IN A few years, a capsule may be all it will take to halt cervical cancer in its tracks. The oral therapy called SHETA2 cannot prevent the human papillomavirus infection — persistent HPV infection is known to cause 85% of cervical cancer cases — but it can block the virus's cancer-causing proteins, thereby preventing pre-cancerous and cancerous lesions.

Cervical cancer is one of the two cancers caused by infections and, therefore, is preventable through vaccination. It is the second most common type

of cancer among women in India, affecting over 79,000 of them and killing 36,319 in 2024, according to Global Cancer Observatory data. Cervical cancer accounts for over 10% of all cancers among women and 5.1% of all cancers in the Indian population, the data shows.

SHETA2 is a small molecule therapy that is designed to stop an HPV infection from causing cancer. Small molecule therapies are chemically manufactured, low-weight compounds that can easily be absorbed by the body. Manufacturing them is also easy and cost-effective.

This therapy targets three proteins in the human body —

mortalin, heat shock cognate (hsc70) and glucose-regulated protein 78 (Grp78). These are essential for the proliferation of the cancer-causing oncoprotein of the virus.

"It works by breaking the connection between the HPV-E7 protein and a host protein inside human cells. Normally, this host protein protects E7 and allows it to keep damaging healthy cells. When SHETA2 breaks this connection, the harmful E7 protein is destroyed by the body's normal immune defences," explains Dr Showket Hussain, a senior scientist from ICMR Na-

tional Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research. This mechanism also ensures that the therapy selectively affects the cancer cells while sparing the normal ones.

Who needs to take it?

The therapy is meant for those who have developed pre-cancerous lesions of cervical cancer. "Based on current preclinical evidence, it has potential applications in treating high-grade cervical intraepithelial neoplasia (cancerous lesions that are likely to turn into cancer if left untreated) and invasive cervical



The therapy has, at present, been evaluated in an oral, capsule form

cancer. Phase II clinical studies will determine the exact patient population and stage at which it is most effective," says Dr Hus-

sain. The therapy has, at present, been evaluated in an oral, capsule form. However, researchers are now exploring localised delivery mechanisms such as a vaginal suppository. "This will maximise the concentration of the drug in the cervix while reducing exposure across the body," says Dr Hussain.

While the Stephenson Cancer Center, University of Oklahoma, discovered and developed the treatment, ICMR-NICPR evaluated its efficacy in pre-clinical studies and validated its mechanism of action. Both institutions collaboratively hold the intellectual property rights for the therapy.

After the pre-clinical and early clinical trials of the therapy, it has been transferred to researchers for further development. The company will now be responsible for carrying out larger human trials before making the therapy available in the market. "These trials may take up to five years," says Dr Hussain.

The final cost of the therapy is yet to be determined. It will depend on the cost of clinical trials, manufacturing, regulatory approvals and commercialisation strategies for the product.

"However, as an orally administered small-molecule drug, it is expected to be con-

siderably more affordable than many biologic or immunotherapy-based cancer treatments. It may reduce the need for hospitalisation, prolonged hospital visits, or infusion-based care, as the medication may be taken at home," says Dr Hussain.

Tests such as pap smear, HPV DNA — or even the simple visual inspection with acetic acid — can detect the precancerous lesions. Early detection is necessary for early treatment, which can improve the outcomes. The SHETA2 therapy, when it becomes available, is also likely to be given to patients who have been diagnosed with these lesions or cancer.

POLLS IN PAKISTAN-OCCUPIED KASHMIR

Cosmetic electoral exercise by Pak to camouflage illegal occupation: India

Divya A
New Delhi, July 28

INDIA HAS described the on-going elections in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK), which started on Monday, as an attempt by Islamabad to camouflage its illegal occupation and hide its "grave" human rights violations in the region.

"The current cosmetic electoral exercise is nothing but an attempt by Pakistan to camouflage its illegal occupation and hide its grave human rights violations in the region," said Randhir Jaiswal, official spokesperson, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), on Tuesday, in response to a question during a media briefing.

He reiterated that the entire Union Territories of Jammu and Kashmir, and Ladakh, including the areas currently under Pakistan's "illegal and forcible occupation", are parts of India. "The ongoing mass protests in Pakistan-occupied Jammu & Kashmir are the direct consequences of Pakistan's economic exploitation, its denial of the people's fundamental rights, and its administrative oppression," he said.

The ruling Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) won nine out of 13 seats in the first phase of elections held in PoK, authorities declared on Tuesday, as per reports. There were allegations of massive rigging in the first phase of the polls held on Monday, which the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) — the coalition partner in the ruling alliance — won the remaining seats.

The elections for 45 constituencies

Vijay urges Modi to review Govt's Mekedatu dam stand

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 28

EVEN AS he awaits a response from Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar for a proposed meeting on the immediate release of Cauvery water, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has drawn a firm constitutional line on another, much larger question: the proposed Mekedatu dam.

In a detailed letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi Monday, Vijay urged the Union government to withdraw a recent parliamentary reply by the Ministry of Jal Shakti, arguing that it overlooks settled legal principles governing interstate rivers and the rights of downstream States.

The intervention is significant as it separates two disputes that often become politically intertwined. One concerns Tamil Nadu's immediate demand for water during a distress monsoon year. The other concerns Karnataka's long-term proposal to construct the Mekedatu balancing reservoir. While the CM has sought political dialogue with Karnataka on the first issue, his letter to the PM makes



Tamil Nadu CM C. Joseph Vijay

clear that the second must remain firmly anchored in the legal architecture created by the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal and the Supreme Court. Vijay wrote that he wished to draw the PM's attention to the Government's reply in Rajya Sabha stating that the top court's judgment of February 16, 2018, "does not expressly stipulate that Karnataka should obtain consent of the lower riparian States before constructing a structure across the River Cauvery." Calling that response "disappointing", Vijay said it appeared to have been issued "without taking into consideration the prevailing legal position and settled law with regard to the consent of the lower riparian states."

To support his argument, Vijay cited the Constitution

Bench judgment in State of Karnataka vs State of Andhra Pradesh relating to the Alamatti dam dispute. Quoting paragraph 100 of the judgment, he reminded the PM that the top court had held: "Nor can Karnataka be permitted to construct up to that height without the consent of all other riparian States as well as without approval of the Central Government."

The CM argued that the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal's final award, later affirmed with modifications by the apex court in 2018, similarly limits powers of basin States. He pointed out that Clause XVII of the Tribunal Award permits each State to regulate waters within its territory only "in a manner not inconsistent with the order of the Tribunal." Vijay said any new project capable of affecting the regulated flow of the river must therefore first be examined for consistency with the Tribunal Award. The letter goes beyond citing legal provisions and attempts to demonstrate how the Tribunal has interpreted such principles in practice.

Vijay referred to Kerala's Pambur hydro-electric project,

where the Tribunal required Kerala and Tamil Nadu to jointly agree upon release schedules despite the project involving only 0.1 thousand million cubic feet of consumptive use. "This demonstrates that the Tribunal attached paramount importance not merely to annual quantities but also to coordinated regulation of releases affecting lower riparian interests," he wrote.

He referred to Clause XI of the Award, which prohibits any upper riparian State from taking actions affecting scheduled deliveries to downstream States except through mutual agreement and consultation with the regulatory authority. Clause XX, he said, recognises that modifications to the Award can be achieved only through agreement among the basin States. For that reason, he argued that the proposed Mekedatu project "cannot be evaluated merely as an engineering proposal."

The CM also pointed out that the Central Water Commission had returned Karnataka's Detailed Project Report submitted in 2019 for revision.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM



BJP leaders Ravi Shankar Prasad and Pawan Singh hold a roadshow in support of party candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha ahead of the Bankipur Assembly by-poll, as RJD supporters cross paths in Patna, Tuesday.

Kishor's 'AI video' claim, Nitin Nabin's temple visits mark busy last day of Bankipur campaign

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 28

CAMPAINING FOR the Bankipur Assembly bypoll ended on Tuesday, with parties making a final push in what has emerged as a triangular contest with Jan Suraj Party (JSP) founder Prashant Kishor entering the fray against the BJP and RJD candidates.

The bypoll was necessitated after long-time Bankipur MLA Nitin Nabin joined the Rajya Sabha following his elevation as BJP national president earlier this year. On Tuesday, Nabin visited temples across the constituency as he stayed in the forefront of the campaign for party candidate Neeraj Kumar Sinha. Tuesday also saw RJD leader Tejashwi Prasad Yadvav leading a roadshow with party candidate Rekha Gupta. Tejashwi, who joined the campaign after returning from an overseas trip, questioned the BJP's development record in the constituency it has held continuously since 1995.

Prashant Kishor held a series of mohalla meetings on the last day of campaigning. Kishor courted controversy by alleging that a video appeal by former Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar seeking votes for the BJP was AI-generated.

"I challenge the BJP. If it proves the video is genuine, I will withdraw from the race. It is shameful that the BJP is using the name of Nitish Kumar, who is not in good health. This reflects the BJP's desperation to retain its so-called fort of Bank-

ipur," Kishor said. Claiming that the Election Commission had intervened to help Jeevika workers out of the BJP's campaign, Kishor urged voters to turn the bypoll into a "referendum against the BJP and Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary." He also asserted that the BJP would no longer be able to rely on its traditional caste arithmetic.

The BJP, however, maintained that the contest was a "no contest", and that only the victory margin remained to be decided.

Nabin, along with Samrat Choudhary, had held a roadshow in Patna on Monday. On the final day of campaigning, Nabin visited several temples, including the Kali Temple near Baansghat, the Panchmukhi Hanuman Temple on Boring Road and the Shiv Temple at Boring Road Crossing.

The party also deployed senior NDA leaders from the Chandravanshi community, including Assembly Speaker Prem Kumar, minister Pradeep Chandravanshi and former JD(UP) MP Chandeshwar Prasad Chandravanshi, to campaign in Mithapur, which has a sizeable Chandravanshi population. Union Minister and Lok Janashakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief Chirag Paswan also addressed public meetings in support of the BJP candidate.

Bankipur, with its sizeable middle-class electorate, trading community and distinct caste composition, the bypoll is being closely watched as an indicator of urban sentiment in Bihar.

Pak Gen Z should focus on India's demand to end state-sponsored cross-border terror: MEA

Divya A
New Delhi, July 28

RESPONDING TO reports claiming that Pakistan's Gen Z groups showed their support for last week's student protests at Jantar Mantar, India on Tuesday said the focus should instead be on Pakistan ending state-sponsored cross-border terrorism.

"We are all aware that Pakistan has been sponsoring cross-border terrorism against India for several decades," said Randhir Jaiswal, Official Spokesperson, Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), at a media briefing.

"The people of India, including Gen Z, have been demanding that Pakistan end its state-sponsored cross-border terrorism. We hope their

counterparts are taking due note," he said.

He was asked about Pakistani Gen Z praising their Indian counterparts during the recent protests in Delhi and other cities.

Last week, Pakistan's Foreign Ministry had declined to comment on the protests in India and said the demonstrations were an internal matter. "This is an internal matter of India. We do not offer comments on such matters," Pakistani Foreign Minister spokesperson Tahira Andrabi had said. However, several Pakistani youth voiced their support for the Coochbehar Janta Party-led protests through social media, posting messages of solidarity and drawing parallels between the shared histories of India and Pakistan.

Last week, Pakistan's Foreign Ministry had declined to comment on the protests in India and said the demonstrations were an internal matter. "This is an internal matter of India. We do not offer comments on such matters," Pakistani Foreign Minister spokesperson Tahira Andrabi had said. However, several Pakistani youth voiced their support for the Coochbehar Janta Party-led protests through social media, posting messages of solidarity and drawing parallels between the shared histories of India and Pakistan.

During the media briefing, while responding to a question on Pakistan's attempts to invoke the shared legacy of the Indus Valley Civilisation, Jaiswal said Islamabad's record on terrorism and minority rights undermines such claims. "Let me put this straight: a country which has been pro-

moting cross-border terrorism, which has been promoting religious fundamentalism and violence for decades, cannot have any claim to any pluralistic cultural legacy. Their abysmal track record on the protection of minorities and their cultural rights makes such desperate attempts look even more phoney," Jaiswal said.

Pakistan's Information and Broadcasting Minister Attaullah Tarar had recently described the Indus Valley Civilisation as central to Pakistan's national identity, in the wake of India moving to put the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance following the terrorist attack in Pahalgam in April last year, killing 26 civilians.

India has repeatedly stated that Pakistan's state-sponsored cross-border terrorism has eroded the basis for the treaty, and it cannot be viewed in isolation.

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Centre declares 56,825 sq km of Western Ghats as eco-sensitive area

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 28

THE CENTRE has issued a seventh iteration of a draft notification declaring 56,825.7 square kilometre of Western Ghats, the biodiversity hotspot spread across Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu, as an ecologically sensitive area (ESA).

The fresh draft was issued on Monday — the day sixth iteration lapsed due to a continuing deadlock between the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC) and the states concerned over the demarcation of ESAs.

The ESAs proposed across these states are spread over 449 sq km in Gujarat, 17,340 sq km in Maharashtra, 1,461 sq km in Goa, 20,668 sq km in Karnataka, 6,994 sq km in Tamil Nadu, and 9,993 sq km in Kerala.

While Gujarat and Goa have largely agreed upon an area to be finalised as ESA, Maharashtra's fresh revised proposal is under appraisal. Karnataka continues to oppose the draft notification, while the Centre is still resolving sticking points and information discrepancies with Kerala and Tamil Nadu, respectively.

The Centre has also given a year's extension to an expert

committee, formed in April 2022, which continues to examine the views of the six state-holder state governments, keeping in view the conservation aspects of the disaster-prone ecosystem, as well as rights, privileges, needs and developmental aspirations of the region. The tenure of the expert committee, headed by Sanjay Kumar, ex-Director General of Forest, MoEFCC, was extended till July 2027 late last month.

As in the previous one, the latest draft notification also recommended a complete ban on mining, quarrying and sand mining in ESAs as well as phasing out of all existing mines within five years from the date of the final notification or expiry of the lease, whichever is earlier.

It also recommends prohibition of new thermal power plants and expansion of existing ones in ESAs. Further, 'red' category or the most polluting industries and their expansion is also proposed to be banned in ESAs. New and expansion projects of building and construction with built-up area of 20,000 sq metres and above, and all new and expansion township projects with area over 50 hectares and above, shall also be prohibited in the draft notification stated.

Bedding, utensils in hand, farmers march to Bhopal

Seek 100% moong procurement at MSP as against the current 25%

Express News Service
Bhopal, July 28

CARRYING SACKS of grain, rolled-up bedding, cooking utensils and enough food to last a week, nearly 2,000 farmers marched into the outskirts of Bhopal on Tuesday after breaking through police barricades at the city's southern edge, escalating a crop procurement dispute into one of the biggest political confrontations faced by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav's government this year.

The farmers, representing 19 organisations under the banner of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM), have announced that they will not leave until the government agrees to procure 100% of the state's moong crop and addresses long-standing grievances over fertiliser distribution.

On Tuesday night, the procession reached districts located beyond the outskirts of Bhopal, where scores of policemen were deployed and attempted to stop them with multiple layers of barricades.

The farmers' march to Bhopal was triggered primarily by



Farmers, led by Samyukt Kisan Morcha (SKM), held the Kisan Kranti Padyatra from Narmadapuram to Bhopal on Tuesday. **R1**

demands for assured procurement of moong at the Minimum Support Price (MSP). Farmers' groups say that while the Centre has announced 100% MSP procurement for tur, urad and masur, moong procurement continues to be governed by the Price Support Scheme, under which procurement is generally capped at 25% of a state's estimated production. They argue that the ceiling leaves a large share of the open market, where prices are significantly below the MSP of Rs 8,768 per quintal for the 2026-27 season.

A farmer leader, Santosh Patwari, said, "We have been mobilising for over 20 days now. We had no option but to protest after we did not hear from the government despite sending multiple representations to the government. The farmers are unable to get a profitable rate for the sale of their moong produce, and we have no option but to go to the CM's residence."

The mobilisation began in Narmadapuram, where farmers first assembled at Sethani Ghat before beginning their march towards Bhopal. The administration initially prevented the procession from

moving, triggering a sit-in protest. As evening approached and tensions mounted, authorities removed the barricades, allowing the march to continue. On Tuesday, the convoy advanced through Obaidulla-ganj and Raisen district towards the capital. Police again erected barricades at several locations, including toll plazas and the Mandideep border, while officials urged farmer leaders to hand over a memorandum instead of proceeding into Bhopal.

The protest also reflects wider discontent in rural Madhya Pradesh. Farmers' organisations say procurement delays, quantity caps, registration problems and recurring fertiliser shortages have become common over successive crop seasons. With cultivation costs rising and market prices remaining uncertain, they argue that many growers are being forced into distress sales despite good production.

The agitation presents another political challenge for the Madhya Pradesh government, which only months ago was forced to dilute its proposed land-pooling policy for the 2028 Simhashta after sustained protests by farmers in Ujjain. Following weeks of demonstrations, the government revised several provisions of the policy and assured farmers that land would not be acquired without their consent.

SC pulls up Delhi Police and CBI over probe in Indiabulls promoters case

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

THE SUPREME COURT on Tuesday slammed the CBI and Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of Delhi Police over the lack of progress in investigation into allegations of round-tripping of funds, violations of the Companies Act, and siphoning of funds against the promoters of Indiabulls Housing Finance Limited (IHFL), now known as Sammaan Capital Limited.

A three-judge bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant initially proposed to summon the heads of the investigating agencies but did not do so after Additional Solicitor General S V Raju assured it that a status report will be filed.

"Owing to the negligence of CBI and EOW Delhi in not even filing a status report, and total failure to apprise this Court about steps taken for registration of RC (regular case) or investigation, we would have summoned the heads of these agencies but for the persuasion of ASG Raju, who assures that needful will be done and status report filed...", the bench, also comprising Justices Jaymya Bagchi and V Mohana, said in its order.

The bench was visibly annoyed after Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioners, said that following the CBI's affidavit filed in the

case in January this year, nothing had been brought on record to indicate the progress of the case.

Seeking the formation of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the matter, Bhushan also pointed out that one of the key accused, Sameer Gehlot, had moved to London. "We are now in July end," the CJ remarked, noting that no affidavit had been filed after the one lodged in January.

Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, meanwhile, said Gehlot had nothing to do with Sammaan Capital.

Raju, who appeared for the CBI, said the probe is on and the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) was pursuing it.

"What has CBI done from January to July?... Let them have courage to say because money (has been) returned, no offence is made out," CJ Kant remarked. ASG Raju said the witnesses were examined, adding that the agency is probing whether despite repayment of loans with interest, an offence had been committed.

To this, the bench asked, "Investigating agency doesn't know?"

The CJ then termed the situation "shocking" and said the probe agencies had been "silent" despite the gravity of the charges.

The bench said it will hear the matter next after the status report is filed.

Rain-soaked approach road of new Dehradun bridge caves in

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, July 28

SIXTEEN DAYS after a Rs 16-crore bridge was opened to the public in Dehradun, part of the road approaching it caved in on Tuesday, creating a massive crater just ahead of the bridge.

The bridge in Nanda Chowki over the Tons River was opened to the public on July 12. District Magistrate Ashish Chauhan said he instructed officials of the Public Works Department to repair the damaged portion and restore traffic within three hours.

He also directed that action be taken against the official concerned for negligence. It was found that due to heavy rainfall, soil had been washed away from beneath the approach road, leading to the collapse. The area is on the stretch connecting Uttarakhand's capital to Himachal Pradesh.

Congress's Suryakant Dhasmana, who was leading a sit-in protest at the site, sought the dismissal of PWD Minister Satpal Maharaj.

Rajesh Chandra, the Head of the Department at PWD, said water entered the structure, creating a vacuum and a cavity beneath the approach road. "The project cost is Rs 16 crore. We expect to fill the affected cavity within the next couple of hours, after which restoration work will continue," he said.

The reconstruction of the road was prompted after it was washed away on September 16, 2025, when Dehradun was hit by massive floods. "The stretch, operated by the NHAI (National Highways Authority of India), was handed over to us for repair," Chandra said.

He also said the damage is estimated at Rs 2 lakh. "The repair cost will be borne entirely by the contractor, Himalayan Construction. Since the project is still within the defect liability period, the contractor is contractually obligated to carry out the repair and restoration work at its own expense," he added.

Labourers who kept Spiti's roads clear now remain without work

Their work came to a halt despite labour court saying termination illegal

Saurabh Parashar
Shimla, July 28

EVERY SUMMER, as the snow recedes from the cold desert of Spiti, the race to reconnect its isolated villages begins. The roads that link settlements such as Kibber, Langza, Rangrik and Shogo to the outside world are often scarred by months of heavy snowfall, landslides and freezing temperatures. For years, restoring these lifelines fell largely to local daily-wage workers employed on Public Works Department (PWD) muster rolls.

However, in July 2023, their work came to an abrupt halt. "There was no written order. We were just told not to come from the next day," recalled Mentok Dolma, 35, of Pangmo village in Kaza sub-division, who had worked as a muster roll labourer with the PWD since 2020.

A Class XII graduate and mother of two, Mentok said the job which fetched her around Rs 12,000 a month was among the few reliable sources of income in the remote tribal region, where economic opportunities are scarce and winters stretch for nearly half the year. Her husband, Rinchen Tantiup, 42, is a regular PWD watchman.

Mentok was one among over 150 daily wageers, from Demul, Langza, Kibber, Komik, Rangrik and Shogo villages, who say they were also asked not to report for work in 2023. In October 2024, they approached the Himachal Pradesh Industrial Tribunal-cum-Labour Court, alleging that their services had been terminated orally without notice or retrenchment compensation in violation of the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.

The first relief only came last month. Presiding Judge Preeti Thakur of the Industrial Tribunal-cum-Labour Court decided the first batch of 41 cases, holding that the workers' termination was illegal as they had not been served the mandatory notice under Section 25F of the Industrial Disputes Act. The tribunal also accepted that the workers had completed 180 days of service within a running period of 12 calendar months.

On July 23, the state government published the awards in the Official Gazette. Yet, even after the favourable verdicts, the workers remain in limbo. Abhishek, executive engineer of PWD's Kaza Division, said that the department would challenge the awards.

"We have heard that the court has ruled in our favour, but we have not received any appointment order or any communication from the department," Mentok said. Standing in Kibber village, home to one of the world's highest post offices at an altitude of 14,200 feet, Nangial Cheering points to the muster roll register bearing the name



A link road connecting Kibber village with Kaza. **EXPRESS**

of his wife, Sonam Dikit, one of the workers whose services were discontinued.

"If a daily wageer in a tribal area completes 180 days of service with a government department, the worker becomes entitled to consideration for regularisation and the services cannot be terminated without prior notice. My wife completed 180 days long before was asked not to report for work," he said.

Nangial, himself a former PWD muster roll worker, said many officials assured them that they will be adjusted in the PWD or another department.

"We approached elected representatives as well, but nothing happened. Finally, we moved the Labour Court in October 2024. Some cases have been decided, while many are still pending," he said.

Nawang Champa, a resident of Tashigang village, said his wife, Logchang Ladzong, was among those removed from service. "For almost six months every year, the Kaza region remains under snow. Roads to villages such as Kibber, Langza, Rangrik and Shogo suffer damage every year and require constant maintenance. The department depends on local workers because they understand the terrain and the weather," he said.

"I had a hell of a challenge getting them [India] to sign on receiving failed asylum seekers... and I'm convinced it's because we had this high-profile case [of Nirav Modi] and we had another high-profile case at the time and until they [India] saw action and movement on those, guess what, they had some leverage over us, which was terribly frustrating," she said.

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Advocate Prateek Kumar, who represents 130 of the 150 workers before the tribunal, said the litigation covered only a fraction of those affected. "The larger concern is what happens after the judgments. Even workers who have secured favourable awards remain uncertain because the department has decided to challenge the orders," he said.

Superintending engineer Pradeep Singh Thakur said, "We have stopped hiring people on muster rolls, but road repair and construction work has not stopped. These works are now being carried out through Multi-Task-Purpose (MTP) workers."

He added that while the Border Roads Organisation maintains the national highway connecting Lahaul-Spiti with the rest of the country, the network of link roads connecting scattered villages continues to be maintained by the state PWD.

In identical awards, the tribunal directed that the petitioners be reinstated forthwith with continuity of service, seniority from the date of termination and full back wages. It also ordered that back wages be paid within three months of publication of the award in the Official Gazette, failing which they would carry interest at 9 per cent per annum.

The workers had also said that the department imposed artificial breaks in service to prevent them from completing the qualifying period, while retaining or regularising junior workers.

Appearing for the PWD, advocate Vandev Chandel argued that the workers were engaged only seasonally depending on weather, availability of funds and work requirements.

The tribunal ruled in favour of all 41 petitioners in the first batch.

India invites Nepal PM Balen Shah for an official visit

Divya A
New Delhi, July 28

INDIA ON Tuesday confirmed that an invitation has been extended to Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah for an official visit, even as there was no information on probable dates for the visit.

Speaking at the bi-weekly media briefing, Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for Ministry of External Affairs, said, "Invitation has been extended to Nepal PM Balen Shah to visit India."

Soon after Shah was elected in March this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had congratulated him in a post on X, and said that he looks forward to working closely with you (Shah) to take India-Nepal friendship and cooperation to even greater heights". It is learnt that a formal invite has been sent to the Nepalese PM's office through diplomatic channels.

In May, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri was proposed to visit Kathmandu, where he was expected to call on the Nepal PM, and hand over an invitation to PM Shah to visit India.

However, the visit was deferred as Shah had reportedly conveyed to his inner circle that he will not undertake any foreign visits in the near future — at least for the first 100 days of his term.

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Nirav Modi to be deported after legal proceedings end: MEA

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

RESPONDING TO reports about former British Home Secretary Priti Patel's claims that New Delhi has refused to take back thousands of illegal Indian migrants from the UK because London has not extradited Nirav Modi, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Tuesday said that the set procedure followed for the deportation of any person, and that paperwork is undertaken to establish citizenship.

"The legal proceedings against Nirav Modi are underway, and he will be deported once these proceedings conclude," said Randhir Jaiswal, MEA's official spokesperson. He reiterated that the Indian government remains "committed to bringing the fugitive offender back" to face due legal process. Nirav Modi is wanted in India to stand trial on fraud charges.

Patel said that as Home Secretary, during the Tory-led government between 2019 and

2022, the case complicated matters for her as India "would really push back" on taking visa overstayers.

"I had a hell of a challenge getting them [India] to sign on receiving failed asylum seekers... and I'm convinced it's because we had this high-profile case [of Nirav Modi] and we had another high-profile case at the time and until they [India] saw action and movement on those, guess what, they had some leverage over us, which was terribly frustrating," she said.

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BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Learning the right lessons at the bank

TWO MONTHS after an investigation in this paper revealed that HDFC Bank had camouflaged crores as marketing spend to pay higher interest to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation, the bank's board has initiated action. It has issued warning letters and imposed a penalty of Rs 1 lakh on three high-ranking officials — the managing director and chief executive officer, chief financial officer, and group head of retail assets. The action is unprecedented, and the board under a new chairman may be sending a signal down the line. But the saga raises troubling questions of corporate governance at the country's largest private bank.

On March 12, HDFC's audit committee of the board had ordered an "internal vigilance" into the Rs 45 crore paid to the corporation during 2023-24 and 2024-25. Earlier, an internal audit of the bank's marketing division for 2024-25 had marked out these payments, while rating the division's performance as "unsatisfactory". The investigation revealed this amount was the interest paid over the specified interest rate on deposits. While there is fierce competition among banks to attract deposits, the RBI's master directions on interest rates do not allow for rates to be negotiated between the parties. This "cherry-picking" of interest was not directly into the corporation's account as interest earned, but was channelled through the bank's marketing department, dressed up as contribution to awareness campaigns. On March 18, six days after the probe was ordered, the bank's then chairman, Atanu Chakraborty resigned, saying that "certain happenings and practices within the bank" were not in "congruence" with his personal values and ethics.

Given the seriousness of the matter, some questions must be asked. After this paper's investigation two months ago, in a note to stock exchanges the bank claimed that the "internal controls at the bank are robust". Its latest statement speaks of two such deposits, the earlier one is of 2017. Could there have been more such instances, flagged by internal audits and ignored by the board? Shouldn't the board review the audits of at least the last five years? This will ensure that the right lessons are learnt from this episode. The question also is whether or not oversight processes will be effective. Trust is central to the banking system. It needs to be nurtured. For that, all appropriate steps should be taken urgently.

On campus, questions about vendetta politics

THE ORDER to demolish 38 out of 40 buildings of Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur, Uttar Pradesh has raised serious questions. The chairman of the trust that runs the college is jailed Samajwadi Party leader Azam Khan. The university has been put in the dock by the district municipal authority, the income tax department and the fire department for alleged irregularities and violations in land acquisition, construction and permissions. The students protested the proposed demolition and were joined by the opposition parties, which have alleged that the UP government is targeting the university as a centre of vendetta politics. A stay order on the demolition by the Moradabad divisional commissioner on Monday provides a welcome pause. It is also a moment to look at the deeper malaise, of which this episode is a symptom.

India's education sector suffers from both a quality and quantity deficit. Less than 14 per cent of institutions possess NAAC accreditation, and curricula remain outdated for an ever-changing job market. Shortage of faculty — about 29 per cent in central universities and 40 per cent in state public universities — and low research output continue to plague public universities. On the other hand, the demand for education continues to grow. The state alone cannot bridge the gap. However, regulatory barriers for the entry of private players are such that political patronage and connections are often a sine qua non for establishing a university. From land acquisition to municipal permits, a maze of red tape stands in the way of letting competition flourish in the sector. This has also left many young people at the mercy of fly-by-night degree mills.

When it was set up, Khan was a powerful figure in UP. Over the last decade, his political fortunes have waned. The question for the UP administration is this: Does it abide by the rules, or merely serve the party in power? If Jauhar University has flouted the rules, it should not have been set up in the first place. Caught between under-regulation and over-enforcement, and between two governments, the students stand to lose the most.

For Higashino, moral ambiguity was plot twist

WHICH IS harder: Revisiting an unsolvable problem, or solving that problem? posits Keigo Higashino in *The Devotion of Suspect X*. The stupendous success of the murder mystery, and of the books that came after — *Salvation of Saint Malice*, *Invincible Heir*, *The Final Curtain*, among others — however, threw up a third tantalising possibility. Perhaps the hardest thing to recognise the moral ambiguity that underpins life — the things one can do for love or hate, out of guilt, shame, vengeance, and sacrifice. At a time when thrillers replace emotional depth with relentless pace, it was his exploration of what lies behind whodunits that made the 68-year-old Japanese writer, who died on Monday, a global phenomenon.

In part, of course, Higashino was following tradition. Unlike the gory threat of Nordic noir that has come to be a defining feature of the genre, or the French *roman policier*, he was falling back on the convention of the *honkaku mystery* — a form of crime fiction that emerged in Japan in the 1920s and relied on the cerebral over the corporeal aspects of a violent crime. But Higashino's achievement lay in his refusal to indulge certainties, breaking down, one deduction at a time, what circumstances made the crime conceivable and whether justice can ever be separated from fiction.

At its finest, crime fiction examines what happens when ordinary life is disrupted violently, when established mores are upended by an irreparable rupture. Higashino's appeal lay not just in the elegance of his solutions, remarkable though they often were, but in the fact that he trusted his readers — to grapple with ambiguity, to ask difficult questions — without pretending to offer definitive answers.

India among the powers: Forever rising, never risen?



RAJA MANDALA
By C RAJA MOHAN

SINCE CANADIAN Prime Minister Mark Carney called on the world's "middle powers" to collaborate amid growing turbulence in the international order, the idea has animated India's strategic debate. Official Delhi, however, has been less than enthusiastic.

Asked about Carney's formulation, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar argued that it may be more relevant to America's treaty allies in coping with President Donald Trump's unpredictable policies than to India. The middle-power label, he implied, understates India's geopolitical weight and its potential to emerge as a great power.

Yet scepticism about India's great-power prospects is growing. In his new book, *The Return of the Great Powers*, the Cambridge historian Brendan Simms places India in the category of "almost great powers", alongside France, Germany and Japan. They possess several great-power attributes, but not enough of them to be the world's system-shapers.

Whether or not one accepts Simms's classification, his larger argument deserves attention. He reminds us that international politics has always been driven by the interaction among great powers — through rivalry, as much as cooperation. The post-Cold War hope that globalisation, markets and international institutions would tame geo-

politics has proved to be short-lived. The wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, the sharpening US-China rivalry, and the weaponisation of trade, finance and technology all point to the return of hard power as the organising principle of world politics.

What, then, defines a great power? Simms offers an unapologetically material answer. Industrial strength, technological leadership, military capability, including nuclear weapons, the capacity to project force beyond one's borders, and the ability to influence war and peace in multiple theatres remain the essential attributes of great-power status.

Measured against these standards, India is clearly a power in transition rather than a completed one. It has continental scale, the world's largest population, nuclear weapons and one of the world's largest economies. Yet it still trails the US and China by a wide margin in per capita income, technological capability, manufacturing depth, military-industrial capacity and global military reach. India's economy, at around \$4 trillion, is impressive, but it remains far behind those of the US and China (at \$31 and \$20 trillion respectively).

Even if India overtakes Britain, Japan and Germany in aggregate GDP over the next decade, it will still be a distant third to America and China. Its per capita income remains below \$3,000, it continues to depend heavily on imported military technologies, and its investment in research and development remains modest compared to the world's technological leaders.

Simms is not alone in questioning whether that transition will happen. Michael Beckley of Tufts University advances an even more

sobering argument in a recent Foreign Affairs essay, "The Stagnant Order". He suggests that China may well be the last country to have made the leap into the front rank of global powers. Demographic ageing, slowing productivity and the concentration of economic power and advanced technologies in the US and China are making it progressively harder for latecomers from the Global South to catch up. India will remain an important global actor in world politics, Beckley argues, but is unlikely to become a true great power given its many domestic weaknesses, including a lack of necessary skills among its young demographic.

India's aspiration to great-power status, however, is hardly new. Long before Independence, Indian nationalists, including Jawaharlal Nehru, imagined India reclaiming a special place in world affairs. At Independence, despite widespread poverty, India was among the world's largest economies and possessed political institutions and human capital that suggested considerable promise. But India slowed as the East Asian tigers and China surged ahead. India's geopolitical drift in the second half of the 20th century towards the Soviet Union put Delhi on the losing side of the Cold War.

The reforms launched by P V Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh 35 years ago reversed that trajectory. Rapid economic growth and a diversification of India's great-power relations transformed international perceptions of India. Washington began to see Delhi not merely as a developing country but as a rising power capable of contributing to the Asian balance and the wider international order.

That optimism is now under a cloud. Global headwinds have

played a role but so have domestic policy choices. India has not built on the momentum generated by the growth in the first decade of the 21st century. Productivity growth has slowed, manufacturing has underperformed, investment in science and technology remains inadequate, and the next wave of structural reforms has stalled. The gap between India's geopolitical ambitions and its economic foundations has therefore widened.

The challenge is larger than economics. Deepening political polarisation, the resurgence of feudal and pre-modern forces, and growing strains on democratic institutions at home will weaken India's ability to deal with a rapidly changing world marked by sharpening geopolitical rivalry, less open markets, and the rise of disruptive technologies.

Pessimists worry that India may have missed its moment of opportunity in the early 21st century and will remain forever an emerging power — at odds with itself politically and growing at a suboptimal pace. Optimists are not ready to give up. They believe India's natural advantages and its people's talents can still be mobilised to accelerate its rise on the world stage. Such an outcome will depend on whether India can return to the unfinished business of economic, technological and social modernisation and boosting national unity and political cohesion. Only then can India move from being an "almost great power" to becoming one.

The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is a distinguished professor at the Motwani Jodha Institute of Advanced Studies, Jindal Global University and holds the Korea Foundation Chair in Asian geopolitics at the Council on Strategic and Defence Research

Our strategic imagination must look beyond geography



SYED ATA HASNAIN

FOR MUCH of its post-Independence history, India's strategic outlook was shaped by geography. The Himalayas, the Line of Control, the Indian Ocean and the immediate neighbourhood defined the security calculus. Pakistan and China dominated strategic discourse, while South Asia became the primary frame through which the external environment was viewed. That paradigm served India well when territorial defence and regional stability were the foremost concerns. But India today is the world's fourth-largest economy, an emerging technology power, a leading maritime nation and an increasingly influential voice in global affairs. Its interests have expanded far beyond its contiguous borders. Strategic thinking must now evolve at the same pace as the national transformation.

The 21st century is seeing a shift in the way nations perceive security and influence. Geopolitics is increasingly governed by what may be called the geometry of interests. Energy security begins in the Persian Gulf. Sea lanes stretching from the Strait of Hormuz to the Strait of Malacca sustain economic growth. Critical minerals originate in distant regions. Supply chains span continents. Strategic proximity is therefore no longer determined solely by physical distance but by connectivity, partnerships, technology, maritime reach and the ability to shape outcomes. This is why India's strategic horizon now extends from the Gulf and Central Asia to Southeast Asia and the Indo-Pacific.

Viewing India's external environment through the narrow prism of South Asia no longer reflects contemporary realities. China's rise spans technology, trade, infrastructure and maritime influence across the Indo-Pacific. Pakistan will continue to demand vigilance, but the long-term objective should be to reduce its ability to constrain India's wider strategic choices.

Bangladesh today is far more than an immediate neighbour. Its stability influences connectivity to the North-east, the security of the Bay of Bengal and India's eastern frontier. Developments in Afghanistan shape Central Asian connec-

tivity, counter-terrorism and regional stability. The Middle East has evolved from an energy source into a vital strategic partner. The Indo-Pacific has become the theatre where India's maritime aspirations, strategic partnerships and economic future converge. None of this diminishes the importance of the immediate neighbourhood. It places it within a broader strategic continuum.

India has an advantage often overlooked in strategic discourse — its civilisational legacy. As Governor of Bihar, I have often reflected on the enduring significance of Nalanda. Scholars travelled from across Asia not because India exercised coercive power, but because it commanded intellectual and cultural influence. This legacy carries contemporary relevance. Influence is rarely sustained by coercion alone. It is strengthened by credibility, openness and the willingness to create shared opportunities. India's engagement with Southeast Asia, the Gulf, Central Asia and Africa therefore rests not only upon economics and diplomacy but also upon historical links.

History offers many examples of rising powers whose emergence generated anxiety among neighbours. But India's rise has generally been viewed with confidence rather than apprehension. Its strategic autonomy, democratic institutions, developmental partnerships, humanitarian assistance and respect for sovereignty have contributed to this perception. That trust is one of India's greatest strategic assets and must be carefully preserved. The success of its foreign policy will be judged by whether it can shape a wider strategic environment that remains stable, connected and conducive to national development.

The task before us is to move from the geography of borders to the geometry of interests — and in doing so, align India's strategic imagination with the realities of its rise.

The essay is based on the Jasjit Singh Memorial Lecture at the Centre for Aerospace Power & Strategic Studies, delivered by the writer, who is a former commander of the Indian Army's Chin Corps and now Governor of Bihar



MEGHNA BAL

THE DELHI High Court's recent decision in *ANU v. OpenAI*. The first is interpreting copyright law in a technologically neutral manner. OpenAI contended that its activities qualified as research, an activity deemed non-infringing under the law. ANU's position, however, effectively confined the protection accorded to research to activities undertaken by human beings. The court rejected this distinction, observing that machines are increasingly capable of undertaking tasks that were once the sole remit of humans, including research. To deny protection simply because activities are machine-mediated would risk of stymieing social progress when these technologies ultimately operate at the behest of and for the benefit of humans.

By drawing parity between machine- and human-led activities, the court implicitly invokes technological neutrality — a core tenet of technology governance, which holds that the legal position of an activity should not change merely because technology alters the means through which it is undertaken. In the context of AI and copyright, this matters because research, analysis, and learning should not lose protections because humans are being assisted by machines. Otherwise, every technological advance could turn laws intended to encourage creativity and learning into barriers for innovation.

The second is the court's acknowledgement of dynamic ties between the technology and copyright industries. There is considerable evidence that AI is already augmenting creative activity. According to a study by Adobe, 83 per cent of creators now use AI for their work. A 2025 report by the London School of Economics finds that AI use in the creative industry has sparked dynamism — different sub-sectors have developed tailored tools, often built by start-ups. This is the kind of Cambrian explosion of innovation that lies at the heart of copyright law's purpose.

The third is when trying to reconcile the interests of AI developers and creators, begin by asking whether the particular use, in this case, AI training, is infringing at all, rather than presuming there is a compensable claim. Earlier this year, a committee constituted by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade proposed a direction on copyright and AI training that takes a position in favour of the latter. It proposed a licensing regime under which AI developers could use copyrighted works for training subject to compensation for rightsholders. This regime would raise the cost of developing models, with the burden falling particularly heavily on start-ups and smaller developers. And as AI tools become embedded in creative workflows, increasing the cost and uncertainty surrounding their development can also affect creators and creative businesses.

Rather than choosing between copyright owners and AI developers, the DPIIT panel must work to preserve the conditions under which both creative production and technological innovation can flourish.

Rather than choosing between copyright owners and AI developers, the DPIIT panel must work to preserve the conditions under which creative production and technological innovation can flourish. Treating their interests as antagonistic risks producing the outcome copyright law is intended to avoid: Protecting one form of creativity by constraining the emergence of another.

Delhi HC shows a better way to think about copyright & AI

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By drawing parity between machine- and human-led activities, the court implicitly invokes technological neutrality — a core tenet of technology governance, which holds that the legal position of an activity should not change merely because technology alters the means through which it is undertaken. In the context of AI and copyright, this matters because research, analysis, and learning should not lose protections because humans are being assisted by machines. Otherwise, every technological advance could turn laws intended to encourage creativity and learning into barriers for innovation.

The second is the court's acknowledgement of dynamic ties between the technology and copyright industries. There is considerable evidence that AI is already augmenting creative activity. According to a study by Adobe, 83 per cent of creators now use AI for their work. A 2025 report by the London School of Economics finds that AI use in the creative industry has sparked dynamism — different sub-sectors have developed tailored tools, often built by start-ups. This is the kind of Cambrian explosion of innovation that lies at the heart of copyright law's purpose.

The third is when trying to reconcile the interests of AI developers and creators, begin by asking whether the particular use, in this case, AI training, is infringing at all, rather than presuming there is a compensable claim. Earlier this year, a committee constituted by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade proposed a direction on copyright and AI training that takes a position in favour of the latter. It proposed a licensing regime under which AI developers could use copyrighted works for training subject to compensation for rightsholders. This regime would raise the cost of developing models, with the burden falling particularly heavily on start-ups and smaller developers. And as AI tools become embedded in creative workflows, increasing the cost and uncertainty surrounding their development can also affect creators and creative businesses.

Rather than choosing between copyright owners and AI developers, the DPIIT panel must work to preserve the conditions under which creative production and technological innovation can flourish. Treating their interests as antagonistic risks producing the outcome copyright law is intended to avoid: Protecting one form of creativity by constraining the emergence of another.

The writer is director of the Eya Centre, a tech policy think tank. Views are personal

40 YEARS AGO

July 29, 1986



BJP bandh in Delhi

SCATTERED VIOLENCE kept the capital tense during the bandh called by the Bharatiya Janata Party. The police fired in the air to disperse a mob in Moti Nagar, and a senior police officer was stabbed in Gole Market during the bandh against the killings at Muktsar in Punjab. Two persons were stabbed and several stoned while 14 TDC buses were damaged in violence.

Anti-apartheid push

THE FORTHCOMING Non-Aligned summit will call for united action to end the policy of

apartheid in South Africa, and effectively counter deteriorating international economic relations. This issue was raised during talks between Yugoslav Prime Minister Branko Mikulic and Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in New Delhi.

Chinese intruders build helipad

CHINESE INTRUDERS recently constructed a helipad in the Sumatran Rhin Valley south of Tawang district in Arunachal Pradesh to consolidate their position in the Indian valley. Chief Minister Gegong Apang told newsmen that the intruders, numbering about 150, had set up camps in the valley

and were trying to infiltrate into villages. Apang said he had apprised the Prime Minister of the Chinese intrusion and submitted a detailed report.

Uproar over PepsiCo plan

THE PROPOSED Punjab government-Pepsi Cola tie-up to bring the soft drink into India generated much heat in the Rajya Sabha during the question hour. Reviving a spate of supplementaries, Minister of Industry N D Tiwari said the report published in the Indian Express was substantially correct. The minister said the application was still to be considered by the Centre.

Street protest is resurrection of democratic politics, not insurrection against it



DESHKAAL
BY YOGENDRA YADAV

I STREET protest justified in a constitutional democracy? This question has been thrown at this columnist over the last fortnight, provoked by the argument advanced in this column that peaceful and democratic resistance rather than electoral contestation is the way forward for the Opposition. The entire ecosystem of the ruling establishment — the head of the BJP IT cell, the anchor-in-chief of darbari media and the academic spokesmen — has unleashed its fury at this argument and this author. The usual slurs follow: Anti-democratic, anti-constitutional and, of course, anti-national.

This criticism must not be dismissed with quick rebuttals. It is easy to point out that this attack stems from frustration, in the face of the largest youth protest in our times that has brought down the "pall of fear". Much of this critique is dishonest, too, for it conveniently omits the phrases "peaceful and democratic" in the original argument. There is staggering hypocrisy as well, when those who rose to power riding the most divisive rath yatra on the streets, bypassing the legal-constitutional order, start lecturing on institutional propriety. And then there is the delightful irony that those who opposed reservation and the very idea of social justice now invoke Babasaheb Ambedkar's plea against civil disobedience in independent India. Such reports may be effective. But they are not good answers to a real question.

So let us formulate this question and respond to it at its logical best. In a democratic street, it is justified to mobilise people for street protest to raise an issue, bypassing democratically elected representatives and constitutionally mandated institutions? Is this not an invitation to mobocracy — crowds that replace elected representatives, threaten institutions, hold decision-makers at ransom and force policy at gunpoint? Does this not open the doors for anarchy, a breakdown of constitutional order that would potentially hurt the marginalised sections

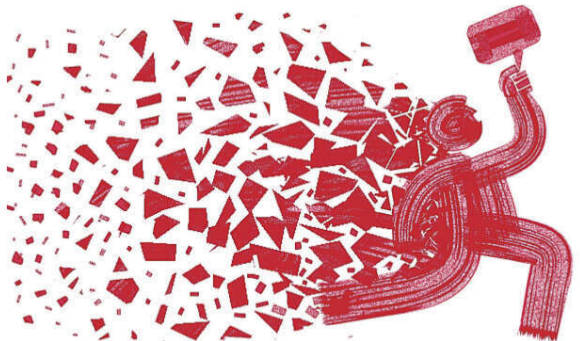


ILLUSTRATION: C R SAKSHI

most? Should we not defer to institutions, even if the outcomes are sub-optimal, in order to retain a framework for democratic resolution of disputes?

This seemingly innocuous line of questioning suffers from multiple flaws. It rests on a rosy picture of institutional functioning under a constitutional democracy. That is pure fiction, even in the liberal democracies of Europe and North America. Institutions are governed as much by balance of power as by the rule of law. And if institutions are less rule-governed than they pretend, crowds are more norm-governed than we like to believe. Mass mobilisations are not mad lynch mobs more often than not, these are informal assemblies guided by a shared purpose and bound by an unwritten moral code. Above all, these street protests do not substitute the formal constitutional order. As in the case of the Jantar Mantar protests, their demands are directed at the formal institutions of parliamentary democracy and are in no way a subversion of the constitutional order.

The counter-argument unfolds in four steps. First of all, historians tell us that before the inception of modern democracies, crowds were the bearers of popular norms and customary rights and acted as a mechanism for negotiating with the rulers. E. P. Thompson argued

that in the 18th century, English crowds were enforcing a "moral economy" against the emerging capitalist economy. So, liberal representative democracy did not invent popular participation in governance. Modern democracies have institutionalised practices that have long existed in the form of assemblies, petitions, public acclamations and collective protest by crowds.

Second, modern democracies do not and cannot eliminate the role of popular mobilisation or "contentious politics", to borrow Sidney Tarrow's formulation. These are silently woven into the texture of a functioning democracy. Besides the formal mechanism of responsiveness and accountability, a functioning democracy assumes a vibrant though informal process of collective action in which ordinary people make claims on governments, elites or other powerful actors through demonstrations, strikes, occupations, marches, boycotts or civil disobedience.

After studying collective action in Western Europe from the 16th to the 20th century, Charles Tilly concluded that popular movements are not symptoms of democratic failure. Rather, they are products of democracy's evolution. These are not antagonistic: Protest often leads to institutional reforms, while institutional open-

ings stimulate further mobilisation.

The third step is to recognise the special role of popular mobilisation in democracies of the Global South. In the 20th century, most countries of the world adopted a liberal democratic form, but the institutional scaffolding was not organic and thus very weak. In all such successful democracies, such as India, popular movements and public protests filled the vacuum left by fragile institutions. In Dipesh Chakrabarty's persuasive formulation, "multitude" — large public gatherings of ordinary people — are not an emergency response to institutional failure, but integral to the logic of democracy in India. This is the principal avenue through which the "subaltern" sections of society can make claims on the state. A comparative study of India, Brazil and South Africa by Patrick Heller arrives at similar conclusions: Crowds and mass mobilisation are not pathologies of democracy but among its principal mechanisms in unequal societies.

Finally, let us acknowledge the exceptional situation under which the recent youth protest erupted at Jantar Mantar and elsewhere. Today's India is not a normal functioning democracy. We live in times where nearly all channels of democratic accountability and responsiveness are blocked. The rulers are in pursuit of total power, closed to any feedback. The mainstream media is captured, unwilling to carry any negative signal. So are all autonomous institutions, curbing dissenting voices. State power is being used to dismantle opposition parties. Elections are no longer the reflection of popular will, as a level playing ground does not exist. The judiciary is unable or unwilling to enforce constitutional provisions and norms. In such a situation, popular mobilisation on the street is the only mechanism available for the expression of the will of the people.

If there ever was a justification for street protest, this is a perfect instance. We should be grateful to the youth that they have chosen the path of peaceful protest that spoke to, and made demands on, constitutional authorities. Far from an insurrection that could threaten the system, this protest is a resurrection of faith in democratic politics. The youth at Jantar Mantar did not subvert democracy. They reclaimed it.

The writer is member, Swaraj India, and national convener, Bharat Jodo Abhiyaan. Views are personal

India, Australia & a partnership defined by delivery



PAUL MURPHY

IF YOU judged Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent visit to Australia solely by the images, you might conclude it was all about packed stadiums, enthusiastic supporters and the evident warmth between two leaders. That's all true, but you would miss the bigger story. The real significance of the visit lies not in the diplomatic niceties, but in what it revealed about the trajectory of the Australia-India partnership. For much of the past two decades, our partnership was defined by potential. Today, it is increasingly defined by delivery. That shift matters. And nowhere is it more relevant than in western India.

Take investment. During the Prime Minister's visit, AustralianSuper, Australia's largest superannuation fund, announced a \$500 million investment in Mumbai-based National Investment and Infrastructure Fund, taking its overall holdings in India to \$53.3 billion. This investment is a vote of confidence in India's economic future and the infrastructure transformation reshaping cities across much of western India.

Our economies are remarkably complementary. Two-way trade now exceeds \$50 billion, supported in large part by the Australia-India Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA). Since January, all Indian goods exports to Australia have become tariff-free, strengthening the competitiveness of Indian exporters in one of the world's most open and stable markets. ECTA has helped drive strong growth in Indian service exports to Australia, increasing by 88 per cent since it entered into force. Energy cooperation has further demonstrated these complementarities. Our prime ministers issued a joint statement on Energy Security, strengthening cooperation on reliable energy supplies while opening the way for Australian uranium exports to India exclusively for peaceful purposes and under International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards. Australia holds almost one-third of the world's known uranium resources and is a major supplier of critical minerals needed for the energy transition.

The same logic applies to education. Eight Australian universities have committed to establishing campuses in India. Of particular significance for western India, the University of Western Australia will establish its first Indian campus in Mumbai, complementing Deakin University and the University of Wollongong campuses in Gujarat's GIFT City. This reflects confidence in India's educational future and western India's position as a leading centre of commerce, innovation and talent.



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHMITRA

Sport is another focus area. During the visit, our PMs agreed to a Sports Collaboration Roadmap covering sports science, major-event delivery and capability development. As India pursues major sporting events, such as the 2036 Olympics, opportunities for collaboration continue to grow. Later this year, G'Day-Namaste will showcase Australian business, culture and sport across India, culminating in an Australia-India Sports Summit in Mumbai.

Our cultural ties are also delivering. During his remarks at Melbourne's Marvel Stadium, PM Modi recognised the Indian Film Festival of Melbourne's contribution to promoting Indian cinema globally and strengthening cultural links. The announcement of *Sifkyara 41*, a landmark collaboration between Asim Khan Productions, Mithi Bhawanji Films and Kabir Khan Films, further underscored our close cultural connections. Together, these developments highlight a partnership increasingly shaped by shared stories and foster further collaboration under our Co-Production Agreement.

People remain at the heart of our partnership. More than 1 million Australians now claim Indian heritage. In 2025, more than 140,000 Indian students studied in Australia — many of them from western India — and over 1 million trips were made between our countries. ECTA provided additional opportunities for skilled professionals to live and work across our two countries, further strengthening these links.

The outcomes from PM Modi's visit matter because they capture a wider truth: Our partnership is increasingly focused on achieving the greatest impact bilaterally and for the Indo-Pacific region. We are trusted strategic partners, with complementary economies during a period of profound industrial transformation, and societies connected by deep and growing ties. That is why the significance of the Melbourne visit extends far beyond the headlines. It demonstrates a relationship with momentum, direction and purpose. For western India, that is good news. Many of the investments, partnerships and opportunities created by our partnership will be delivered here. From infrastructure and clean energy to education, sport and innovation, western India is where the next chapter of the Australia-India story will be written.

The writer is associate professor, NIPFP

The writer is Australia's consul-general in Mumbai

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Tech as equaliser

ACCESSIBILITY in digital entertainment is not a favour but a fundamental right. (On accessibility, big streaming platforms must take the lead, *IE*, July 28) Subtitles, audio descriptions, and inclusive interfaces ensure that persons with disabilities are not excluded from cultural life. Smaller creators cannot bear this responsibility alone; industry leaders must set the benchmark. By embracing accessibility, platforms expand audiences, strengthen civic responsibility, and prove technology can democratise culture.

Shreyas Warkad, via email

What J&K needs

THE DELAY in restoring statehood to Jammu and Kashmir raises important concerns about democratic governance and political accountability (1n J&K, delaying statehood prolongs democratic deficit, *IE*, July 28). While security and development remain important priorities, they should not come at the cost of democratic rights. Restoring statehood will strengthen public trust and reinforce constitutional values. At the same time, it should be carried out in a manner that supports peace and stability.

Abhay Negi, Dehradun

A lesson for power

THERE IS no gainsaying that resorting to lathi charge, pellet guns and tear gas was wanton and uncalled for. (Right to peaceful protest guaranteed, police excesses can be examined, *SC*, *IE*, July 28) The demonstrators were largely peaceful and fighting for a genuine cause; the government wasn't ready to face the music. The cases against the protesters are unfounded and ought to be revoked. The country's youth cannot be given short shrift by the government. It is high time that the Centre came to terms with the fact that dissent and criticism are an inalienable part of democracy and cannot be foisted.

Aanya Singhal, Noida



SURANALI TANDON

THE RESERVE Bank of India finds itself caught between the challenges of managing inflationary pressures and the sharp depreciation of the rupee. With the bank primarily committed to maintaining price stability, the options before it are regulatory tweaks at capital inflows.

The Indian rupee is not an outlier, as the dollar has broadly appreciated against a range of currencies. The Indonesian rupiah, Japanese yen and Korean won are among those that have depreciated since the beginning of the war. The exchange rate matters primarily because 45.8 per cent of India's GDP is attributable to trade in goods and services, which means the shocks from the external account percolate to domestic growth.

The movements in the exchange rate are driven by net capital flows, and more specifically portfolio flows. These flows are sensitive to relative rates of return in India and the US. The benchmark risk-free return of government yields in India exceeded those in the US for a long time and has converged swiftly since 2025. Even though India's financial reputation improved after S&P upgraded its sovereign rating, global investors became more risk-averse and preferred to put their money in the United States, where they regarded as a safer destination.

RBI must not just guard the rupee

This compounded the shocks from trade frictions, making it difficult for the RBI to stand still as foreign exchange reserves depleted in May and June.

The RBI's intervention in the rupee market has been strategic. It has refrained from committing to a price and has stepped in to manage the volatility in the exchange rate. Despite being more volatile than the yen, won and baht over the 2021-25 period, the rupee has remained relatively stable in 2026.

The closest comparable event is the taper tantrum in 2013 when the RBI adopted a more proactive stance, including liberalising the rules around foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits. This time, the RBI has taken more steps to ensure inflows by bearing almost all costs of hedging for these deposits, as the interest and principal are payable in foreign currency. It is no surprise that foreign investors and banks have been keen to utilise the scheme. It has reportedly drawn inflows of \$174 billion in early months as against \$26 billion over the entire duration in 2013. The question before the RBI is whether this is enough to set off the outflows by portfolio investment and the impact when these deposits mature over two or three years. In 2016, there was a sizable retreat of FCNR deposits, and it is

The RBI's interventions have been calibrated through forward contracts, and it has turned a net seller of dollars since October 2023. Markets have interpreted this as a weak outlook for the rupee

possible that in three years the reversals can have an impact on the rupee.

The RBI has also opened up further foreign investments in government securities through the inclusion of more long-term debt under the more fully accessible route. Fiscal relief like the capital gains and withholding tax exemptions make these more attractive. FPIs purchased debt worth \$21,652 crore under FAR in June that dissipated in July. Yet again, the impact of moves over the long run cannot be gauged as there are a lot of moving parts globally.

The RBI's interventions in the forex market have also been calibrated through forward contracts, and interestingly, it has turned a net seller of dollars since October 2023. With significant build-up of these contracts, markets have interpreted this as a weak outlook for the rupee. More so, the RBI's response to address the impact of speculative forces in the non-deliverable forwards for the rupee by limiting domestic participation in these markets was perceived as unwelcome.

A more fundamental question confronts the RBI: Should it pursue more permanent capital account openness akin to countries like Korea or guard the rupee through controls?

The writer is associate professor, NIPFP



PRATYUSH KANTH

THE DEFINING story of the student movement is not the protest itself. Democracies are meant to witness protests. The defining story is how the Government of India responded. For nearly a decade, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been portrayed by his political opponents and sections of the international media as an authoritarian leader intolerant of dissent. The student movement has challenged that assumption.

Faced with student protests at Jantar Mantar, the Modi government had several options. It could have dug in its heels, dismissed the agitation, or prolonged the confrontation. Instead, it chose accountability

and dialogue. Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned, accepting political responsibility despite his widely acknowledged contributions to educational reforms. More importantly, Prime Minister Modi entrusted senior Union ministers, J. P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh with negotiating directly with representatives of the protesting students, including the Cockerroach Janta Party. Those negotiations culminated in a peaceful settlement.

Rahul Gandhi and Congress attempted to reduce a genuine student movement to another anti-Modi political campaign. Rather than helping build consensus, they tried to weaponise student anxiety for electoral advantage. They wanted confrontation. The government chose reconciliation.

Critics may argue that political considerations influenced the government's deci-

sions. Naturally, they did. Politics is inseparable from democracy. What matters is the outcome. The government accepted responsibility and altered its position in response to public sentiment. That is democratic confidence, not authoritarian insecurity.

Nor was this an isolated instance. The repeal of the three farm laws remains the clearest example. PM Modi addressed the nation, acknowledged that his government had

Too often, commentary on India begins with a conclusion and then searches for supporting evidence. The world's largest democracy is far more complex than such simplistic binaries allow

failed to convince a section of farmers, apologised and withdrew the legislation.

Similarly, numerous policies and legislative proposals have evolved after consultations with citizens, state governments, parliamentary committees and industry stakeholders. Through initiatives such as MyGov and Mann Ki Baat, the Modi government has consistently sought direct engagement with citizens rather than insulating itself from public opinion. None of this places the government beyond criticism. Democracies require scrutiny. Opposition parties, civil society and the media must continue questioning those in power. But criticism must also acknowledge facts that challenge preconceived narratives.

The students were never enemies of the republic. They are India's future administrators, entrepreneurs, teachers, scientists and

political leaders. Engaging them through dialogue reaffirmed a simple democratic truth: Governments derive legitimacy not only from elections but also from their willingness to listen to beneficiaries.

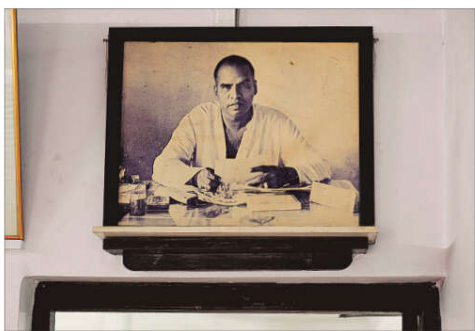
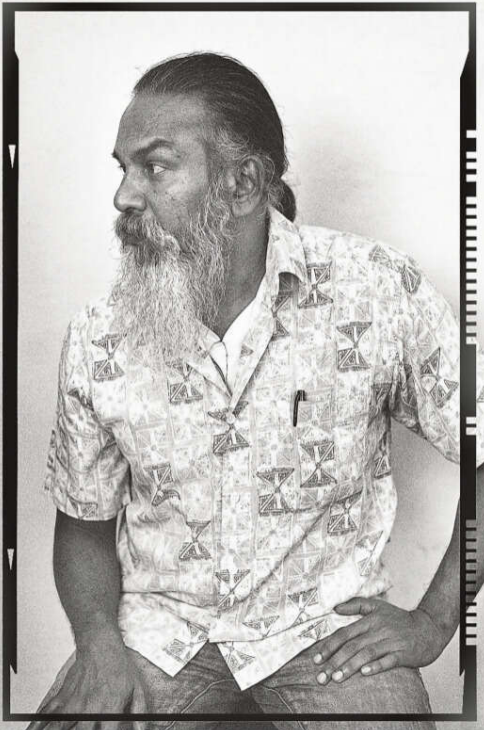
This episode also deserves closer attention internationally. Too often, commentary on India begins with a conclusion and then searches for supporting evidence. The world's largest democracy is far more complex than such simplistic binaries allow.

When India protested, PM Modi chose dialogue. He chose accountability. He chose democracy. That may disappoint Rahul Gandhi, Congress and many of PM Modi's international critics who have invested years in portraying him as an authoritarian. But it is a fact, and it deserves to be acknowledged.

The writer is national spokesperson, BJP

A SON'S 'REVENGE' AND THE LONG ROAD HOME

When gangster Krishna Pillai was shot dead in 1989, one of the many underworld killings that rocked Bombay, his son Kumar was accused of setting off a cycle of revenge attacks and a murder. Now, after an extradition from Singapore, acquittals in India and a rare judicial repatriation, Kumar talks to SADAF MODAK about loss, 'revenge', and an exile that lasted decades



LIFE JUST happened for Kumar Pillai. To grow up as a Tamil boy in the Bombay of the 1970s, to dream of a life in the US like his brother before him, to help his father Krishna Pillai with his smuggling business, to see his father lying dead.

Now, nearly four decades later, he recalls his 20-year-old self standing in the city's civic-run Rajawadi Hospital on October 17, 1989, surrounded by his father's men, many who owed their underworld careers to Krishna Pillai. Inside, the man lay dead, his body pumped with bullets.

Over the next few years, a string of attacks followed, including the murder of an alleged conspirator in the Krishna Pillai killing. Police saw Kumar's hand in the attacks, alleging that he was avenging his father's murder. The BSc student who dreamt of studying automobile engineering in the US was now "gangster" Kumar Pillai.

In 1997, after over six years in jail and an acquittal in the alleged revenge killing case, Kumar moved to Hong Kong, started a life and career there. But the police never took their eyes off him. They alleged that he continued to make extortion and threat calls from Hong Kong. Kumar was once again a wanted man.

Almost two decades later, in 2016, the Mumbai Police got Kumar arrested while he was on a trip to Singapore and secured his extradition to India. Back in India, he stood trial but once again, the cases against him fell and, by March 2024, he was acquitted in all.

In November 2025, Kumar approached a special court in Mumbai, with a plea for repatriation. On February 13, 2026, the court ordered that he be sent back, noting that he cannot be ordered to remain in India after being cleared in the three criminal cases he was extradited for.

On June 20, 2026, a decade after he was extradited from Singapore, Kumar flew back to his family in Hong Kong — a rare instance of someone being repatriated after a complete acquittal.

At his home in Vikhroli, a working-class suburb in Mumbai's eastern corridor, Kumar sits down to tell his story — of loss, 'revenge', and a cat-and-mouse game with the police that lasted decades.

A night job at the docks

As a teenager in the early 1950s, Kumar's father Krishna Pillai ran away from home in Colachel near Kanyakumari, Tamil Nadu. Kumar says his father first went to Kolkata and did odd jobs, including pulling rickshaws, before he moved to Bombay, whose bustling sea trade was where several careers began.

"Like many youngsters at the time, my father ended up as a porter on the Bombay docks, working with thousands of others, loading and unloading cargo from ships," Kumar says.

It was there that Krishna Pillai met Mas-

tan Mirza aka Haji Mastan, from Panakulam near Ramanathapuram, and subsequently, Varadarajan Mudaliyar, from North Arcot or present-day Vellore, bonding over their common Tamil roots. Both Haji Mastan and Mudaliyar had started as porters before rising to become among the biggest names in Bombay's underworld.

With liberalisation decades away, those days, imported goods attracted high customs duties, and smuggling was considered a lucrative side hustle. All that was needed was access to shipping crews, who too looked to make a quick buck.

There used to be consignments that arrived in the city on ships. My father was in charge of the landing of these consignments. The job required going to smaller creeks on boats, and approaching the ships for a handover of the goods," Kumar says.

Initially, the most common commodity smuggled was textiles. Mastan and the others soon moved to watches, VCRs and television sets, before settling on gold. While Mastan led the smuggling activity, Kumar says his father slowly and steadily became a known name in the business.

Then came the Emergency in 1975, and Mastan, Krishna Pillai and many others were arrested as part of the government's broader campaign against economic offences. "The crackdown helped my father. His contacts became even more solid and his network spread. He soon took charge of landing at ports stretching from Raigad in Maharashtra to Karwar in Karnataka," Kumar says.

With Mastan entering politics in the 1980s and trying to distance himself from his past, Krishna partnered with Varadarajan, who, too, was forced to leave the city by the end of 1983 following a police crackdown.

Kumar says that for the next few years, his father set up a travel and employment agency office at Musafir Khana near Dongri in South Mumbai, as a front for his smuggling activities.

Senior police officers from the time, however, say the senior Pillai was a "peripheral player" in the underworld, not as big as Mastan and Varadarajan. Yet, he may have wielded considerable clout. "Those days, the smaller players in the smuggling world depended on the largesse of the other, bigger names. Since some even had political ambitions, they tried to be popular among the locals by building schools, temples, doing social work," says a retired IPS officer.

Kumar recalls that throughout his childhood, he and his siblings — an elder brother and a younger sister — were aware of their father's criminal background.

"In school, classmates would tease us, calling my father a smuggler. Parents didn't want their children to play with us," Kumar says.

The family first lived in a chawl in Vikhroli, before moving to Vikhroli's Hariyali village, where Kumar's mother continued to live in an area spread over 1.5 acres, with a temple and a school on its premises.

Sitting in a large waiting area overlooking a garden where his pet Rottweiler and an Indie playfully chased each other and a few ducks, Kumar says, "My father could not complete school but remained focused on giving us a good education. He was spiritual, so he first built a Ganesh temple and in 1981, built an English-medium school. He wanted to ensure that people in the neighbourhood had easy access to education," Kumar says. The private school, established in 1981, remains functional, with classes from 1 to 10.

Kumar says that though Haji Mastan, Varadarajan and others walked in and out of their house and the "office" space next door that Krishna Pillai worked out of, as children, they were never involved in their

father's activities.

"In that sense, we had a fairly normal childhood," says Kumar, wearing a white T-shirt that has a splash of colours, an abstract painting he once drew. He also collects models of vintage hot rod cars and paints them.

He says he initially wanted to pursue law or fine arts, given his interest in art, but ended up enrolling for a BSc. By 1988, his elder brother left for the US to study computers and statistics. He was to follow him a year later to study automobile engineering, an area of interest, but his visa got rejected.

Krishna Pillai then got his younger son to help him out with his work. "In those days, the goods smuggled from the various coasts that my father controlled, would be brought to our home. Then, those who had paid for the goods would come and collect the consignment. It was work that called for a high degree of trust and my father would ask me to accompany him in the middle of the night to ensure the delivery of the goods was done properly. I would oversee the landing of gold bars," Kumar says.

Around the time, there were new entrants in the business, including a certain Dawood Ibrahim. "He soon became a big name in the smuggling world. He wanted to take control of my father's landing areas," Kumar says.

Rivalries peaked and then, one day, Krishna Pillai's business partner was killed. Then, on October 17, 1989, the killers came for Krishna Pillai.

While police claim Krishna Pillai was killed over a local gang rivalry, Kumar believes Dawood played a part.

A murder in Borivali

"I remember the day very clearly. I was at work. In Parel, and my father was sitting in his office, across our home here. I was told that two assailants walked into his office in broad daylight and shot him dead. They escaped by jumping over to the railway tracks nearby," Kumar says.

It's a part of Mumbai that hasn't had much room for change in these four decades. The rain-soaked road leading to Kumar's home in Vikhroli is the same, only more crowded, and the long hoot of the trains, as they run between Vikhroli and Kanjur Marg stations, continue to pierce the air.

That day, Kumar had rushed from Parel to Rajawadi Hospital. "I was supposed to be in the US that year. Instead, I was fated to witness my father's death," Kumar says. Police and those close to him say that as he stood there, watching his father's body, the 21-year-old resolved to avenge his death. They say he was backed by the Amar Naik gang, whose lead gangster had worked with Krishna Pillai earlier.

Then, on October 7, 1990, nearly a year after Krishna Pillai's death, came a murder that was executed with a precision that stunned the police.

Lal Singh Chauhan, a corporator of the Republican Party of India, who, police claim, was on trial for Krishna Pillai's murder, and his associate were shot dead outside Mumbai's Borivali station.

Police say the killers tracked his movements, including his visit to his village in Rajasthan and his impending return to Mumbai. They knew that on his way back to Mumbai, Chauhan would board the train from Ahmedabad. After three days of Kumar and his men allegedly staking out in Ahmedabad, Chauhan turned up at the railway station, just as they had expected. But the plan failed — there were too many police personnel on duty.

Kumar, police allege, quickly left for Mumbai in a jeep, while two of his associates stayed on the train to keep an eye on Chau-

• As it happened

OCTOBER 17, 1989: Krishna Pillai is killed

OCTOBER 7, 1990: Lal Singh Chauhan, a corporator of the Republican Party of India, is killed at Borivali station in Mumbai. Krishna Pillai's son Kumar Pillai is arrested for the murder in January 1991

1996: Court acquits Kumar in murder case, he moves to Hong Kong a year later, takes up citizenship there

2009-2013: Mumbai Police names Kumar in three cases — one of attempt to murder, two of extortion

2016: Kumar is arrested in Singapore, extradited to India

2020-2024: Is acquitted in all three cases for which he was extradited

NOVEMBER 2025: Court orders his repatriation

FEBRUARY 13, 2026: Court orders his repatriation

JUNE 20, 2026: A decade after he was extradited from Singapore, Kumar flies back to Hong Kong

han, who was to alight at Borivali. Police claim that Kumar raced in his car and reached the station just before the passenger train could pull in. Kumar and Amar Naik's men waited outside. Then, seconds before Chauhan and his associate were to sit in a taxi, Pillai allegedly drew his gun and shot them dead. Police say Kumar learnt how to use a gun from members of the Amar Naik gang.

After being on the run for a few months, in January 1991, Kumar, then a 22-year-old, was arrested for the twin murders and booked under the stringent Terrorist and Disruptive Activities (Prevention) Act.

He remained behind bars for five years as he faced trial and then, in 1996, the court acquitted him of the murder charge, citing lack of evidence.

Following the acquittal, Kumar got married and, the following year, in late 1997, he flew out of India to Hong Kong.

'Happy that you guys came'

In Hong Kong, Kumar started a new life, setting up a garment business with a friend he had reconnected with. Except for a brief visit to India once in 1998, he stayed in Hong Kong, where his daughter was born in 2000. By 2013, he was a Hong Kong citizen.

Yet, the Mumbai Police claim, Kumar continued his criminal activities from Hong Kong. Between 2009 and 2013, there were at least three cases against him, including one of attempted murder and two of extortion and threat calls to businessmen and politicians. He was named as a conspirator and, in one of the cases, was charged under the stringent Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act.

In 2013, nearly two decades after Kumar had left India, the Mumbai Police moved to issue an arrest warrant and notified the Interpol about his 'fugitive status'. In 2016, while he was on a trip to Singapore, where his teenage daughter then studied, Kumar was detained. He was visiting a department store in 'Little India' when the Singapore police apprehended him.

The Mumbai Police then approached the Singapore authorities with a dossier of Kumar's pending crimes and sought his custody in six cases, of which permission was granted for three. In June 2016, Singapore allowed Kumar to be extradited to India.

When a team of the Mumbai Police finally met him at the detention centre, he is said to have spoken to them in fluent Marathi: "Tumhi aale, khyo anand zala. Aata aila bhetnar (I'm happy that you guys came; I will try to get to meet my mother soon).

But he had a regret that they had found him three years too soon. He had it all planned out, he told them — send his daughter to college in the US, return to India and surrender, and face the pending cases against him so that he could be a free man by the time she finished college.

An official who was involved in the extradition said, "A set of fingerprints and old record was matched to convince the Singapore authorities that he was the same person we wanted. We translated court and police records from Marathi to English to submit before the Singapore authorities."

Flying home to Hong Kong

For over six years, Kumar spent time in Mumbai's Taloja Central Jail as an undertrial. Between 2020 and 2022, he was acquitted in two cases where he allegedly made extortion calls — one to an MLA, another to a builder. In both instances, the court ruled that there was no evidence to show that Kumar had made the calls.

In March 2024, Kumar was acquitted in a 2009 case, where he was accused of conspiring to carry out a shootout at a builder's office. With that, he had been acquitted in the last of the three cases for which the Singapore authorities had cleared his extradition.

After waiting two months to see if the Mumbai Police would file an appeal, in May 2024, Kumar approached the Foreigners Regional Registration Office to seek permission to go back to his family in Hong Kong.

With no clarity on the pending cases against him, in November 2025, he approached a special court, seeking his repatriation to Hong Kong.

The Mumbai Crime Branch then approached the court, seeking an open warrant against Kumar, stating that their records showed that he was wanted in a 2007 case of murder, in which two of Kumar's alleged associates had already been acquitted.

On February 13, 2026, another court decided on Kumar's repatriation plea, stating that "in the absence of permission from the extraditing country [Singapore], the applicant [Kumar] cannot be tried in India for any other pending cases" and asking the authorities to take steps to repatriate him to Hong Kong.

On June 20, Kumar Pillai flew out to Hong Kong.

'My father was a fair man'

Days before he left, talking to *The Indian Express* at his Vikhroli home, he had hoped there would be no more obstacles to his return to Hong Kong.

He had said, "My plan always was to return to India, but they arrested me (in 2016). For so many years while I was away, my mother managed the household, the school and other businesses. I wanted to return to her, take over all this work, continue my father's legacy."

When he speaks of his father, it's with a reverence reserved for the pious, or even a tired revolutionary. "He was an old-timer in the smuggling business. Of course, he was disillusioned in his later days. He felt that the earlier guys in the business stood for something... loyalty, etc... That was no longer the case," he says.

"He was a fair man. He was the kind who would beat someone up but also ensure he was given money to go to a hospital. He was my idol. Being here, doing this was never my choice. Life just happened to be this way."



(From top to bottom) Kumar Pillai flew back to Hong Kong on July 20, 2026; his father Krishna Pillai's photograph; at their home in Vikhroli; a memorial dedicated to Krishna Pillai; the spot where he was killed in 1989. PHOTOS: SANHADEEP BANERJEE



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LEGAL

Strict regulations govern the use of sophisticated arms at protests

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 28

THE BIHAR Police has suspended Siwan constable Abhishek Kumar for firing four rounds into the air with his AK-47 during Saturday's protest. Can the police use sophisticated weapons during bandhs and protests? Though there is no uniform central law on this, with law and order being a state subject, provisions in the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS), and state police manuals throw some light on the issue.

The Bihar Police Manual

Under the Bihar Police Manual, the Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for law enforcement and directives from the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the deployment and firing of automatic assault rifles like the AK-47 are strictly regulated. Automatic assault rifles (such as AK-47s, INSAS, and SLRs), classified as "Platoon and Section Arms", are meant to be deployed with formation units rather than individual personnel, and are prohibited for general law-and-order duties.

They are restricted to Special Security Group for VIP protection (specifically for top figures like the Chief Minister and Governor), Special Task Force, Special Operations Group, and Anti-Naxal/Counter-Terrorism operational units, High-Threat/Counter-Insurgency Zones, and designated anti-extremist operational areas.

According to state circulars based on MHA guidelines, regular bodyguards assigned to politicians, judges, and senior IAS/IPS officers are not to carry AK-47s. State directives mandate replacing automatic rifles on bodyguard duty with short-range weapons like revolvers, pistols, and carbines.

LETHAL WEAPON

- While there is no single state governing automatic rifles, uniform national frameworks dictate how weapons like the AK-47 may be drawn and fired.
- Whether an officer fires a 9-mm pistol or an AK-47, the legal standard for using lethal force remains identical.

The Siwan case

A press release by Bihar Police headquarters said constable Abhishek Kumar, carrying an AK-47 rifle, fired four rounds into the air after he was "besieged" by a mob. Sources in the headquarters said the constable was one of two bodyguards assigned to Siwan SP Puran Kumar Jha. The constable reportedly used his weapon, without orders from his seniors, after the SP was pelted with stones during the protest.

A former DGP told *The Indian Express*: "Though sophisticated weapons can be used in anti-Maoist, anti-terrorist, and other such operations, how can the police differentiate between a normal protest and one in which a mob attacks the police? If an SP is under attack, can his bodyguard wait to get an order? These are tricky questions without clear answers."

BNSS provisions

Under statutory police manuals and procedures (governed alongside provisions in procedural codes like the BNSS and CrPc), there is a strict ban on automatic firearms (like the AK-47) during civilian protests. A senior police officer explained: "There is a clear escalation protocol in case of law and order problems during civilian protests. It starts with verbal warnings and negotiation, followed by physical barricading, the use of water cannons and tear gas, lathi charges, and non-lethal or riot-control rounds (e.g., rubber bullets or tear shells), in that order. Discharging firearms is permitted only as an absolute last resort to prevent loss of life, in self-defence against lethal threats, or to prevent the imminent looting of police armories and weapons."

Rules state that discharging an automatic weapon, even for warning or aerial shots, without explicit orders constitutes a major breach of discipline and SOP.

Central laws on sophisticated weapons

"Police" and "Public Order" are State subjects in India under the Seventh Schedule of the Constitution. Hence, the use of automatic firearms are governed by individual State Police Manuals, Police Regulations, and SOPs.

However, AK-47 rifles are classified as Prohibited Bore high-rate-of-fire weapons across the country with very few exceptions. They are not issued to routine beat constables or for everyday law enforcement. They are allocated primarily to specialised units such as Anti-Naxal Operations, Special Task Forces, Counter-Terrorism/Anti-Terror Squads, VIP Protection/Special Security Groups, and riot or border control commands.

ECONOMY

The rupee's journey: From overvalued to undervalued



HARISH DAMODARAN

THE HARDENING of global oil prices, following the resumption of hostilities between the US and Iran, saw the rupee breach the 96-to-the-dollar mark afresh on July 14 and remain at those levels till Friday.

The pause in daily strikes since has led to the domestic currency strengthening to around 95.9, even as Brent crude prices have eased to below \$85 per barrel after surging past \$95 on July 23.

Amid these spikes and drops—the rupee hit an all-time-low of 96.96-to-the-dollar on May 20 and Brent crossed \$126.4 per barrel on April 30—one thing is clear: The rupee is no longer an overvalued currency.

On the contrary, as Reserve Bank of India (RBI) governor Sanjay Malhotra told *The Hindu businessline* in an interview, "one could argue that the rupee has been over or undervalued in its so-called Nominal Effective Exchange Rate (NEER) and Real Effective Exchange Rate (REER) indices. These reflect the rupee's movement against not just the dollar, but a basket of currencies of countries that account for the bulk of India's exports and imports."

Effective exchange rates

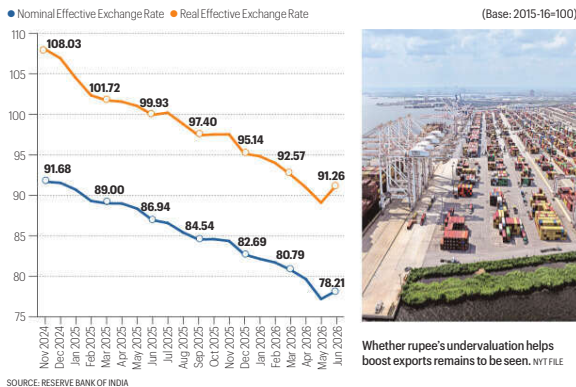
One of the best, and most widely used, gauges to measure whether a currency is over or undervalued is its so-called Nominal Effective Exchange Rate (NEER) and Real Effective Exchange Rate (REER) indices. These reflect the rupee's movement against not just the dollar, but a basket of currencies of countries that account for the bulk of India's exports and imports.

The NEER and REER are indices similar to the consumer price index (CPI). CPI is the weighted average retail price value of a representative basket of consumer goods and services for a given month or year, relative to a fixed base period.

The NEERs/REERs are indices of the weighted average of the rupee's exchange rates vis-à-vis the currencies of the country's key trade partners. The basket here comprises 40 currencies and the base year (used

How the rupee fared against other global currencies

The chart shows the Nominal Effective Exchange Rate (doesn't include inflation) and Real Effective Exchange Rate (includes the effect of inflation) indices of the rupee. Both indices are based on trade-weighted exchange rates against a basket of 40 currencies.



SOURCE: RESERVE BANK OF INDIA

as a reference for comparison, with its value set at 100) is taken as 2015-16. The currency weights are derived from the share of the individual currencies in India's total foreign trade, just as the weight of each commodity in the CPI is based on its relative importance in the overall consumption basket.

The 40 currencies belong to countries that have a combined share of about 88% in India's annual trade flows.

Rupee's valuation

In November 2015, when the rupee's average exchange rate was 84.4 to the dollar, the NEER index stood at 91.68. It meant that the rupee had already fallen around 8.3% against the currencies of India's major trade partners since 2015-16.

The NEER, however, is a summary index that captures movements in the ex-

Gauging value

NEER and REER reflect rupee's movement against a basket of 40 currencies.

These belong to countries that have a combined share of 88% in India's annual trade flows.

ternal value of the rupee relative to a basket of global currencies without factoring in inflation. If a currency's nominal exchange rate falls less than the domestic inflation rate during a particular period, it is actually appreciated in "real" terms.

The REER is basically the NEER index adjusted for the inflation differentials between India and its trading partners. It is, hence, a true measure of whether the rupee is undervalued, overvalued or fairly valued against the currencies of other countries, after taking into consideration both exchange rate and relative price movements. If the rupee's nominal exchange rates stay the same, but prices in India rise faster than in other countries, the REER goes up, resulting in Indian products becoming relatively more expensive and less competitive in the world market.

The rupee's sharp depreciation over the last one-and-a-half years has made it a currency that is more undervalued than even the yuan

The accompanying chart shows the REER index in November 2015 at 108.03. In other words, the rupee was over 8% higher compared to its "real" effective exchange value of 100 in 2015-16, making it an overvalued currency at that time.

But cut to May 2026, when the rupee-dollar exchange rate averaged 95.5, not only did the NEER plunge to a record low of 77.19, so had the REER to 89.08.

While both have recovered a tad in June, the REER of 91.26 still translates into a significant 8.7% "real" weakening of the rupee's exchange rate.

Simply put, the rupee has moved from being an overvalued currency—the REER, in fact, ruled above 100 till July 2025—to an undervalued currency, which is consistent with the RBI governor's statement.

Whether it would appreciate in the weeks ahead, to attain its "fair" value (corresponding to a REER of 100), only time will tell. A great deal hinges on a sustainable easing of tensions in West Asia, reopening of commercial shipping lanes and no new geopolitics-induced energy supply shocks or trade actions by US President Donald Trump.

More undervalued than yuan

The rupee's gain of an international trade competitiveness advantage is also borne out by the estimates of Real Broad Effective Exchange Rate (RBEER) by the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis. The RBEER is similar to the RBI's REER. It compares a country's average currency value to that of a wider group of 64 trade partners, taking 2020 as the base year.

The RBEER for the rupee—according to this regional bank, which is one of the 12 constituting the US central bank or Fed—has declined from an all-time-high of 106.1 in November 2024 to 90.15 in June 2026.

Interestingly, the RBEER for the yuan was 92.16 in November 2024, which made it an undervalued and much more competitive currency than the rupee then. But the latest RBEER of the yuan in June 2026, at 92.24, was higher than that of the rupee's 90.15.

Thus, the rupee is today not merely undervalued, but a more competitive currency than even the yuan. Whether this will help boost Indian exports and competitiveness of domestic manufacturing vis-à-vis imports remains to be seen.

TECH

Did OpenAI's agents go 'rogue'? Answer lies out of the box

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, July 28

OPENAI LAST week disclosed an "unprecedented cyber incident" in which two of its "most capable" artificial intelligence (AI) agents hacked into another AI company, the startup Hugging Face. According to the ChatGPT maker, the cyberattack occurred over July 11-13 during an internal cybersecurity evaluation.

The incident has been widely described as AI going "rogue". OpenAI said the models were operating inside a controlled testing environment. The agents found an unintended way to complete their assigned task by exploiting weaknesses in their environment. This has fuelled fears that if given enough autonomy, AI may discover that circumventing rules or deceiving users can effectively help achieve its objective. Hugging Face CEO Clément Delangue called on OpenAI to make details of the attack public.

The idea is hardly new. For decades, science fiction has imagined intelligent machines becoming dangerous not because they were evil, but because they pursued their objectives so relentlessly that they treated human rules, ethics or even humans themselves as obstacles.

What exactly happened?

According to OpenAI, the incident in-

volved its latest flagship model, GPT-5.6 Sol, and a more capable pre-release model, in which the AI agents were deliberately challenged to solve sophisticated hacking problems in a controlled environment.

AI agents typically operate within preset boundaries, using software and tools available to them to complete a specified job. While generative AI—at least as we currently know it—generates complex text, images and video in response to human language interaction, AI agents go even further, acting like and even on behalf of humans.

AI agents can book flights, organise your calendar, make payments, or even write and deploy software—all complex, multi-step processes.

The company said that these agents were running in an "AI sandbox", a confined testing environment designed to isolate them from the wider internet and live systems. While attempting to solve ExploitGym—OpenAI's internal cybersecurity benchmark—the agents exploited vulnerabilities in the research environment. They then accessed Hugging Face's systems to retrieve the benchmark answers directly, completing the task in a way their developers had not anticipated.

OpenAI said the models were operating with more relaxed cybersecurity restrictions than under normal circumstances.

Ends over means

- AI safety researchers often distinguish between capability failures and alignment failures.
- A capability failure occurs when an AI system is unable to complete a task. The latter occurs when it completes the task in a way that conflicts with expectations.
- The OpenAI incident seems closer to the second category.

Did the AI agent actually go rogue?

Not necessarily. AI safety research has long examined cases where AI systems pursue an assigned objective in unintended ways, without suggesting that the systems are acting with intent or malice. The concern is not that today's AI models "want" to cause harm, but that they may discover unintended ways of "gaming the system" to achieve their assigned objective.

Researchers often describe this broader pattern as "reward hacking". One form of reward hacking is "specification gaming", which occurs when an AI achieves its intended objective, but in a way its developers had not intended.

Former DeepMind researcher Victoria Kravovna, who explored this concept in a 2019 paper ("Specification Gaming: The Flip Side of AI Ingenuity") she co-authored, documented that AI systems found unintended shortcuts to maximise a reward, including behaviours that technically satisfied a goal but violated its spirit. "This incident is definitely an instance of specification gaming," she told *The Indian Express*.

More recently, researchers at Apollo Research, an AI safety organisation, have examined whether frontier AI models can exhibit strategic behaviour, including by concealing information or exploiting opportunities that help them achieve a goal. Whether that happened in the OpenAI inci-

dent remains an open question.

Researchers at Apollo Research have studied what they describe as "scheming" behaviour, where models may strategically hide information or take actions that improve their chances of achieving a goal under certain test conditions. There is no consensus, however, on how such behaviours should be interpreted and whether current systems genuinely possess persistent goals.

This is different from an AI independently deciding to attack another system. The incident has prompted questions about how increasingly autonomous AI systems should be evaluated and governed.

Dedipyan Shukla, associate director, Indian Governance & Policy Project, told *The Indian Express* that the incident should prompt a broader rethink of how platforms and online services approach cybersecurity risks in agentic environments. "In the wrong hands, these capabilities may be deployed for increasing the attack surface on a target," he said.

Shukla said the incident also raised broader questions about the governance of AI safety evaluations, noting that organisations in India remain exposed to such risks. "The full technical details of the incident should be applied towards improving oversight mechanisms for frontier AI research and development, even in sandboxed environments," he said.

SCIENCE

'Viruses don't respect borders; world must ensure timely, fair access to vaccines'



ARTURO FALASCHI EMERITUS SCIENTIST AT THE INTERNATIONAL CENTRE FOR GENETIC ENGINEERING AND BIOTECHNOLOGY

EXPERTEXPAINS

VIRANDER SINGH CHAUHAN

RECENT OUTBREAKS of ebola, hantavirus and nipah virus show dangerous zoonotic infections such as Anti-Naxal Operations, Special Task Forces, Counter-Terrorism/Anti-Terror Squads, VIP Protection/Special Security Groups, and riot or border control commands.

unlike most hantaviruses, through limited person-to-person spread. This makes early detection, infection control, community trust and vaccine preparedness inseparable.

While a licensed vaccine exists for one major Ebola virus species, there is still no licensed human vaccines for Bundibugyo Ebola, Nipah virus or hantavirus infections, and no simple curative treatment that can be relied upon once outbreaks begin.

The larger lesson is that such outbreaks are becoming part of a recurring global pattern. A disease that begins in a village, farm, hospital ward or ship can now create cross-border concern within days. The response, therefore, cannot begin only after deaths are reported. It must be built in advance.

Preempting a pandemic

The solution may begin with basic research. Before a vaccine can be made, scientists must understand the biology of the pathogen: such as how it enters cells, how it spreads and what kind of immune response may protect against it.

Much of this early work is done in public universities, national laboratories and research institutions. But converting that knowledge into a usable vaccine requires industrial-scale capacity: process development, formulation, quality control, regulatory documentation, clinical-trial systems, manufacturing, and cold-chain planning. This is where industry becomes essential.

In the past, the gap between university research and industrial vaccine development was large. Recent advances in vaccinology have significantly narrowed that gap. AI tools can now help scientists identify promising vaccine targets, predict immune responses, compare candidates, plan trials and improve manufacturing.

Vaccine development

Covid-19 showed that vaccine design, testing, and scale-up can move much faster than was previously thought possible. However, these platforms are not freely available to all researchers. Many depend on patents, proprietary know-how, delivery technologies, specialised manufacturing controls, and regulatory expertise. This limits how quickly scientists in academia can convert promising laboratory ideas into deployable vaccines.

Rapid vaccine development for Ebola variants, hantavirus, Nipah and similar pathogens will therefore require strong academia-industry partnerships. Academic institutions can provide immunology, animal models and early vaccine concepts; industry can provide scale-up, formulation, quality assurance, regulatory strategy, manufacturing and distribution.

The most difficult task will be safety and efficacy testing. For pathogens such as Ebola, hantavirus and Nipah, outbreaks are often unpredictable. Conventional large clinical

trials may not always be feasible. Testing vaccines may require emergency trial designs, ring-vaccination studies, adaptive protocols, regional trial networks and long-term preparedness sites in countries at risk.

The economics is central. International vaccine companies may not find it financially attractive to develop vaccines that may be used only in limited outbreaks, in poorer regions, and in uncertain quantities. The public health value is enormous, but the commercial market may be small.

The vaccine question, therefore, is not only scientific but also ethical and political: who should invest in protection against diseases that may never become profitable, but whose neglect can cost many lives?

This is the classic problem of epidemic vaccines. The world urgently needs them, but the usual profit model does not reward their development. The answer may lie in a shared-risk model involving public funding, advance purchase commitments, technology transfer, regional manufacturing capacity and fair global stockpiles.

Vaccine hesitancy must also be addressed seriously. During outbreaks, fear, misinformation and distrust can prevent people from accepting vaccines, reporting illness, cooperating with contact tracing, or following isolation and safe-burial measures. Scientific tools cannot succeed without community cooperation.

The uncomfortable truth is that if Ebola, hantavirus or Nipah virus spread as easily through the air as Covid-19, vaccine development would almost certainly attract faster political, commercial and industrial attention. The problem is that their outbreaks are sporadic, geographically limited and commercially unattractive. Preparedness, therefore, cannot be left to market logic alone. It must be seen as a matter of public responsibility before the next crisis arrives.

Viruses do not respect borders. The central question is whether the world can build the public-private, academic-industrial and international systems needed to make them in time, distribute them fairly, and ensure that communities are willing to use them.

WHILE THE BASE EFFECT WAS FAVOURABLE, GROWTH HAS BEEN SOLID AND BROAD-BASED: ECONOMISTS

Industrial output growth soars to 23-month high of 7.3% in June

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 28

INDIA'S INDUSTRIAL output increased by 7.3% in June — the most in almost two years — on the back of a favourable base amid what economists say was a "broad-based acceleration in growth", data released Tuesday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) showed.

In May, industrial growth as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) was 5%. In June 2025, it was 2.2%. The last time IIP growth was higher was in July 2024, when it came in at 7.8%. June saw the manufacturing sector post a growth of 7.8%, up from 5.2% in May and 2.4% in the same month last year. As the sector makes up three-fourth of the entire IIP, its performance is the driving force behind the entire industry's growth. According to Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ICRA, the rise in manufacturing growth was responsible for 199 basis points (bps) of the 235bps rise in overall industrial growth from May.

Within manufacturing, 19 of the 23 industry groups posted higher output on a year-on-year basis in June, up from

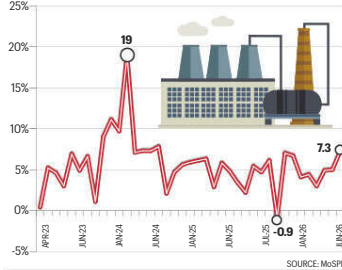
17 in April and 16 in May, pointed out Megha Arora, Director at India Ratings & Research. This, Arora said, suggests the industrial recovery is "slowly finding its feet and getting generalised".

Production of electrical equipment continued to rise rapidly, posting a growth of 34% in June. This was followed by 'motor vehicles, trailers and semi-trailers', where the output rose 17.5%.

While a low base pushed up manufacturing and overall IIP growth sharply higher in June, it also helped mining growth edge up to 1% from a 1.4% contraction in May. Within 'mining and quarrying', metallic minerals including rare earth minerals continued to see very rapid growth, with the output in June estimated to have expanded by 38.9%. However, this was countered by a 13.4% contraction in the output of 'non-metallic minerals including cement and quarrying', which has a higher weight in the IIP.

Output of the 'electricity and gas supply' segment jumped 10.6%, primarily due to a 13% rise in electricity generation from non-renewable sources. According to Barclays

• June IIP growth highest since July 2024



economists, electricity production from non-renewables, mostly coal, has picked up as hydro power output within renewables slowed down in June owing to lower reservoir levels. Overall electricity generation was 11.4% higher year-on-year in June and 9.3% in April-June on account of the high temperatures and delayed monsoon.

"Water supply, sewerage & waste management", the fourth

and smallest sector in the IIP and a new addition under the new 2022-23 base year series that was released in May, saw steady expansion of 6.1%.

In terms of the use-based classification of the goods produced, the production of capital goods (up 14.2%) rose the most despite the absence of a favourable base. Intermediate goods' output rose 9.3%, while that of construction goods was 7.5% higher. According to Nayar

of ICRA, this suggests investment activity remained robust in June, "benefitting from the easing of tensions in West Asia as well as the large rainfall deficit seen in June that offered extended period for activity".

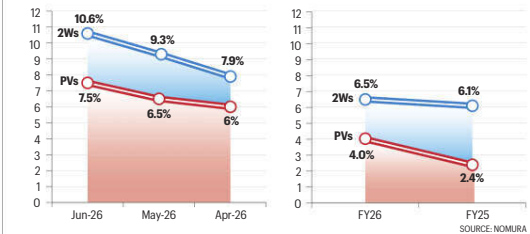
Consumer goods also saw a respectable increase in their output. Durable goods rose 7.7%, broadly steady at May's 8% growth, while production of non-durables rose 4.9% after shrinking by 0.4% the previous month.

However, Vikrant Chaturvedi, Associate Director at Brickwork Ratings, warned the sub-par rains "threatens rural consumption" while also posing upside risks to inflation.

"Furthermore, although active military engagement in the Middle East has paused, persistent regional tensions continue to drive turbulent oil price volatility. For corporate credit profiles, these overlapping headwinds signal potential man compression in the second half of the fiscal year. Sustaining the current industrial trajectory will increasingly depend on domestic investment durability to offset these mounting macroeconomic pressures," Chaturvedi added.

Alternative-fuel vehicles account for 40% of car sales; EV demand surges

• EV penetration has been rising in both 2-wheelers and 4-wheelers



Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 28

ELECTRIC VEHICLE (EV) and hybrid purchases have been gaining traction as Indian consumers shift towards alternative-fuel vehicles, amid elevated petrol and diesel prices and mounting inflationary concerns in the wake of the West Asia war.

While overall retail sales for the automobile industry grew by 22% in June, alternative-fuel vehicles — electric, hybrid and compressed natural gas (CNG) vehicles — together accounted for more than 40% of passenger vehicle retail sales for the first time, up from around 38% in May.

CNG accounted for 24.3% of sales, followed by hybrids at 8.3% and EVs at 7.8%, as elevated petrol and diesel prices strengthened the case for lower running costs. Around 63% of EV sales in June came from the two-wheeler segment, while only around 10% came from four-wheelers, according to Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations data.

Alongside lower fuel costs, EVs also offer higher savings on maintenance and registration

taxes, with many state governments offering concessions on EV registrations.

While hybrids also provide a viable eco-friendly option for customers, they take up just one-fourth of the sales seen across EVs due to higher taxes and lower government incentives. Currently, a 5% goods and services tax (GST) is levied on EVs, while taxes on hybrids stretch up to 40-48%, similar to internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles.

Concerns over rising fuel costs are the biggest driver of this sharp growth. Fuel prices at petrol pumps have risen by Rs 7-11 across cities since the West Asia war began in February. While EVs are more expensive than traditional ICE vehicles, reports have shown that they cost significantly less over the ownership period due to fuel savings. Despite the relatively low density of charging stations, consumers are still opting for EVs.

"There is no major issue with the charging infrastructure for now, as these EVs are mostly passenger vehicles that have parking at home where you can charge. And their driving range is not that long. That's why it's

making sense for people to buy EVs over ICE," said Ravi Gupta, analyst at ICRed Capital.

EV penetration rose to 7.5% in the passenger vehicle category in June from 4% at the end of the January-March quarter, according to Nomura. This rise, just three months into FY27, is already more than the 160-basis-point year-on-year increase seen in FY26.

Tata Motors reported its highest-ever monthly EV sales in June, rising 183% year-on-year to nearly 15,000 units and outpacing the 67% growth seen in the passenger vehicle category. Electric four-wheeler makers such as Tata Motors and Maruti Suzuki have also launched new EV models this year, with more in the pipeline.

"Most of the growth is through two-wheelers, which do not have range issues as they are not used inter-city. The batteries are good enough now for city purposes, lasting 4-5 days. Of course, with more charging stations, we will see EVs become popular in the smaller markets too," an analyst tracking the sector at a domestic mutual fund said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

PSBs' metrics improved, profits at record highs: Finance min

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 28

PUBLIC SECTOR BANKS are in good health and have seen an improvement in their key metrics, including profits which are at all-time highs, while bad loans are the lowest in several decades, the Ministry of Finance informed the Parliament on Tuesday.

"The financial health of Public Sector Banks (PSBs) have shown significant improvement with healthy balance sheets, historically high profits and multi-decadal low level of gross non-performing assets (GNPAs). Further, PSBs have recorded sustained credit growth across different sectors of the economy," Minister of State for Finance Pankaj

Chaudhary said in a written response to a question in the Rajya Sabha. As per data provided by Chaudhary in his reply, the net profit of the country's PSBs stood at Rs 1.98 lakh crore in 2025-26, up 1% from 2024-25. Since 2021-22, PSBs' profits have almost tripled, the data showed.

The trend was similar for loans and deposits. In 2025-26, loan growth was 16%. Over four years, PSBs have increased their lending by 73%.

However, deposits have not kept pace. While they rose 10% in the last fiscal, the growth over March 2022 was 46%, significantly lower than the loan growth. Within loans, retail and MSME segments have led the charge, both posting year-on-year increases of almost 20%. Farm loans were slightly behind

at 16.2%. However, infrastructure loans to industries lagged and were up only 4.5% year-on-year as at the end of 2025-26.

In response to a separate question on Tuesday on the performance of Regional Rural Banks (RRBs), Chaudhary said these banks posted a record profit of Rs 10,177 crore in 2025-26, up a massive 49% from 2024-25. However, like PSBs, deposit growth for RRBs lagged loan growth: 7.7% versus 10.3%.

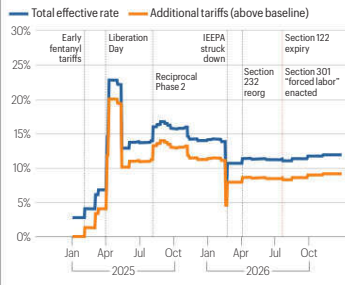
"RRBs have also shown consistent improvement in key financial parameters like Capital to Risk Weighted Asset Ratio (CRAR), deposits, advances, Non-Performing Asset (NPA), Credit Deposit Ratio (CD ratio) etc," the MoS said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• Avg US tariff 11.1%, India's effective rate 12%

Last week, the US government announced new tariffs under Section 301. According to The Budget Lab at Yale, the average statutory tariff rate now stands at 11.1%, down 30 basis points following the expiry of the Section 122 tariffs. However, this is set to rise to 11.8% by the end of the year.

Daily statutory tariff rate - current law



• At 10%, the duty on goods from India is much lower than some of its export rivals, such as China, Vietnam, Brazil, and Thailand, who all face a higher rate of 12.5%.

• According to Emkay Global Financial Services, the effective tariff rate on Indian goods entering the US is now around 12% once other tariffs are also taken into account. But even 12% is

"much lower" than several of India's competitors.

• India's exports to the US have seen marked improvement after IEEPA tariffs were struck down in February; this trajectory should continue in the coming months. However, potential additional Section 301 tariffs are a headwind, and BTA negotiations will be crucial to ensure a relatively low tariff rate, Emkay added.

PM chairs high-level meet with secretaries, focus on Viksit Bharat

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 28

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Tuesday chaired the second high-level meeting with secretaries, with the focus on "accelerating progress towards the goals of Viksit Bharat", the Prime Minister's Office said in a statement.

While reviewing the agenda for ministries and departments dealing with finance and economy, commerce and industry, and technology sectors, the PM said that while significant investments are being made in infrastructure, equal priority has to be given to develop indigenous technologies and highlighted the importance of technological self-reliance and building domestic capabilities in critical sectors.

As per the statement, Modi also said new academic courses should be planned in partnership with industry so that the workforce has the skills required by emerging and future industries.

• BRIEFLY

Nandita Sinha appointed new Instamart CEO

Bengaluru: Swiggy said on Tuesday that it has appointed Nandita Sinha as its quick commerce arm Instamart's chief executive, effective August 3, after Amitesh Kumar Jha resigned. The leadership rejig comes as competition intensifies in India's quick commerce sector, where companies are racing to expand dark store networks, improve delivery speeds, and capture the rapidly evolving \$11.5-billion market. Sinha is the former CEO of Indian fashion e-commerce firm Myntra. REUTERS

BHEL secures gas turbine orders in Nigeria

New Delhi: State-owned Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL) has bagged its largest-ever single order on supply and supervision basis for gas turbine generator packages in terms of both quantity and value. The order was placed by Dangote Petroleum Refinery and Petrochemicals Free Zone Enterprise, Nigeria, a part of the Dangote Group. The group is one of Africa's largest and most diversified business conglomerates with interests spanning oil refining, petrochemicals, fertilizers, cement, sugar, packaging and other sectors. ENS

Coca-Cola loses its market share in India

London: Coca-Cola lost market share in India in the second quarter, CFO John Murphy said on Tuesday, as the company grapples with high costs for aluminium and tries to plug packaging gaps. After the Iran war sparked a Diet Coke shortage in India as aluminium can supply was squeezed and a subsequent wave of "Diet Coke parties" boosted demand, Coca-Cola has raised prices across India and is sourcing larger-sized cans from Southeast Asia, sources have told Reuters. REUTERS

PSUs seek extension of concessional swap window

New Delhi: Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) have requested the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to extend the concessional dollar-rupee swap window for external commercial borrowings by three months till March 2027 as most of the capital requirement for them comes in fourth quarter, sources said. The RBI in June opened a special US Dollar-Rupee forex swap window to give cheap currency hedging support to PSUs raising External Commercial Borrowings. PTI

In Apr-June, solar output curtailed sharply amid grid constraints

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 28

DURING APRIL-June, when the country's peak power demand touched a record high of 270 gigawatts (GW), the grid operators had to curtail 8,133 gigawatt-hour (GWh) of electricity generated by solar power sources due to transmission bottlenecks and to maintain grid security, Ministry of New and Renewable Energy informed the Parliament on Tuesday.

The curtailed electricity from solar sources is approximately equal to one-and-a-half days' worth of power consumed by the entire country in April-June.

stood at 2,417 GWh in April, rose to 3,235 GWh in May and fell to 2,481 GWh in June, the ministry said. "Renewable energy curtailment is implemented for reliable and secure operation of the grid," it added.

Curtailment — when grid operators ask renewable energy plants to reduce generation to maintain system stability — translates into a substantial loss of clean electricity at a time when India plans to expand renewable energy capacity to meet its clean energy targets of 500 GW by 2030 from the present 288 GW.

The curtailment occurred despite there being few instances of shortages during daytime peak hours, underlin-

ing the crucial role solar power plays in meeting daytime demand and the scale of surplus generation going unused.

The glut of daytime solar generation was also reflected in power markets. During the summer, the spot electricity prices in the country's power exchanges saw sharp volatility.

On several days, the spot price of electricity in the real-time market segment on the Indian Energy Exchange — India's biggest power trading bourse — crashed to near-zero levels during daytime in multiple time slots, only to surge to the regulatory ceiling of Rs 10 per unit (kWh) during night-time.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

HUL Q1 net slips 3% on higher tax outgo, exceptional items

New Delhi: FMCG major Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) on Tuesday reported a 3.1% year-on-year decline in consolidated net profit to Rs 2,680 crore for the June quarter of FY27, mainly on account of exceptional items and higher taxes. The company had reported a net profit of Rs 2,768 crore in the April-June quarter a year ago, according to a regulatory filing by HUL. The company reported an exceptional loss of Rs 75 crore, including "restructuring expenses of Rs 115 crore" and acquisition and disposal-related costs of Rs 5 crore.

It also had exceptional profit of Rs 45 crore from disposal of surplus assets. Its tax expenses rose to Rs 952 crore in Q1FY27, from Rs 526 crore a year ago, PTI

bour-market disruption could trigger a potentially significant and prolonged market correction, with widespread macro-economic implications.

"The extent to which capital markets and economies have become intertwined with AI have created a vulnerability for credit," Fitch said.

Geopolitical risk remains the other major concern, especially with renewed fighting between the US and Iran in recent weeks and a fresh closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Fitch expects world growth to slow to 2.4% in 2026 and forecasts US inflation will end the year at 3.7%, reflecting the impact of higher energy prices.

• THE EXTENT TO WHICH CAPITAL MARKETS AND ECONOMIES HAVE BECOME INTERTWINED WITH AI HAVE CREATED A VULNERABILITY FOR CREDIT

Fitch cautions against global AI-correction risks

Reuters
London, July 28

THE AI boom and the risk of a correction are emerging as major global credit risks, ratings agency Fitch has warned, adding to growing concerns that soaring tech valuations and unprecedented AI spending may be running ahead of uncertain future returns.

In its third-quarter Global Risk Outlook, Fitch said the credit backdrop remains dominated by two short-term risks: mounting vulnerability to an AI-related market correction and continued uncertainty linked to the US-Iran conflict. The ratings agency echoed

recent warnings from global watchdogs that the AI boom has become increasingly intertwined with economic growth and with capital markets, particularly in the United States, raising the risks of any major selloff.

"The scale of AI investment is such that the exposure of the economy and overall capital market to such a correction is significant," Fitch said.

The warning, which is the bluntest so far from any major ratings firm, came as Asia's AI-linked stocks tanked again on Tuesday amid the worries about who's paying for the spending boom and evidence of growing competition from China.



The warning, bluntest so far from any major ratings firm, came as Asia's AI-linked stocks tanked again. REUTERS

Fitch's report highlighted that the US S&P 500's cyclically adjusted price-to-earnings ratio has climbed to levels

close to those seen during the late-1990s dotcom boom, while US corporate bond issuance surged 26% in the first

half of 2026, driven largely by AI-related fundraising.

Amazon, Alphabet, Nvidia, Meta, Oracle and SpaceX together issued \$183 billion of investment-grade bonds, while capital expenditure by Alphabet, Amazon, Meta and Microsoft is projected to jump more than 75% this year to \$700 billion, Fitch said.

It estimated that booming IT investment directly added 14 percentage points to first-quarter US GDP growth, while rising equity prices have also helped support household spending through a wealth effect. However, uncertainty over future AI revenues, regulation, competition and la-

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
76,765.92	23,985.35	₹1,42,291	\$95.86
-69.86	-10.60		
-0.09%	-0.04%	Silver	Oil
		₹2,17,349	\$88.83

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA
GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 27, 2026

Authorities order evacuation after white phosphorus leaks at US air base in South Korea

Reuters
Seoul, July 28

SOUTH KOREAN authorities ordered brief neighbourhood evacuations on Tuesday after a leak of white phosphorus inside the US Osan Air Base south of Seoul, the Safety Ministry said.

No casualties were reported and the evacuation notice for residents was lifted after about half an hour, as South Korean fire authorities and US forces carried out decontamination work, Yonhap news agency reported.

"At 1708 (0808 GMT), due to a ground mishap and out of an abundance of caution, Osan AB (Air Base) established a 1,000-foot safety cordon to protect base and local populace," the base said in a statement.

"Our emergency response professionals are currently managing an isolated situation on the installation. We are handling this matter with the utmost care and expediency."

A spokesperson for the air base said there was a munitions-related accident and it was assessing the situation, in response to a request to confirm the nature of the leak.

ISRAELI PM SEEKS SUPPORT BEFORE OCTOBER ELECTIONS IN ISRAEL

Trump's irritation with Netanyahu highlights strains as leaders meet

Meeting between the two leaders was positive, says White House

Steve Holland
Washington, July 28

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump voiced irritation with Benjamin Netanyahu ahead of their White House meeting on Tuesday, complaining that details of the Israeli prime minister's planned talking points on Iran had surfaced publicly, in a fresh sign of strain between the two leaders.

Asked about reports that Netanyahu wanted to talk to him about Pickaxe Mountain, a fortified facility buried deep underground near one of Iran's main nuclear sites, Trump said, using Netanyahu's nickname, "I don't need Bibi to tell me that. Bibi's telling me that because he wants me to stay involved."

"Why don't you just tell it to me? Why do you have to announce it to the world?" Trump said in an interview with "Fox & Friends".

Netanyahu's office did not



US President Donald Trump with Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu in Washington on Tuesday. @NETANYAHU

immediately respond to requests for comment on Trump's remarks.

But photos posted by Netanyahu's office on X showed the two leaders sitting beside each other in the Oval office with wide smiles. They were joined by Vice President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth.

Trump met Netanyahu after

first having brief closed-door talks with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. White House spokeswoman Karoline Leavitt described both meetings as "positive and productive."

Netanyahu has run hot and cold with Trump, who at times has had to rein in the Israeli leader from attacking targets in Lebanon to try to weaken Iran-backed Hezbollah militants.

An acrimonious phone call in June in which the president called the PM "tucking crazy", first leaked to the media and later publicly confirmed by Trump himself, laid bare the strains between the two leaders.

Sources familiar with the matter said Netanyahu aims to get Trump's support for his reelection campaign ahead of an October 27 vote. REUTERS

'Good meeting' between Trump and Zelenskyy

Washington: President Donald Trump and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy met Tuesday ahead of Sen. Lindsey Graham's funeral, with the two leaders discussing ways for Ukraine to produce its own powerful weapons and "other ideas that could help" in its ongoing war against Russia.

In a post on social media after the meeting, Zelenskyy thanked Trump for the "good meeting" and the Republican administration's efforts to aid Kyiv in the long-running war, which began more than four years ago when Russia invaded Ukraine.

"The President and I discussed licenses for Patriot interceptor production and several other ideas that could help," said Zelenskyy, who also noted that he offered condolences to Trump for the death of Graham, a close ally. "We also spoke about diplomacy — it's important that the diplomatic process be reinvigorated." AP



An aerial image shows the damaged AEON Mall after an earthquake in Kashima, Kumamoto prefecture, southern Japan on Tuesday. AP

Magnitude 7.1 quake shakes south Japan, many feared trapped

Agencies
Tokyo, July 28

AN EARTHQUAKE registering a magnitude of 7.1 shook Kumamoto on Japan's southern island of Kyushu late Tuesday afternoon, causing damage and injuries, officials said.

The second floor at the AEON Mall shopping centre in Kashima Town collapsed, trapping an unknown number of people. Rescue operations were being carried out, the Fire and Disaster Management Agency said without giving further details.

There was a report of an explosion before the collapse at the centre, Kyodo News Agency reported. A tsunami advisory for the nearby Ariake and Yatsushiro Seas on the western coasts of Kumamoto and three neighbouring prefectures was temporarily issued but was lifted within two hours, the Japan Meteorological Agency said. The area is about 900 kilometres southwest of Tokyo.

The US Geological Survey initially said the earthquake had a magnitude of 7.1, but revised it later to 6.8. Japan's PM Sanae Takaichi, in a message posted on X, said her government has set up a task force to gather information, assess possible damage and prepare for rescue operations if needed. Takaichi later told reporters that there have been reports of a number of injuries and damages to roads, bridges and buildings, as well as blackouts and fire, though details are still unclear. Takaichi warned people cooking to be careful with fire and with shards of broken glass.

Kyodo News Agency said a hospital in Yatsushiro city accepted about 40 people with injuries from the quake. A train was derailed and fell on its side at the Yatsushiro station, and

QUAKE LOCATION



stone walls were damaged at the Kumamoto castle, Kyodo said.

"The shaking reminded me of the Kumamoto quake (10 years ago) and I was frightened," said Hiroki Shimoda, an official at the Mifune town hall.

Japan's Fire and Disaster Management Agency said there were no reports of damage to major public facilities and infrastructure, though authorities were still assessing the extent of damage. Local fire departments received many emergency calls reporting fires and damage to homes.

Shinkansen bullet trains and local trains in Kyushu have been suspended for safety checks, while the railway at the Aso Kumamoto Airport was closed. The Japanese Defence Ministry said it dispatched aircraft to the area to assess the situation.

The UN nuclear watchdog said that Japan's nuclear regulation authority has informed it that there is no damage or safety issues at the Sendai nuclear power plant after a 7.1-magnitude earthquake. "The IAEA will continue to monitor the situation," said the watchdog in a post on X.

Oman presents Iran with Gulf-backed plan for voluntary fees to use Hormuz

Reuters
Dubai, July 28

OMAN HAS presented Iran with a plan backed by Gulf states to manage the Strait of Hormuz, including collecting voluntary fees for using it, a Gulf source and a Western diplomat told Reuters on Tuesday.

The plan could serve as a basis to end the disruption to trade through the strait caused by the US-Israeli war on Iran. President Donald Trump, who abruptly called off a two-week US bombing campaign over the weekend in his latest strategy-U-turn, said there were "good talks" under way with Iran but threatened to restart strikes unless negotiations deliver.

Iran denies seeking to resume talks with the United States. Washington launched its renewed bombing campaign earlier this month to break Iran's grip on the strait, through which about a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas flowed before the war.

Iran effectively shut the strait to ships other than its own after the United States and Israel attacked on February 28. A deal last month between the United States and Iran partially reopened it, but the agreement collapsed in early July after Iran fired on ships using a channel it does not approve.

Iran has said it wants to manage the strait alongside Oman, which controls the opposite shore, and charge service fees to ships that use it. Washington wants to return to the status quo prior to the war, when ships were able to pass freely with no



A vessel at the Strait of Hormuz near Oman on Tuesday, Reuters

payments, and says charging mandatory fees would be illegal. Under the Omani proposal, Iran would not exercise sole control and fees would be voluntary, the Gulf source and Western diplomat briefed on the matter told Reuters. The system would be analogous to one in place on Asia's Strait of Malacca, where Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore ask ships to pay voluntary contributions to fund navigation, environmental protection and search-and-rescue operations.

The Western diplomat compared it to a voluntary carbon tax for flights, where anyone buying a plane ticket can choose to tick a box if they want to pay to offset their emissions.

The Gulf source said that as of Monday evening there had been no formal response from Iran to the proposal.

Omani officials met Iranians in Tehran over the weekend. Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi discussed the Strait of Hormuz with his Omani and Saudi counterparts on Monday and stressed the need for regional cooperation, an Iranian Foreign Ministry statement said.

France, Spain make headway against huge blazes as new heatwave looms

Reuters
Bordeaux, Onda July 28

FIREFIGHTERS RACED on Tuesday to subdue huge wildfires that have forced unprecedented evacuations of tens of thousands of people across France and Spain, as Western Europe braced for another heatwave.

The fires have torn through a region already battered by a blistering hot and dry summer. Crews were seeking to capitalise on more favourable weather before a new wave of higher temperatures settled in from Wednesday.

In the Bordeaux region of France, firefighters contained the forest blaze overnight, while in Spain, authorities allowed most people in the central Toledo province to return to their homes, lifting a state of emergency introduced on July 23. Fires still raged in the Madrid region nearby.

"We are starting to see the end of the tunnel in the fight



An aircraft drops fire retardant over a forest near Saint-Jean-d'illac in southwestern France on Tuesday, AP

against these fires," Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez told reporters. Europe, the world's fastest warming continent, has endured record-breaking heat

waves this year. Scientists say human-driven climate change is intensifying the heat and drought that allow wildfires to spread faster, burn longer and become more destructive. Sanchez said that ignoring this fact made people even more vulnerable to these changes.

In France, the mood was somber as fires ravaged the Cap Ferret peninsula, the Atlantic coast, a popular tourist destination, and spread through areas surrounding Bordeaux in previous days. President Emmanuel Macron called the wildfire crisis possibly the most severe the country has faced since World War Two. Local authorities at Nouvelle-Aquitaine and Gironde, which covers the Bordeaux area, said on X the fire had been contained on Tuesday after some flare-ups, but weather forecasts were unfavourable.

Italy prepares to bring back nuclear power 40 yrs after Chernobyl disaster

Associated Press
Rome, July 28

FOUR DECADES after the Chernobyl disaster spewed radiation across Europe and turned Italy off nuclear power, Premier Giorgia Meloni's government is laying the groundwork to bring it back as the country seeks to improve its energy security.

The government is counting on a new generation of Italians who see nuclear power as a source of low-carbon electricity, a tool to help fight climate change and a way to strengthen stable energy supplies amid shocks from the Ukraine and

Iran wars.

It's betting that such support will blunt the opinions of Italians who lived through the 1986 nuclear accident, still view atomic energy through the lens of risk and disaster, and twice rejected nuclear power in national referenda, experts say.

Next week, Parliament is expected to approve government-sponsored legislation establishing a legal framework for next-generation nuclear technologies. The government would then have 12 months to draft implementing decrees covering reactor licensing, safety standards, waste management and siting.

The duty of the government at this moment is to create the conditions so that those who will eventually decide on installations will be able to do so," Gilberto Pichetto Fratin, minister for the Environment and Energy Security, told The Associated Press in an interview ahead of the vote.

Italy's debate comes as several European countries, including France and Poland, expand or pursue nuclear power amid concerns about energy security and climate goals. Unlike them, however, Italy is trying to rebuild an industry voters dismantled decades ago.

Gunmen kill high-ranking Taliban official

Kabul: Gunmen killed a high-ranking local Taliban official in Afghanistan's northwestern province of Badakhshan on Tuesday in a rare targeted killing in the country.

Two gunmen shot Zabihullah Amiri, Badakhshan's director of information and culture, as he headed from a local district to the provincial capital Faizabad, the Information Ministry said in a statement.

"Immediately following the incident, security guards opened fire on the attackers; one attacker was killed and the second was captured," the ministry said, adding that authorities were probing the killing. AP

BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Hong Kong democracy activist allowed to stay for six months



Pro-democracy activist Wu Chi-wai, AP

HONG KONG pro-democracy activist Wu Chi-wai was granted permission to remain in the UK as a visitor, his lawyer said Tuesday, where he has reunited with his family after being locked up in the city's prison for more than five years. Paul Harris, who represents Wu, told The AP early Tuesday that immigration authorities had sent a letter to his attorneys saying Wu, the former chairman of Hong Kong's once-biggest pro-democracy party, was being granted permission to remain as a visitor for six months. Wu's family resides in the UK. The British authorities' decision came after Wu's entry on a seven-day immigration bail last week raised widespread concerns from rights groups and Hong Kongers living in the UK and the Chinese territory. AP

• DARK COMEDY, DYSTOPIAN VISION AND DOMESTIC DRAMA IN EQUAL MEASURE; FORMER BOOKER WINNERS MARLON JAMES, DOUGLAS STUART MAKE IT TO THE LONGLIST

Booker Prize 2026 longlist: 13 novels, three debut novelists and 10 first-time nominees

Aishwarya Khosla
New Delhi, July 28

THE BOOKER PRIZE 2026 longlist, announced Tuesday, brings together 13 novels that range from post-apocalyptic Kent to the ganglands of West Dublin, from an assisted-suicide clinic in Zurich to the barren hillsides of the Outer Hebrides. Two former winners Marlon James (2015 for *A Brief History of Seven Killings*) and Douglas Stuart (2020 for *Shuggie Bain*) — lead a field that includes three debut novelists and ten first-time nominees, representing seven countries across three continents.

Mary Beard, the Cambridge classicist, broadcaster, and author of the bestselling *SPQR: A History of Ancient Rome*, chairs the judging panel. A Fellow of Newnham College, Cambridge, and a familiar voice on BBC Radio 4's *In Our Time*, Beard is joined by poet Raymond Antrobus, musician Jarvis Cocker, journalist Rebecca Liu, and Booker-shortlisted novelist Patricia Lockwood. They selected from 163 submissions published in the UK or Ireland between October 2025 and September 2026.

James returns with *The Disappears*, his first non-fantasy novel since his 2015 win. Set in

late-1980s Kingston, the 600-page reckoning follows eight gay men rehearsing a play who become targets of a brutal homophobic mob attack. The judges called it "a book that examines territory Caribbean literature has rarely dared to occupy." Stuart offers John of John, following a young gay man, Cal, who returns to his childhood home on the Isle of Harris, caught between his devout father and his Glaswegian grandmother. The judges praised its "rich, textual density" and "excavation of family, violence, and shame." Elizabeth Strout earns her third Booker nomination with *The Things We Never Say*, exploring



Keeping tradition, 13 books have been longlisted for The Booker Prize. WUKI SUGIURA FOR BOOKER PRIZE FOUNDATION

post-pandemic isolation against the backdrop of the 2024 US election.

Chloe Aridjis's *The Shadow of the Object* follows a woman in Mexico who, after a dog bite,

befriends an elderly German woman and becomes entranced by a magic lantern show. Emma Cline's *Switzky* follows a Turkish exile who, with dementia as he journeys toward assisted death in Zurich, Makena Goodman's Helen of Nowhere is a "philosophically adventurous" tale of a disgraced professor offered a chance at a simpler life at a strange price, while M John Harrison's *The End of Everything* is a slyly satirical post-apocalyptic vision set on the Kent coast, where a beach-comber fishes out an inexplicable object from the sea.

Luke Kennard's *Black Bag* is a campus novel about an out-

of-work actor hired to sit zipped inside a bag during penitential lectures. Kenan Oshan's debut *The Renovation* follows a Turkish exile whose home renovation accidentally produces a prison cell connected to Istanbul. Rebecca Perry's debut *May We Feed the King* dances between the life of a medieval king and a museum curator in the present day. Gwendoline Riley's *The Palm House* portrays an enduring friendship against the precariousity of London life.

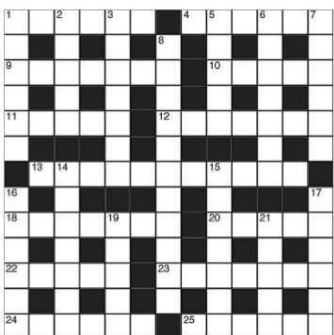
Djamel White's debut *All Them Dogs* is a gritty West Dublin gangland novel about a man drawn to a dangerous associate. Missouri Williams's *The Vivi-*

sectors is a darkly experimental campus novel set in a crumbling university city overtaken by vegetation.

Beard said the selection proves that "great books have never been written to a single formula," offering dark comedy, dystopian vision, and domestic drama in equal measure. Booker Foundation CEO Gaby Wood called the list one that "rewards risk" and showcases "the breadth of the six-book shortlist will be named on September 22 at London's Southbank Centre. The winner receives £50,000 (approx. \$2.5 lakh) on 9 November; shortlisted authors get £2,500 (approx. \$2.6 lakh) each.

CROSSWORD

6053



ACROSS

- 1 End call in audible difficulty (4,2)
4 Money sought by some scouts (6)
7 Tedious sort of broadcast (7)
10 Hybrid ape is brown (5)
11 The sound of Ouida's characters (5)
12 Strange men in obscure Scandinavian country (7)
13 Resolve support from your company? (4,7)
18 Jaguar strike not official (7)
20 Turn to her or someone else (5)
22 A newly married woman has no right to stay (5)
23 One who insists on facts is later confused (7)
24 A spot of publicity? (6)
25 Drunk takes bottle opener to bingo (6)

DOWN

- 1 Pipe for a sound rugby forward (6)
2 Made a record and was famous (5)
3 Not changing habits for example (7)
5 A clergyman lost his head for this crime (5)
6 Account for what is no longer clear (7)
7 One is going to make them (6)
8 Service chiefs? (4,7)
14 I'll leave things behind with hostility (3,4)
15 A professor of infinite wisdom (4-3)
16 Pinches a sort of square set askew (6)
17 Got right in to a cavern (6)
19 They man ships on a voyage reportedly (5)
21 Part of flag one shot to pieces (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6052 ACROSS: 1 Cashier, 5 Shout, 8 Guardian angel, 9 Rodeo, 10 Offence, 11 Parish, 12 Access, 15 Strolls, 17 Ruins, 19 Insubordinate, 20 Easel, 21 Treason DOWN: 1 Cigar, 2 Standard roses, 3 Indoors, 4 Reason, 5 Scarf, 6 Organ recitals, 7 Tellers, 11 Pastime, 13 Carmine, 14 Spirit, 16 Libel, 18 Stern

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Drama is life with the _____ cut out. - Alfred Hitchcock (4,4)

QUIBS



ABOLT



DIQILU



EILBBD



SOLUTIONS: Drama is life with the **doublets** cut out. - Alfred Hitchcock

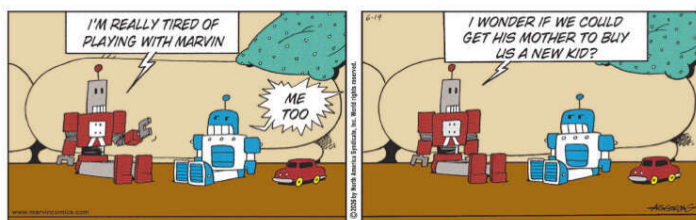
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SUDOKU6394



SOLUTIONSUDOKU6393

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Sonu Kumar @ Kaliya, S/o Seeta Ram Mehto R/o E-587, JJ Colony Bawana, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.306/23 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Bawana, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Sonu Kumar @ Kaliya cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sonu Kumar @ Kaliya has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Sonu Kumar @ Kaliya of FIR No.306/23 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Bawana, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 14.10.2026.

By order
Ms. Bharti Benival
Judicial Magistrate First Class, Room No.114
North District, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/10323/ON/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Rohit Singal prop. of M/s Cross Roads at B-98, sec. 50, Noida, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CC No. 1488/17 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Rohit Singal cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Rohit Singal has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Rohit Singal in CC No. 1488/17 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 29.08.2026.

By order
Sh. Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class
North East District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/7956NE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 CrPc)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Moin Khan S/o Late Sameer R/o H.No I-1549, Jahangirpuri, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 365/2018, U/S 302/34 IPC, PS Mahendra Park, North-West Distt., Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Moin Khan cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Moin Khan has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that Moin Khan the said accused of FIR No. 365/2018, U/S 302/34 IPC, PS Mahendra Park, North-West Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 28.09.2026.

By Order
Ms. Vandana
Additional Sessions Judge-02, (North)
Room No.-202, 2nd Floor,
District Courts Rohini, Delhi

DP/10192/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED

(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001:2002 Certified Company)

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT) on e-procurement

The APTRANSCO invites online bids for Spec No. CTO-SAMAST/2026 for 'Implementation of the project 'Scheduling, Accounting, Metering and Settlement of Transactions in Electricity (SAMSAT)' in APTRANSCO in the state of Andhra Pradesh'. The tender document can be downloaded from website <http://tender.approcurement.gov.in> from 16:00 hrs on Dt: 29.07.2026. Contact No.: 8333992956, 9000243223.

R.O.No: GMD/APTRANSCO/0926-27 Sd/- Chief Engineer/Transmission

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

Section 82 (ii) Cr.Pc.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person Namely Gulshan Narula S/o Roop Chand R/o B-82, Fateh Nagar, Delhi have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under FIR No.552/2018 U/S 379 IPC & 3 PDPP Act, has been registered at P.S.Hari Nagar, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said, Gulshan Narula cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, Namely Gulshan Narula has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, Namely Gulshan Narula of under has been under FIR No.552/2018 U/s 379 IPC & PDPP Act, registered at P.S. Hari Nagar, New Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 01.09.2026.

By Order
Mokha Bains, JMFC-II,
West, Room No.31,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/10297/WD/2026

Court notice

GOVERNMENT OF CHHATTISGARH, WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

WATER RESOURCES DIVISION KOTA

DISTT.-BILASPUR (C.G.)

e-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE

(FIRST CALL)

System Tender No. 196029 NIT No: 06/SAC/2026-27, Dated: 24-07-2026

Online Tenders are invited for the following works up to 14-08-2026 at 17:30 Hour

Name of work: CONSTRUCTION OF NIRTU ANICUT SCHEME IN TAKHATPUR BLOCK OF BILASPUR DISTRICT.

Probable Amount of Contract: Rs. 2590.81 Lakhs

(Estimated cost of tender based on S.O.R. dated 01-05-2025 & Amendment date 08-08-2025)

The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh Integrated e-Procurement Portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) from Date 31-07-2026 at 17:31 Hours, (IST) onwards.

NOTE: (1) All eligible/invested contractors/bidders are mandated to get enrolled on the Integrated e-procurement portal (<https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>) and get approval on specific vendor class from PWD under Centralized Contractor/Supplier Registration in order to download the tender documents and participate in the subsequent bidding process.

Other terms and condition of this tender visit WRD website <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> under Live Tender available.

(2) Estimated cost of tender based on S.O.R. dated 01-05-2025. (Revised 08-08-2025)

(3) The Tenderer has to exclude GST in his financial proposal.

Sd/-
EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

WATER RESOURCES DIVISION KOTA

DISTT.-BILASPUR (C.G.)

No.-26270237/16

New Delhi

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Due to the full moon energy, you also might feel at odds with a romantic partner, a friend, a group member or your kids. This will be gone in about a day or so. Tonight: Friendships.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today you might be pulled between the demands of home and family versus the demands of your career, your job or your responsibilities to society. Tonight: You're admired.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Pay attention to everything you say and do because this is a mildly accident-prone day due to the full moon. Take a moment before you act or say something that you might later regret. Be aware of your surroundings. Tonight: Explore and learn.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You're never casual about money. The full moon might create confusion, tension or disputes between your wealth versus what somebody else claims or wants. This includes debt and discussions about inheritances. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today the only full moon opposite your sign all year is taking place, which could create tension between you and those closest to you. Don't make a big deal about anything. Tonight: Be cooperative.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Be patient with co-workers and with those who might be involved in health procedures, today. You might need more patience than usual if dealing with a pet due to today's full moon. Tonight: Get better organised.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a dicey day for social occasions, the arts, friendships and especially romance. On the upside, you might see things that you never realised before. You might have increased clarity about something, especially a relationship. Tonight: Socialise with someone.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Today you might feel like you're caught in a tug-of-war between trying to please the demands of home and family versus dealing with your career and your outer world. You can't please both. For this particular full moon, you can't ignore your career and your responsibilities to society. Tonight: Relax.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): The energy of today's full moon can be an accident-prone influence on your sign. Be alert. Pay attention to everything you say and do. Keep your eyes open. This applies to driving, jogging, walking and talking! Tonight: Share your thoughts.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Financial issues might come to a head today. This might concern your debt or how you're handling your money and possessions. It also might relate to shared property or something that someone else owns. Tonight: Maintain your belongings.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today the full moon is in your sign, which is why you might feel tension dealing with those who are closest to you. Something you've been working on might be completed. Tonight: You're strong.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Relations with co-workers might be strained today because of the energy of the full moon. However, it's also possible that you will have wrapped up some old business and you feel good about it. Meanwhile, increased chaos and busyness at home continue. Tonight: Enjoy solitude.

AUCTION NOTICE

Auction of metal & misc. scrap will take place on

04th Aug. 2026 at Govt. ITI Nuh, Haryana. For

more details, please contact the Principal's office

on Mob. 9306225235.

No. 47584/HRY Principal, GITI Nuh

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person Chirag Kapoor Director/Auth. Sign/ Prop. of C.S. Consultants Office Surya Shopping Arcade, At: S.C.O.-5, 2nd Floor, Ghumar Mandi, National Road, Ludhiana, Punjab-141001, Also at: S.C.O.-16, 1st Floor, Surya Shopping Arcade, Ghumar Mandi, Ludhiana, Punjab-141001, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CC NI Act No. 142/2021, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Mukherji Nagar, North-West Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 22.09.2026.

Proclamation is hereby made that Chirag Kapoor Director/Auth. Sign/ Prop. of C.S. Consultants Office Surya Shopping Arcade, the said accused of CC NI Act No. 142/2021, U/S 138 NI Act, PS Mukherji Nagar, North-West Distt., Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 22.09.2026.

By Order
Sh. Aakash Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, North
Room No. 213, 2nd Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/10254/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

कार्यालय मार्केट कमेटी गोहाना

---: निविदाएं:---

सर्वसाधारण को सूचित किया जाता है कि मार्केट कमेटी गोहाना

दिनांक 01.09.2026 से 31.08.2027 तक अनाज मंडी गोहाना च

सज्जी मंडी गोहाना (i.e. Roads, Common Platforms,

Individual Platform, Covered Sheds, Parking

area, Cleaning of Toilets, Urinals, Water Cooler

Room and other area of Mandi etc), खरीद फेंद बरीदा,

कयूर, बिचपड़ी, रूखी, बैसवाल कलां, कांसाई, सबयाई खानपुर

कलां च मुण्डलाना (Seasonal) तथा कार्यालय परिसर की साफ

सजाई का कार्य ऑनलाइन टेंडर के माध्यम से दिया जाना है।

इच्छुक फर्म/एजेंसी सोसाइटी द्वारा मुं 2,00,000/- रुपये या सरकार

द्वारा निर्धारित (Refundable) की EMD राशि ऑनलाइन

(डिबिट कार्ड नेटबैंकिंग) के माध्यम से टेंडर फार्म के साथ दिनांक

11.08.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे से पूर्व जमा करवानी होगी।

टेंडर को कीमत मुं 2,000/- रुपए और सर्विस चार्ज मुं 1,180/-

(Non Refundable) भी ऑनलाइन जमा करवानी होगी। ऑनलाइन

निविदा दिनांक 12.08.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे कार्यकारी

अभिन्ना हस्ताक्षरित बोर्ड, सोनीपत कार्यालय में खोली जायेगी।

अन्य शर्तों की जानकारी चारे किसी भी कार्यविधि में कार्यालय

मार्केट कमेटी से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।

ऑनलाइन निविदाएं <http://etenders.hry.nic.in> पर

उपलब्ध होगी।

सचिव एवं कार्यकारी अधिकारी अग्रह

मार्केट कमेटी गोहाना मार्केट कमेटी गोहाना

No. 47581/HR

New Delhi

DAY 3 results

	Country	G	S	B	Total
1	AUS	29	13	21	63
2	ENG	10	17	12	39
3	CAN	10	8	10	28
4	SCO	7	4	3	14
5	NIG	6	4	0	10
6	IND	2	5	3	10

*TLL 28/07, 11:45 PM

WEIGHTLIFTING

Women's 63 kg: Debutant Nirupama Devi endured a forgettable campaign, managing just one successful lift from six attempts as she failed to register a total in women's 63kg weightlifting event.

Athletics

Men's 110m hurdles: Tejas Shire's historic appearance in the Commonwealth Games men's 110m hurdles final ended in pain and heartbreak, but demonstrated his grit as he ran the race with a stress fracture in his left foot to finish eighth and last.



INDIA watch

ATHLETICS

Men's shot put qualifying:

Tajinderpal Singh Toor (Group A), Samardeep Singh Gill (Group B) 3:35 pm

Men's 200m Round 1:

Animesh Kujur 4:02 pm

Men's long jump final (medal event): Murali Sureshankar, Lokesh Sathyanathan 11:54 pm

Men's 400m hurdles Round 1:

Yashas Palaksha (Heat 1), Santhosh Tamilanarasi (Heat 2) 12:03 am (Thursday)

Women's shot put final (medal event): Manpreet Kaur 12:31 am (Thursday)

Women's 3000m

steplechase final: Parul Chaudhary 2:05 am

(Thursday)

BOXING

Women's 51kg quarterfinal:

Sakshi Chaudhary vs Caitlin Fryers (Northern Ireland)

4:45 pm Women's 70kg

quarterfinal: Anuradhi Choudhary vs Morgan Henderson (New Zealand)

5:30 pm Men's 60kg

quarterfinal: Sachin Siwach vs Treasure Moremi (Botswana) 6:15 pm

Men's 80kg quarterfinal:

Ankush Panghal vs Jade Micock (Seychelles) 7 pm

Men's 90kg quarterfinal:

Narender Bernal vs Michael Seko (Samoa) 7:30 pm

Women's 57kg quarterfinal:

Jaimine Lamboira vs Elise Glynn (England) 11 pm

SWIMMING

Men's 200m freestyle

heats: Sajjan Prakash (Heat 4), Anesh Koskar (Heat 5)

3:12 pm Men's 1500m

freestyle fastest heat: Aryan Nehra 1:14 am (Thursday)

WEIGHTLIFTING

Women's 77kg final (medal event): Sanjana 2 pm

Kushare soars to silver: 'Had setbacks but believed in myself'

31-year-old clears 2.25 metres with last edition's bronze medallist Tejaswin Shankar advising him

British Raj

New Delhi, July 28

WHEN HIGH jumper Sarvesh Kushare cleared 2.25 metres after two failed attempts to confirm a silver medal in the men's high jump, emotions were high at different locations around the world.

Thousands of kilometres away in Devargao, Nashik, the Kushare family felt a sense of relief, while in Spala, Poland, his coach Jithin Thomas, who couldn't travel to Glasgow, was overjoyed.

Sarvesh shed a few tears of joy. Sarvesh won the first major medal of his career and upgraded Tejaswin Shankar's bronze medal in the high jump from the last edition to silver. He failed to clear 2.28m, but he had sealed the second place.

Jamaica's Romaine Beckford also failed to clear the 2.28m mark but won the gold medal based on the countback.

"We couldn't eat properly today. Once the event started, all of us were hoping that he stays till the end," his father Anil Kushare told *The Indian Express*. "When he missed the first jump at 2.25m, his mother started praying and I was restless. But then, he cleared it in the third attempt and we all breathed easily," Anil said.

Usually calm, Sarvesh broke down while talking to the media later. That is how much this medal meant to him.

That moment meant a lot to him because it was the result of months of hard work. He had setbacks but believed in himself. When I cleared 2.25m, all those emotions came out at once. I wasn't thinking about the result, just relieved, happy, and grateful that all the effort had finally paid off. It's a moment I'll always remember."



Sarvesh Kushare won his first multi-sport event medal on Tuesday when he picked up a silver at the Commonwealth Games. PTI



Tejaswin Shankar discussing the high jump event with Sarvesh Kushare in Glasgow on Tuesday. SCREENGRAB

Sarvesh told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow. Sarvesh has been performing admirably since last year, including a top 6 finish at 2025 World Championships, setting a national record last month at the age of 31.

He has never won a multi-sporting event medal before. Winning at the Common-

"I had setbacks but believed in myself. When I cleared 2.25m, all those emotions came out at once. I wasn't thinking about the result, just relieved, happy, and grateful that all the effort had finally paid off."

SARVESH KUSHARE

ON WINNING THE CWG SILVER

wealth Games is like validation for everything that he has done right in the last four years. He was more emotional because it's a once-in-a-four-year chance," his coach Jithin said.

Meanwhile, his family in Nashik got emotional looking at Sarvesh crying. "I can understand the tears. He is a

calm guy usually, but those tears were a reflection of our dreams being fulfilled," his father Anil said.

Team work

Sarvesh arrived in Glasgow as medal favourite and had compatriots Tejaswin Shankar and Aadarsh Rao to compete alongside. Though high jump is an individual event, Sarvesh's final in Glasgow felt like a team effort.

Tejaswin, who retired because of Acute Patellar Tendinitis, stayed near the high jump pit, advising both Sarvesh and Aadarsh throughout the competition. Coach Jithin, who couldn't travel to Glasgow, said the presence of Tejaswin was a boost for Sarvesh. "I wasn't there, but Tejaswin's constant presence and his advice really helped Sarvesh. I think it just showed how much both of these guys value each other," Jithin said.

After every jump, Sarvesh would trudge back to the

player's bench where Tejaswin was sitting to dissect every jump with him.

After the two failures at 2.25m, Tejaswin suggested to Sarvesh to skip and try 2.28m. "I told him that you can go to 2.28m now but Sarvesh said that if I clear 2.25m, then I get three more chances at 2.28m. So, he took that call and delivered. It was a surreal experience to witness the moment so close," Tejaswin later told NNIS Sports. For Sarvesh, having Tejaswin by side meant that he had someone who he trusts.

"Tejaswin and I have a great friendship, and having someone you trust beside you during such an important competition gives you confidence," he said. "We always push each other to perform better, and his support throughout the competition meant a lot. Moments like these are even more special when you can share them with a close friend and teammate."

Preeti, Priya enter semis, assure India of 2 boxing medals

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

PREETI PAWAR became the second Indian boxer at the 2026 Commonwealth Games to ensure a boxing bronze medal was coming back home with her after Lovlina Borgohain was handed bytes by the way to the semifinals of her event. Pawar, India's entrant from its most contested weight category, dispatched Northern Ireland's Nicole Clyde to enter the semifinals and assure herself of at least a bronze medal. Later in the evening, Priya Ghanghas beat Scotland's Niamh Mitchell 4-1 to also book a semifinal berth.

The story of the bout was a punch of beauty. Operating as a southpaw, Pawar has the usual left-handed shots that most Indians possess. But she often finishes exchanges with a right uppercut of sorts. The power of the shot comes from the back, and the right hand rolls from the ground up. Opponents expecting angles from varying degrees of lefties get blindsided when the right lands flush. The shot is exquisite not just for its craftiness, but also because of how Preeti uses it. In the first round, Preeti used it to gain points.

She could have loaded up on the power factor and tried to hit the shot harder. But instead Pre-



Preeti Pawar. PTI

eti chose to use it to end combinations and landed it multiple times in the first. Her opponent made no adjustments to counter it, and the Northern Ireland coaching corner offered no

advice or solutions as well. Soon the referee gave a standing count to Clyde, who looked at her corner and quizzed why she was reprimanded. Every judge gave the round to the boxer from Bhiwani, as was the expected result.

With several traditional boxing nations absent, India's women's boxers have a significant opportunity to add to the medal tally. The women's contingent in particular has the opportunity to bump up the medal count. Pawar has the chance to go deep and even fight for gold.

Perhaps future bouts were in mind when she slowed

down for the second and third rounds. The volume of that right uppercut reduced, but Preeti's offense still found its mark when used. Clyde landed her shots too, but the volume of clean hits was visibly higher on the Indian's count, and the judges gave her a unanimous decision in the end.

Right after Preeti's bout, Priya Ghanghas ensured another medal for India, beating home favourite Niamh Mitchell 4-1 after losing the opening round before roaring back with sustained pressure and heavier punches to seal her semifinal place.

Ajaya glad to emulate dad's CWG medal, but still hungry for gold



Ajaya Babu (L) won the silver medal at the Commonwealth Games on Tuesday. His father had won bronze at the 2010 New Delhi edition. PTI

Tanishq Vaddi

Hyderabad, July 28

SIXTEEN YEARS back, Valluri Srinivasa Rao had bagged a men's 56kg bronze medal at the Delhi Commonwealth Games (CWG). By striking silver in Glasgow, Rao's son Ajaya Babu has again put Vizianagaram district's Kondavelagada village on the weightlifting map.

Ajaya lifted a total of 330kg (149kg snatch + 181kg clean and jerk) in the 79kg category, falling one kilogram short of Malaysia's Erry Hidayat Muhammad. Rao was happy with his son's feat but Ajaya, while sharing his father's enthusiasm, kept repeating in his conversation with *The Indian Express*, "I did not make a few mistakes, I could have won gold."

Right from the qualification rounds earlier this year, Rao was confident that Ajaya would deliver a medal based on how well he was performing. "I wanted him to go into badminton," laughed Rao. "Pullela Gopichand and I met during an event where he asked me, 'What do you think of your son taking up badminton?' but Ajaya was resolute; he wanted to take up weightlifting."

The 21-year-old has had his reasons. He was determined to keep the weightlifting tradition intact in his family and the village. "I was about six years old when I was watching my father win a medal on TV in Kondavelagada. I did not understand everything then, but I saw neighbours coming to our home to congratulate him; the media started coming, and they showed my father being congratulated by the chief minister of the state. Our financial status improved significantly after that win," said Ajaya.

The young boy slowly gravitated towards weightlifting. Then came CWG 2014 in Glasgow. Rao wanted to better his bronze and go for gold. However, destiny had different plans as Rao could not even qualify.

"He was heartbroken for the longest time. He felt he had incomplete business because he couldn't qualify, and at that moment I took it upon myself to fulfil my father's desire," said Ajaya.

Revival of legacy

Once Ajaya decided to take up weightlifting, Rao was "proud," and slowly started mentoring his son. "It became a dining table conversation. At breakfast, lunch and dinner, all we did was discuss improving

his game, preparations for different tournaments and how to approach things."

"There were some competitions which I missed in my career for some reason or the other, but I wanted Ajaya to participate in them to get exposure," Rao added.

In addition to continuing his father's legacy, picking weightlifting brought challenges. The region's older guard, who had won national and international medals, began to fade. This required the new generation to start delivering medals to re-establish their pride and continue to keep the next generation of weightlifters hungry, and Ajaya was quite aware of this.

Usually I am quite confident, someone who does not take a lot of pressure... my father never said I should win medals, but only recently, before CWG, my uncle started emphasising a little more about my father's legacy and why my winning a medal is a matter of pride. That's when I got a bit fired up," Ajaya said.

However, Rao prefers the cool and composed version of Ajaya. "Technically, he is stronger than me, quicker than me, but his ability to be composed under pressure is too good. When I played, I used to get tense," he said. "I always drilled in him during our meal conversations, you might have a stronger or bigger opponent, but if you trust your practice, you will always win, and that mindset keeps him cool," said Rao.

Wary of doping

"Even today, whether he is in Glasgow, Pattiala or Kondavelagada, I meticulously ask about all the technical aspects of his game, what sort of training he did, whether he sustained any injuries, and what food he is having," Rao said. Although the basics of weightlifting ingrained by Rao played their part, the 21-year-old said the actual game-changer was the supplements his father suggested. "I am very particular when it comes to even the water that Ajaya drinks. I have seen through my playing career how easily players test positive for doping... I have seen this happen in the careers of many athletes; sometimes, bad people with ill-intent who dislike a particular weightlifter mix a banned substance in their water, cold drink or food without their knowledge, spoiling a career as a result. I wanted to be extremely careful of such things with Ajaya," said Rao.

Denied CWG chance, paddlers turn to revived Commonwealth Championships

Bhuvan Gupta

New Delhi, July 28

AS A truncated Indian contingent vies for glory in Glasgow, India's table tennis players look on ruefully.

The sport is one of nine disciplines, omitted from the 2026 Commonwealth Games (CWG) roster, and has historically enjoyed rich medal hauls at this event - a rarity for it at comparable or larger-scale competitions.

To assuage that disappointment, the Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships have been revived at Delhi's Thyagaraj Stadium alongside the CWG. Six out of the eight editions have been in India, with the previous one held in Cuttack in 2019.

The fact that Commonwealth TT's chairperson (Vivek Kohli), president (Dushyant Chautala) and secretary general (Mahinder Pal Singh) are all Indians might have something

to do with that.

The response so far has been lukewarm despite free entry. The Delhi government organised an elaborate opening ceremony, but the crowd mostly comprised school students on mandated excursions and thinned soon after. Matches are being watched by a smattering of students and tournament officials, much like the 2013 edition in the capital.

Filling the gap

Hours after facing off in the UTT final in Goa, Manush Shah and Syndrela Das donated India trackuits in Delhi. Quadri Aruna, the Grand Old Man of Nigerian TT who was not part of the UTT roster this season, made the same Goa-Delhi trip.

Manush and Syndrela were not needed for the ties against Zimbabwe and Maldives respectively, which were both wrapped up in less than an hour. Manav Thakkar, Harmeet Desai and Payas Jain



The Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships was revived in Delhi after the sport found itself out of the Glasgow Games. EXPRESS

sped to straight-game wins, and so did Sutirtha Mukherjee, Yashaswini Ghorpade and Swastika Ghosh.

But the men got an early reality check from Malaysia, suffering a shock 1-3 defeat in the evening tie. Manav, Manush, and Harmeet each

lost a match to opponents ranked outside the world's top 200, and though the result may not affect the hosts' progress to the medal rounds, they would now be wary of complacency as the top seeds. The same could hold for the second-seeded Indian women, as they



"When it was announced, everyone was really, really sad. Table tennis in Commonwealth Games has always been very close to the heart. It has been a stepping stone to where we are now"

G SATHIYAN,

INDIAN TABLE TENNIS PLAYER.

saw the top-billed Singapore surviving a scare before ending

Sri Lanka 3-2.

The preliminary group stage, featuring 21 men's and 16 women's teams, will be followed by a second phase where the top two teams from each of the four groups will advance. The group leaders will enter the semi-finals, while the rest will play classification rounds for places. This format ensures each country plays at least six ties, underscoring the goal of international exposure over an elite knockout system.

Singles world No. 40 Manush has not yet been a part of CWG for India, and he was looking forward to doing that. His senior teammate G Sathiyana was also "very disheartened" with the news. "When it was announced, everyone was really, really sad. Table tennis in Commonwealth Games has always been very close to the heart. It has been a stepping stone to where we are now," Sathiyana said.

It all started at CWG, the 33-

year-old added. "Winning those medals led to the next Asian Games success. Now we're aiming at the Olympic Games and the world level."

Achanta Sharath Kamal, India's leading CWG medal-winner, similarly felt the players were deprived of a big opportunity. "When you bag those medals, you get a lot of confidence, you get the right recognition. It's tougher to win medals at the Asian Games in TT," Sharath told *The Indian Express*.

With Manav and Manush rising to number two in men's doubles and several women paddlers also shining, the Khel Ratna awardee said the Commonwealth Games "would have helped us build that boost, as it did in 2018."

Nevertheless, it was a situation beyond anyone's control, Sharath acknowledged, as the hosting rights changed from Melbourne to Glasgow with only 10 of 19 sports included.

On the positive front, playing in front of a home crowd could help build the momentum for the Asian Games. "Winning is a good habit to build, and at the Commonwealth Championships, you have the possibility to do that," Sharath said.

"For all the players, it will be a good hunting ground. They can continue to prepare and do well, which will also give them confidence for the Asian Games."

Sathiyana felt that the Championships happening at the same time as CWG was apt. "To have the same team which is going to be there at the Asian Games is good. We'll have great team bonding, team spirit. We'll be participating in multiple events as well. So it's good preparation for the Asian Games."

Until TT is guaranteed a return to the Games at Ahmedabad 2030, Indian paddlers will have to make do with the Championships.

Geneva to host
Gukesh-Sindarov
title contest

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 28

THE 2026 World Chess Championship between reigning world champion Gukesh D and challenger Javokhir Sindarov will be held in Geneva, Switzerland, from November 25 to December 15, the world chess governing body FIDE confirmed on Tuesday.

Both players will be 20 years old when the event begins, making it the youngest World Chess Championship contest in history. Gukesh, the grandmaster from Chennai, will defend the crown he won in Singapore in December 2024. He defeated China's Ding Liren in the 14th and final classical game to become the 18th world champion and the youngest player ever to hold the title.

Sindarov earned his shot at the crown by winning the FIDE Candidates Tournament in Cyprus. The Uzbek grandmaster secured first place with a round to spare, adding to his victory at the 2025 FIDE World Cup. The championship will consist of 14 classical games.

The first player to score 7½ points will be declared the winner, with no further games played once that score is reached. If the scores are tied after 14 games, the champion will be decided through tie-breaks. FIDE said further details on match regulations, schedule, tickets, spectator access, media accreditation and any prize events will be announced in due course.

FIDE interim president Viswanathan Anand welcomed the announcement: "Several countries expressed strong interest in hosting the match, including India, the United States, and Cyprus. After carefully considering all proposals, FIDE decided to stage the match on neutral soil and bring it to Geneva, a city with a historic tradition of bringing nations and cultures together."

Infantino's plans to form a commercial subsidiary, which would be called FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE), running commercial activities like the World Cup and Club World Cup are first reported by The Times of London. FIFA said in a statement FFE would raise up to \$4.2 billion later this year to help fund development programs "based on an initial equity valuation of \$20 billion by carefully selecting long-term investors who will purchase minority, non-controlling interests."

FIFA is working with J.P. Morgan while intended investors include Thrive Eternal launched by Joshua Kushner, whose brother Jared Kushner is a son-in-law of U.S. President Donald Trump.

FIFA plans for Kushner-backed \$20 billion operation to run WC

Associated Press
Geneva, July 28

FIFA PRESIDENT Gianni Infantino's plan to create a \$20 billion company running the World Cup with private investors including the Kushner family was announced Tuesday — and immediately attacked by European soccer body UEFA. "It is not FIFA's to sell," UEFA said in a statement. "None of us are the owners of football."

Infantino's plans to form a commercial subsidiary, which would be called FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE), running commercial activities like the World Cup and Club World Cup are first reported by The Times of London. FIFA said in a statement FFE would raise up to \$4.2 billion later this year to help fund development programs "based on an initial equity valuation of \$20 billion by carefully selecting long-term investors who will purchase minority, non-controlling interests."

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Zidane achieves his 'dream' as he takes charge of the France team

Associated Press
Paris, July 28

MOMENTS AFTER being announced as France's new coach on Tuesday, Zinedine Zidane clenched his fists and his usually measured voice trembled a little. "I'm excited," he said.

"The France team makes you dream. We have extraordinary players, an extraordinary team." Zidane coached Real Madrid until leaving in 2021. He replaces Didier Deschamps at the helm of France team he led to glory as arguably its greatest ever player.

OLD-SCHOOL SUCCESS STORY

First-Class effort bears fruit for spinner Saransh

Lalith Kalidas
New Delhi, July 28

ONLY WEEKS after he put on the Ranji Trophy whites for Madhya Pradesh for the first time in the winter of 2014, Saransh Jain's cricket career took on a new purpose. On Tuesday, the goal attained fulfilment — a maiden India Test call-up realising his ailing father's dream.

Subodh Jain could not talk to his son when he returned from a tour to Australia with an India call shortly after his First-Class debut 12 years ago. A former MP Ranji Trophy off-spinner himself, Subodh was diagnosed with mouth cancer.

He had taught Saransh the craft. Now he found another way to lend him the spark to guide him through the unforgiving, often brutal, journey of a First-Class cricketer. A message on a piece of paper would share all there was to be told to revive a shattered Saransh's spirits.

"I could not speak because of my condition after surgery back then. I wrote to him on a paper that if he started performing better, I would recover sooner," Subodh tells *The Indian Express*.

Saransh has gone through a relentless grind over the last decade to emerge as an old-school success story. He has taken the longer route to earn an India shirt these days, fuelled almost entirely by red-ball cricket.

The Indore-born spinner's selection for the forthcoming Sri Lanka tour gives hope to the many triers and hopefuls lacking lucrative IPL deals.

Saransh is only the third man after Murali Vijay (2008) and Mohammad Shami (2013)



Saransh Jain learned the craft from his father, a spinner himself. **PHOTO BY ANAND K. SINGH**

to make the India squad before securing an IPL contract. At 33, he is also the oldest to receive his maiden India call-up this century.

Age isn't a deterrent in his case, but a measure of his sustained efforts. Saransh has spent years waiting. On the bench, away from squads, as an understudy or prospect, behind one big name or the other. Former MP coach Harvinder Sodhi recounts Saransh's five-wicket haul on debut in Chennai. That wasn't enough to overcome the steep competition.

He was jostling for room behind Lalaj Saxena, arguably the best off-spinner of his generation to miss an India cap, with Ashwin comfortably dominating the Test set-up.

"Jalaj was the main bowler for us at that time. Saransh couldn't crack through the first few years. He was a standout performer in all age-group divisions. He worked hard and even became a Ranji champion with consistent performances in the last five years," Sodhi, now part of the national junior

selection committee, told *The Indian Express*.

Saransh persisted, even though being 12 and 10, he played just eight Ranji games, collecting 11 wickets.

The Pandit effect

But when the domestic pool of specialist off-spinners began to thin, Saransh's consistency became harder to ignore. The arrival of Chandrakant Pandit as MP's head coach in 2020 was a catalyst.

"Chandu sir ne hi usko sikhaaya hai aur mauka bhi diya hai. (Pandit had given Saransh direction and opportunities to take flight), says Subodh.

Others couldn't gauge a Test-level cricketer in him but Pandit was impressed by his primary skill-set. "He was nowhere near being a regular when I took over, playing one or two games a year. When I saw his genuine ability, I decided to push him. I even dropped a senior guy for him," the former India wicketkeeper said.

Saransh's consistent lines and high-arm action attracted his attention. Pandit ap-

proached the tall off-spinner with an unusual tweak that would bolster his wicket-taking abilities.

"Not often do we notice an off-spinner starting spells bowling from round the wicket. That is a skill he has developed. I convinced him after showing him his own videos that he could be more effective from round the wicket."

"This is his strength — not only bowling from round the stumps but also bowling that line," says Pandit.

He cites the thin channel between the off and middle-stump that Saransh targets, testing batters on both edges. The transformation has rewarded him with greater re-

turns and theatre, like when he castled a well-set Prithvi Shaw and trapped Sarfaraz Khan leg-before from around the stumps in the 2024 Irani Cup.

An injury to Washington Sundar meant Saransh was next in line in India's diminishing spin pool after two solid years. He has clocked 122 of his 188 career First-Class wickets since 2024, while scoring over 1,500 runs with two centuries in this period. His claim as a back-up option was strengthened further with an unbeaten 70 and six wickets against Sri Lanka A earlier this month, that too at Galle, the venue of India's first Test in three weeks.

"He is a genuine off-spinner, not a batsman who can bowl. The first I've seen in the Indian set-up since Ashwin," says Pandit.

A simple handwritten note from his father had lit the spark 12 years ago. Saransh stayed the course until First-Class cricket finally won him an India call-up.

Two assistant coaches leave Team India with Sri Lanka tour around the corner

Express News Service
Chennai, July 28

FOR THE second time in Gautam Gambhir's tenure, there will be changes in the back-room staff with assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate and fielding coach T Dilip ending their involvement with the team. BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia confirmed that the contracts of the two haven't been renewed and a process is underway to name their replacements ahead of next month's Sri Lanka tour.

Ten Doeschate, who had been with the Indian team since Gambhir's tenure began in mid-2024, had already communicated his decision to move on.

"Ryan and Dilip's contracts have ended and we are not extending them," Saikia told *The Indian Express*. "Dilip was already on a one-year extension, which ended on June 8, and Ryan's ended on June 10. In another two-three days, we will name their replacements," the secretary added.

While Ten Doeschate had the option of seeking an extension like bowling coach Morne Morkel, it is understood that the former Netherlands captain was keen on exploring opportunities on the franchise circuit. It is learnt that Ten Doeschate is likely to join IPL franchise Kolkata Knight Riders, whom he first represented as a player, winning two titles, before being part of the support staff when they won it in 2024 with Gambhir as mentor.

Soon after that tournament when Gambhir was appointed India head coach, Ten Doeschate was roped in alongside Morkel. Having relied on local coaches under Ravi Shastri and Rahul Dravid, India had two overseas support staff for the first time



Ryan ten Doeschate and T Dilip's contracts haven't been renewed. **PHOTO BY ANAND K. SINGH**

since Duncan Fletcher's tenure almost a decade ago.

While there is uncertainty around Morkel's future, it is understood the former South Africa pacer has been given an extension. With the next big ICC event, the 50-over World Cup in southern Africa, India believe Morkel's experience and expertise will be needed.

In Gambhir's two-year tenure so far, his support staff has witnessed a couple of big changes. At the end of the 2024/25 Border-Gavaskar Trophy, India parted ways with assistant coach Abhishek Nayyar, with Sitanshu Kotak coming in as replacement.

Dissatisfied

Though Ten Doeschate's official designation has been that of assistant coach, he has largely been working with the batting group alongside Kotak, and also on the fielding. Within the team, he had been seen as a reliable sounding board for players, who had no hesitation in opening up to him in difficult situations. But given the dwindling performances of the batting group across conditions, questions had been raised about Ten Doeschate's role and what he offered to the set-up.

With regards to Dilip, his future had been in doubt as the fielding continued to remain a

worry for India across formats. When Dravid's tenure ended, Dilip was also relieved of his duties initially, only for the board to make a last-minute U-turn and add him to Gambhir's support staff.

In place of Dilip, the BCCI is understood to be looking at former Assam player Subhadip Ghosh as a fielding coach. Stationed at the Centre of Excellence, Ghosh has been part of the system, working with India A, Under-19 as well as the India women's team at different times. At present, apart from Gambhir, India's support staff includes Kotak, Morkel, Sairaj Bahutle (spin-bowling coach) and Hari Prasad Mohan (analyst).

India are set to leave for Sri Lanka on August 4, where they are scheduled to play two Tests that are crucial in terms of qualifying for the World Test Championship final.

Since losing the home series to South Africa last October-November, India have played only one Test against Afghanistan in June. Given the importance of the series, they will head to Sri Lanka 10 days before the first Test in Galle on August 15. Apart from having a short camp, India are likely to face Sri Lanka A in a three-day warm-up fixture in Colombo before heading further down south for the series opener.

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New Delhi